Preface

AD455

Artorius greeted Ambrosius warmly.

The atrium of the villa was massive, its domed roof and giant floor mosaic dwarfing the guests. Like all villas built in the prior century in Britain, it was a testament to its owner's wealth and power. After the chill autumn morning outside, the villa's hypocaust heating offered a warm sanctuary without visible means of heating.

Around the hall, the men and women stood in small groups, seeming lost in the giant atrium, greeting friends, comrades and acquaintances. Most of the aristocracy of Britain was here tonight, and all of the Council members. And, regardless of which sides they had taken in the various disputes of the past half-century, the recognized each other as the powers in this land.

At least, the powers that they officially recognized. Also in the room, and looking out of place in the midst of such grandeur and witchcraft were the Saxon barbarians who had come here to "protect" them and now were possibly the biggest existential threat to Britain since the Emperor Hadrianus had built his wall 300 years ago.

Ambrosius gently pulled Artorius to one side and started to whisper conspiratorially. "There's something in the air," he confided and looked at his bosom companion meaningfully. Artorius looked around the villa but saw nothing. "What?" he asked, but starting to feel that prick of uncertainty even as he tried to shake off the feeling that his friend had an instinct about such things. "Treachery," Ambrosius said, firmly. "I can smell it."

"Vortigern?" Artorius asked, naming their nominal leader, but who, on any given day, seemed more likely to side with the Saxons that with his own people.

"Maybe," admitted Ambrosius, "and maybe not. No, I feel my 'old friend' is on our side today."

"Not that we should have 'sides' on a day like today," interjected Artorius with a wry smile.

"That naive you are not, young Artorius," replied the other. "Hengest knows he won't be able to take Kent back by force of arms, so he has to beat us at the negotiating table. He will achieve here what he did 20 years ago."

Artorius looked over at the aging warrior and would-be King, with his flowing locks washed and arranged for the formal meeting. "Does he have another daughter to marry off, then? Which tribe does he want to depose for this one?"

Ambrosius remained unmoved. "Your wit will get you into a lot of trouble one day, old friend. I just hope it isn't today."

Vortigern called the meeting to order. Older now, he was visibly tired and worn from thirty years of struggling to hold this nation together. The meeting was to be held in Latin, the first language of many of the rich British nobles present in the room, and easily accessible to the other British. But Hengest, even after all this time, spoke only a little of the language and many of his underlings even less. Ceretic was there to translate and duly translated Vortigern's brief opening remarks into a flowery address for the benefit of his leaders.

"Let's get down to business," Ambrosius whispered to Artorius. "Then we can get on with the drinking."

"This war must stop," Vortigern declared. "You are here to defend this Republic from its enemies, and yet you have declared war on us."

Ceretic translated, waited for his master to consider this, respond, and then translated for the Britons waiting in the hall.

"My master says when you invited him here, you agree to pay him to defend you. But you do not pay. When you say you cannot pay, you agree to give Kentiworg to him as his possession and you marry his daughter make you brothers. How now say you that he has no rights in Kentiworg?"

"We are not saying he has no rights, in Kent or anywhere else. But when, as a Patron, he abuses the trust of his *free* citizens, he has to expect that those citizens will rise up in rebellion against him. He has the rights to the produce and wealth of Kent, not the right of Paterfamilias over them."

Again a pause as Ceretic and Hengest translated, and then the riposte: "But how my lord collects the rents of people in Kentiworg when he is once more locked in Ruoihm by actions of your men?"

"They are not *my men*; they are the free citizens of Kent, acting independently," retorted Vortigern. "Do you not know the law?"

Here and there in the hall, there was an intake of breath. Vortigern seemed to be disowning the actions of the Cives of Kent; disowning them in front of their own representatives in this hall. Disowning them, indeed, when his son had died this past winter past at the battle of Rutupiae. Could he, really?

Ambrosius turned to Artorius, significantly. Artorius turned to meet his gaze and whispered, "I thought you said it was not to be Vortigern selling us out this time."

"Indeed I did, although anybody can be wrong. But in this case, I think he is just telling it how he feels it. He wants peace, peace at any price and to go back to the way things used to be. If he could get Hengest to leave, he would, but there are prices he will not pay. But no, the man I'm watching is Osric. I don't trust him."

Osric was the Lord of the Keels of Norfolk, based at Venta Icenorum at the end of the Icknield Way. He was responsible for guarding all of the East Coast of Britain from his bases between the Thames Estuary and the river of Linnius. His responsibility was mainly seaborne, but since the crushing of the Picts twenty years before, and the fact that he welcomed in Saxons with open arms, he had little to do. Stuck in the flat boglands of the East, it was possible to do some farming, but where was the glory in that? He would rather be marching in full battle order down the Icknield Way and laying waste to Verulanium that coming down here to hold a peace conference that would do him no good.

Yes, Artorius thought, he would love to be Lord of Verulanium, or Linnius, or even Emperor of Britain. Ambrosius was right to be wary of him.

Artorius, of course, was not *Lord* of anywhere. A true Roman did not aspire to anything as crass as *ruling* over other people. Some things (why was the Army always the first thing that came into anybody's head) had to be provided by the people in concert, and obviously those things had to be paid for by "the people" and that meant that *somebody* had to be in charge of collecting the money in taxation and dealing with all the thousands of petty, bureaucratic details. Which is why we had magistrates. Artorius had, himself, been *duumvir* of Linnius a few years back and had been approached by Vortigern about standing for one of the praetor roles when his year came around; not long now.

No, the barbarians may have been here for a while now, but they were still barbarians. Much like the army in the north, they basically kept themselves to themselves and did their job without involving themselves in the political situation that surrounded them. Even when they "took over" a part of the country - as Hengest had in Kent - they still treated the people that lived there - free, Roman citizens! - as if they were chattels or slaves. What was the world coming to? Well, we all know that. The end days are nigh.

Artorius shut out the depressing thought. Enough time later for thoughts like that. This was a time to try and bring this ludicrous internecine warfare to an end. Osric and Hengest were here to defend Britain and the British way of life: why would they try to tear it apart?

"No, no, no! One thousand times no! My master says No! He been cheated, he been betrayed, he been defrauded", Ceretic yelled, stumbling over some of the trickier Latin words that he still struggled to learn. "My master is right King of Kentiworg and you must agree this. Or else."

The words came out like a threat; there could be no denying it. Slowly it dawned on all those present that they were a threat. Some atavistic premonition made Artorius turn from the men in the triblinum to face back towards the door. Where there had been an empty space, now fifty or more Saxons stood blocking the entrance, all armed with swords and axes in spite of the complete ban on all weapons at the conference.

"Treachery! We are betrayed!" he shouted, reaching instinctively for the gladius which should have hung at his left hip had he not been disarmed for the conference. His mind whirled, trying to think of how he could obtain some weapon; get some leverage to defend himself against these barbarians.

Others were turning now, facing the revealed enemy in shock and horror. Some like Artorius sought weapons to defend themselves; others looked to flee. Ambrosius was the first to take action, sweeping most of the detritus off a nearby table, grabbing up the heavy lead candlestick in his right hand and lifting the table by one of its legs in the other. Artorius saw him move and jumped to his side, lifting the other half of the heavy oak table and snatching up another of the candlesticks as a makeshift club. Together they charged the Saxons, hoping to break the still-forming line as they had so many times before.

Behind them, Hengest was yelling now, incoherent in his native barbarian tongue. Ceretic had ceased translating; obviously whatever he was saying was intended only for his own men; those invited into the hall or those who had entered surreptiously. Everywhere action was erupting as those on both sides separated, struggling for makeshift weapons and clamoring imprecations.

The table crashed into the shields of the first Saxons. Although the move was probably surprising, there was no doubt that these Saxons knew why they were here and were expecting trouble. Only the fact that they were still coming into the hall, and had not had the opportunity to properly deploy and form their battle line gave Artorius and Ambrosius any opening at all. And yet, it was a slim one.

"To me, to me," yelled Ambrosius, naturally taking the lead as he had so many times before as Legate and General.

"For the glory of the Second", should Artorius, slipping back into the battle cry of the unit where he had done his military service on the border against the Picts.

The Saxon line held but swayed; the first Saxon opposite them heaved his axe, spewing thousands of splinters from the once-elegant table. Ambrosius and Artorius swung in unison with their clubs and forced the opposing Saxon to retreat a step: all they needed to start the line moving backwards until it would eventually break.

Others were coming to join them now; veterans of military service either in the North or in the recent wars in Kent. Artorius felt, rather than saw, Gwyrangon, the erstwhile Consul of Kent come to his left hand side, a serving tray acting as a shield and a meat skewer for a weapon. Cornelius Albus, ever a good man in a crisis, had hauled down a tapestry and was using it as a Retiarius might have in the arena in Camolodunum in years gone by.

"To the left," shouted Ambrosius and without conscious thought, Artorius obeyed the order of his superior. Together they turned the Saxon line, opening a hole through which some of their compatriots might escape to the door. From behind, men came running, some to further open the gap, others to flee through it. For a few moments, the Britons held the field, then the numbers and weapons told and Ambrosius and Artorius went down, stabbed from behind by the encircling Saxons.

Some fled; many more were executed by the rampaging Saxons. Vortigern was captured and held alive, forced to cede all of Kent, along with the lands west of there as far as the Arun to Hengest and his compatriots.

Those that fled passed down the story that we all know. When it mattered most, Vortigern crumbled but Ambrosius and Artorius stood firm in their bravery, even when the cause was hopeless. But to Artorius' now-orphaned son, that would be cold comfort on the nights to come in the years ahead.

1. On the Arun

AD472

The mist was seeping up from the river.

To the left, they could hear some geese clacking, oblivious to the actions of the men nearby. Soon the dawn would come, and with it the noise of war. The geese would fly then. Hopefully so would the Saxons.

Arthur peered into the mist, trying to divine something from what was little more than reflected moonlight in the dark. The moon was past full and just setting behind them, as the sun would soon rise in front of them, giving the enemy a precious advantage if they allowed them to take it. Assuming the enemy were here.

They probably were. Over the past decade as the British had started to fight back, fords like this were common battle sites. The river was the "accepted" border although Arthur swore that he would never accept it, never accept that this land was no longer Britain but "SudSexe" as the barbarians called it. He would rather die than give in to the final destruction of that which he held dearest: the past that had passed before he had been born, but was still, in some sense, preserved and alive in the magnificent books he had read as a child: Cicero, Sulla, Rutilius Rufus, Pompeius, Caesar, Seneca, Tacitus, Severus. The great men who had understood what it was to be great and yet to be but a small part of something infinitely greater: Rome.

He shook his head slightly to bring himself back to the moment. A mistake here could cost him his life; more importantly, it could cost the lives of his men. Men, who, even though many of them were old than him, trusted him implicitly; not because he had been placed over them but because he was the man with the birth, the rank and "the spirit". A concept he knew that Aelle, somewhere out there but probably not just across the river, would never be able to understand.

From his right came a bird honk that, although fairly natural-sounding, Arthur knew to be out of place. Quintus had never been able to quite manage the delicate sound of the river heron. Of course, if you didn't know what to listen for, weren't actively listening to hear it be wrong, be out of place, then you probably wouldn't notice. Arthur hoped that nobody across the river was listening that closely. Certainly nobody had moved yet.

Time dripped on; slowly the sky in the east was starting to turn from black to grey; the mist was becoming more substantial, less ethereal. It would give them some cover but nothing like enough once the horses starting splashing across the ford. Time to move? He was waiting for Quintus to call again, confirm that he too saw nothing waiting for them. Saw nothing at all in this mist, more like.

Arthur tapped Morcant's shoulder next to him. Morcant made the sound of a crow that alerted the band to be ready and to saddle up. The horses were a hundred paces back from the ford; even the best-trained horse will occasionally make a noise and that could be fatal at this range. Arthur and his scouts hurried back and found the other men already saddled and waiting to go in the slowly glistening light.

Arthur considered saying something but everyone knew the plan; everyone had been here before, done this before, survived before. Saying anything would only betray his own nervousness and fear that maybe they would never do it again. That maybe on the other side of the river, Aelle had drawn up all his forces in battle array and were waiting for them to cross. You scouted, you tested, you probed; but until you were in that water you never knew for sure what was going to happen.

Getting back to his horse, Arthur grabbed the saddle with both hands and threw himself up and onto its back. Some men needed tree stumps - or even help from their friends - to get up onto a horse but Arthur was skilled enough - and young enough - to be able to jump up into the saddle. He made it a requirement that all the men in his unit could do the same thing.

If it was dark out by the riverbank, here under the trees it was almost pitch black. With the moon setting behind them, even that faint light was cut off. By touch Arthur checked his weapons: the long horse-spear that he had heard the Gauls had lengthened again and were now calling a 'lance'; the two javelins that would be needed against defended positions; the cavalry sword, longer than the infantry gladius and with a cutting edge for slashing down at infantry stuck on the ground; and the small, round shield that he rarely used since it was only effective against other cavalry. Against infantry, the bigger danger was damage to his legs or his horse.

Slowly, they advanced towards the river. Until they were actually in the water, splashing across the ford, the priority was quiet. Hopefully, nobody even knew they were coming. Maybe there wasn't even anybody there.

To the right, he knew that Quintus would be leading his flanking column down to the ford, while to the left, Lucullus would be leading his flankers. They had practised this enough, and done this enough, that he knew they would be there without looking.

Suddenly, they were at the bank; turning to Morcant, he gave the signal to attack and spurred his horse into a stream. As if nature itself responded to his signal, suddenly all was confusion in the lightening gloom. To his left the geese honked and erupted into the sky. From across the river came the unmistakable sounds of infantrymen reading swords, shields and bows. Before he was halfway across the ford, the first arrows came threading their way among the charging horses; undeterred, they kept moving.

With a crash they broke through the brush on the far side of the ford. Behind the brush were two earthworks, one either side of the primitive track that led to the ford. While ineffective against an organised infantry assault, they were sufficient to deter a horse charge.

With effortless decision making, Arthur led his band straight through the middle, as archers from both sides let fly at his men. In running the gauntlet, he took a risk, but gained a much superior position. To start with, he had no actual need to stand here and fight these men; they had been placed here to deter the kind of river crossing he had just attempted and, once he was through, they had failed in their job. If he simply carried on, they would be forced to choose between holding their current position in safety but settling for just raising the alarm, or chasing after him and putting themselves at a tactical disadvantage.

But plundering and burning lands "occupied" by the Saxons was not Arthur's chief concern. It was necessary, of course, after a fashion, and certainly easier, but his main drive was to kill Saxon warriors. It was harder, but it was the only way to make Britain back to the way it should be.

He pulled up, wheeled his horse and signalled to his men to follow suit. The timing now was critical. His flanking troopers would, by now, have crossed the river - slower than him due to not having the help of the ford - and be picking their way through the woods to make it back to the ford. Pulling out into three files, the horses charged, each of the men pulling his first spear to throw into the defended positions.

It was lighter now and as they charged the sun started to lift above the horizon behind them; hopefully it would shine brightly into the eyes of the men facing them and make it harder to aim their missiles.

As they came back to the defensive positions, the three files split open like a flower. Arthur led the central column back down the narrow path to the ford, while his men on either side ran across the back of each of the positions, each launching a javelin at a target as they went.

Just as the unit to the south had cleared the area, Quintus crashed through the undergrowth and started a frontal assault from the south side of the enemy position. Dozens of spears clattered over the earth-and-timber wall, striking defending Saxons and bouncing off defensive timbers.

Arthur's column was trapped between the two embrasures and the river but they had known that was going to happen. With a precision that could only come from hours of practice from their homes in the West Country, they wheeled and rode back through the narrow channel between the embrasures, drawing and throwing their second spears as they passed.

Now Lucullus arrived from the north, his men dispatching their spears into the northern embrasure before rolling around to join Arthur's men on the track. As he did so, Quintus disengaged from the southern embrasure and joined Arthur as well. Reunited, the thirty-strong band rode down the track looking for farms to burn and halls to torch.

Such was life on the border of Saxon England.

It always seemed a lot further going back to the West Country. Of course, a lot of that was simply because coming, they would make a stealthy camp close to the border to spend the night, but on the return journey they had to move away from the border lands as quickly as possible, and by the time you were far enough from the border to feel safe and make camp, you might as well carry on back to the halfway fort.

Arthur was based at the impressive fort of Mons Badonicus, but that was much too far to ride in a single day; all the more so after the horses had been in action for much of the day. So, both outbound and return, his troop would stop overnight at Clausentum.

Today they were weary and dispirited. After the initial engagement, they had spent the morning burning and destroying, but had failed to find any Saxon soldiers willing to dispute the territory or come and be killed. While the halls they had destroyed, and the crops they had burnt would inconvenience the Saxons come winter, Arthur and his men all knew that the people that would suffer the brunt of the attacks would be fellow Britons.

Sometimes they were lucky and the Saxons even chased them across the river into their own territory. Without horses, they were unable to keep up and presented no threat; nevertheless, Arthur had the opportunity to set an ambush and possibly kill some of them when they were not behind their fortifications. Of course, there were other times when they came and Arthur and his men were not around; then it was British farms that would be put to the torch.

As they finally arrived back at Badonicus the following evening, the sun was starting to set and they began the weary climb up through the fortifications. As always, Arthur marvelled at these works, built before the coming of the Romans and left deserted for hundreds of years before being pressed back into service as the countryside once again became dangerous and full of bandits.

A voice pulled him out of his reverie. "Ho, Arthur!" exclaimed Quintus Ambrosius Aurelianus, officially his general - and possibly emperor - but to Arthur much more an avuncular figure from his childhood and "youth" - if you can look back on your youth when you have just turned 20.

"Good to see you managed not to lose anybody in the forests," joked Aurelianus. He usually made some joke such as this when one of the units came back from a raid. It was his way of pretending that the tension they all felt back at base was just about the possibility of a simple accident; not the all too likely prospect of a man being fatally wounded by an arrow.

Arthur leapt down from his horse and gave the man a bear hug. Aurelianus had given Arthur his first sword, taught him to ride and done a thousand other things for him, all while single-handedly pulling Britain back from the edge of the abyss. How he had done it - how he still did it at that - Arthur could never comprehend. Even with the tireless vigour of youth, Arthur was worn out by these raids. To have to come back from one to plan another and sort out a thousand details of the life of a whole community was beyond his imagination. Much more to have time for a boy who was more interested in his books.

"Quintus thinks we may have killed a couple of their sentries at the border crossing, but other than that the raid was a failure." Arthur looked at the ground, unable to meet the eye of this man when relating the destruction of British, rather than Saxon, property. "We burnt out a number of farms, and destroyed two of the halls the Saxons had built, but nobody came to challenge us. We came back round to the south and found that ford wasn't even defended. It's almost like they don't care about whether we come and attack anymore."

"Maybe they don't, at that, young Artorius. You still have much to learn about the world for all your book-reading and feats of arms. They know as well as we do that it's stalemate as long as they can stay in defensible positions and we have the monopoly on horses. It'll be a sad day when a Saxon finally decides to mount a horse."

"All the more reason for us to beat them sooner," replied Arthur. "We can't afford to let them develop cavalry and dominate us on the battlefield. We need to get them to come out and fight us."

"That's easily said, young man, easily said. And don't think we haven't tried. But your Saxon knows which side of his bread he's put that greasy butter on. He's not going to come out and fight us at a disadvantage, and the more land they can hold the more safe areas they have that they can hold on to for supply."

They walked back up the hill together side by side, Arthur leading his tired horse back to its stall. As the passed the sentries, Arthur greeted each of them by name, unconsciously recognizing them and thanking them for their service. Without secure bases like these, the resistance would have frittered away years ago.

Europe

AD350-AD410

Of course, the troubles didn't start in 472, or even 452. Opinions vary, but I think everybody would agree that it goes back a hundred years or more.

The history books tell us that the Roman Republic died in a plethora of civil wars the like of which could not be imagined in this age. If Pollio tells the truth - and why should we doubt him? - then in their day enough Roman soldiers died fighting each other that if they were here with us today we could not only see of these pesky Saxons but push the Goths and the Huns back across the Rhine and the Danube.

But for four hundred years, after Octavianus took sole control of the government and the Republic died its slow death of strangulation when it seemed nobody was looking, there was peace throughout the whole of the Roman domain. To be sure, there were occasional skirmishes with the barbarians across the border rivers, and every century or so a particularly bad emperor would have to be deposed violently, but for the majority of us - including those of us in Britain who missed the first century of peace because Augustus (as Octavianus came to be known) decreed that his father Julius had been wrong to come here at all and they should just let the Britons keep to themselves - it was a very placid time.

But then, in AD350, when the boy Constans was titular Emperor of the Western half of the Empire, holding it in the name of his brother Constantius, a Rhine general called Magnentius decided that he would be a better emperor than Constantius. Enough time has gone by that it's hard to say now what he was really thinking, but given that Constans was a boy at the time let's give him the benefit of the doubt: a man would have been a better emperor than a boy.

If he had actually been the emperor.

The problem was, that while he thought he might make a better emperor, and had the backing of an influential group of Senators in Rome and the west, there wasn't an actual vacancy, and he didn't have the backing of the armies on the Danube who remained stedfastly loyal to the Emperor of the East, the deposed emperor's brother Constantius. So the only way for Magnentius to get the job was to take his army, based in Gaul, tasked with holding the Rhine bridges in the face of the Goths, all the way to Eastern Europe to fight a battle with Constantinus.

The fact that he lost the Battle of Mursa a couple of years later is really a footnote to history. The two important consequences were that while he was away, the Goths flooded into Gaul, devastating swathes of the countryside and wreaking havoc; and, like Sulla marching on Rome, it gave other people the idea that it was fine to decide that if you didn't like the current emperor, you could find some troops holding back the dam against the barbarians and whisk them off to your coronation ceremony in Rome without worrying about the consequences for the rest of us too much.

It took Constantinus another half a decade to try and put the genie back in the bottle and force, bribe or blackmail the barbarians back across the Rhine where they belonged. But in a lot of ways, the genie never was put back in the bottle. Civil wars are much deadlier than foreign wars for a number of reasons. First off, all the casualties are "yours", so that's going to be double what it would otherwise be. Then, the troops you're facing are generally a lot better trained than barbarians, so the death count is much higher. And, finally, when you're facing barbarians, they often decide that discretion is the better part of valour, and go home when the going gets tough. That's not an option when you have two well-trained Roman generals in charge. If you take all that into account, you can see that both on the Rhine and on the Danube, we were under-strength for a long time.

Moreover, while the Goths were in Gaul, there was a rearrangement of barbarian forces in Central Europe. We will probably never know everything that went on, but new tribes appeared from nowhere - east of Parthia, they say, although where that might be, I have no idea. The Huns were fearsome horse warriors. Excellent, as Arthur always said, that none of them decided to come here. The Saxons were always ship people, but they used to ply their violent trade somewhere in the far east where we never saw them. Between the Goths raiding into Gaul, and the Huns pushing up into Central Europe, the Saxons were displaced and found their way towards Western Europe, but still on the other side of the Rhine. When Constantinus pushed the Goths back across the Rhine, the Saxons wanted out - and sailing to Britain was an obvious trick to try. Time and again over the next decade or two, Britain came under attack from every direction - Saxons from the east; Irish from the west; Picts from the north. Britain had always had four legions since the conquest under Claudius (the II, IX, XIV and XX), although under Hadrianus the VI had come and the IX had eventually left.

Most of the time, these four legions were enough to deal with these attacks, but in AD367 the forces of darkness united against us and launched a coordinated raid, destroying much of our defences down the East Coast of Britain and overrunning our northern stations. The new Emperor, Valentinian, sent his most dependable troubleshooter, Theodosius, Count of Gaul, to Britain to reinforce the legions and to eject the invaders. In a series of lightning campaigns he defeated and destroyed the Saxons in the South and East of Britain, redeployed the legions in such a way as to free up the II and XX to humiliate the Irish in the Demetia and near Anglesey, and then reorganized the whole of the defence of the northern marches, appointing regional governors with plenipotentiary powers as a buffer before the regular legions based at Hadrian's wall.

The next disaster to befall the empire happened far off in the east. Some of the Gothic tribes were allowed to cross the Danube and settle in Roman lands. But they were unhappy in their new homes, and soon rebelled, defeating the Imperial forces and killing the Emperor in a battle that was fought at Adrianople in AD 378. In his place, the new emperor was the son of Theodosius who had rescued Britain, also called Theodosius. But he - and his colleague in the west, Gratian - were unpopular in much of the west, and once again Britain provided the leader of a new rebellion. Gnaeus Magnus Maximus left Britain in 383, taking the II and the XIV with him, leaving us woefully undermanned. He picked up more units on the Rhine and went east to do battle with Theodosius - and once again lost. Some of the troops returned to Gaul five years later, but none of them made it back to Britain.

Again, Gaul was overrun by barbarians, and it took yet more years of hard work by Theodosius, only to die himself in 395. On his death, Stilicho, the senior general of the west, controlled the new emperor Honorius, and in his name restored order to Gaul and Britain.

But events in the east dominated time and again. When Goths crossed the Danube in force and threatened Italy, Stilicho had to strip the Rhine of many of its units and recalled the XX from Chester in a bid to protect Italy. Not surprisingly, the barbarians hordes held up on the other side of the Rhine exploded into Gaul and threatened Britain. Constantine, the general of the one remaining British legion - the IX based at Hadrian's Wall - was quickly proclaimed "Emperor" and sent to Gaul to round up the remaining forces, put some backbone into them and do battle with the marauding Goths, Saxons, Alans, Suebi, Vandals and all the rest.

Eventually Constantine prevailed and drove the barbarians from Gaul, but was unable to destroy them or drive them back across the Rhine. Instead, they took flight to the south, considering invading Italy but ultimately crossing the Pyrenees into the Spains. For once, Constantine was able to return the units to whence they had come, but remained himself in Gaul. For mercy, he did not try to make himself Emperor of all the West, but just settled for "Emperor of the Gauls and Britain".

On the other hand, Honorius could not let him be even that, and sent his generals to attack Constantine rather than working together to destroy the barbarians, or at least hold some of them out of Italy. Yes, he succeeded in destroying Constantine, and getting the British and Gauls to recant, but it cost him the Empire.

Because next came the big blow. Through treachery and betrayal, Rome was sold out to the barbarians and was sacked. A thousand years of civilization and history was destroyed overnight. And the 24th day of the month of August in the year of our Lord 410 went down in the history books as a day of infamy that none will ever forget.

2. Mons Badonicus

AD477

Arthur looked up as he heard the shouts.

Instinctively, he knew something was up. Something in the tenor of the shouting was off; this was not the normal sound of a returning unit.

He dropped the hammer he had been using to hammer out the new shoes he was preparing for his horse and walked out of the forge. Down in the valley he could see the column of men coming in, ragged and torn. Aside from anything else, they were late, but now he recognized the tonality of the sound for what it was: the grief of men who had lost their leader. Suddenly it dawned on Arthur: Ambrosius! He had been leading yesterday's raid and it would be he that was being mourned. Without thought, he ran for the gates and down the hill.

"I don't know how they knew we was coming, Young Arthur," Mardoc said when Arthur ran up to him and asked for news. "But they must've. They was ready for us, all right and we walked right into their ambush."

"How?" asked Arthur, struggling to handle this news on top of the tragedy of Ambrosius' death. With the massive advantage in maneouverability and speed, it was almost impossible for the Saxons to ambush the British: their only real weapon was defence, either through fortifications or through a solid shield wall.

"I don't know how they knew we was coming, but they knew all right. Just on the ford, before we crossed the river. They was there. Must have been there before we arrived the night before the raid. As we was getting ready to cross the river in the morning, there they was. All around us. We was mounting up and they was just appearing out of the trees, swinging them axes of theirs and just hacking everyone in sight. Until we got mounted it was slaughter, it was.

"And then?"

"They got old Ambrosius before he could even make it back to his horse. We tried to get over there and rescue him, but he was dead by the time we got there. You know what he was like for quiet: no weapons with him when scouting and we couldn't cover for him when we was under attack ourselves."

Arthur screamed inside his head in frustration and rage. The way they did things made sense - as long as everything went to plan. And until today, everything had gone to plan. How *had* the Saxons known that Ambrosius would be there? Good luck? Did they guess every time and just guess wrong most of the time? Were they tracking somewhere back in British territory? Did somebody give us away? Maybe they had raided and held somebody hostage against this day. His thoughts spiralled through all the ramifications.

Stay calm.

The first lesson that Merula had taught him all those years ago. When he was tempted to give into his rage at the unfairness of it all, Merula would calmly - oh so calmly - remind him that losing his temper was only the first step towards losing his head. But a calm man could do anything. So said Merula. We'll see.

The cortege wound its way up the hillside and through the gates of the fort. After the men had mounted their horses, it had been relatively easy to disperse the Saxons, who had, in any case, wanted to flee at that point. By the time the men had regrouped and recovered the bodies of their leader and four others who had been killed, there seemed little option but retreat. Again Arthur fumed: if Saxons were out of their forts and on our side of the river, there was the opportunity for slaughter. An opportunity which was not taken. If he had been there ...

If he had been there, he, like Ambrosius, would now be tied on the back of his horse being taken home for burial.

At last the funeral was over.

It had only been a couple of days, but despite his best efforts to remain calm, Arthur had struggled to deal with the loss of the man who had given him so much. Only Merula had done more for him. And - may the Lord be praised - Merula had arrived this morning in answer to his summons for the funeral. Merula would probably not have left his home in Glestinium in the west of Britain had it not been for the death of his erstwhile friend and colleague.

Merula - Gnaeus Laelius Merula to give him his full name - had had a long and illustrious history in these islands and had now reached a very respectable old age. How old, he would not say when Arthur questioned him, but old enough to have been older that Arthur and Ambrosius, but a contemporary - if not older still - than their fathers.

When Arthur's father had died outside Verulanium twenty years before, Arthur had been left an orphan. Merula - who then lived in Linnius with the Artorii - had adopted him under the terms of Artorius' will. In many ways, Merula was the father Arthur would have chosen; or maybe Arthur was the child Merula would have chosen. Or maybe Arthur grew up to be the child Merula formed.

They walked together back to Arthur's "hut". When the rebellion had first started, they had quickly realized the need for safe and secure bases long from the reach of the Saxons. They had quickly felled logs and dragged them up here, building temporary structures that they sarcastically called "huts". As time had gone on, the houses, the stables and the whole community had grown into something approaching a real Roman village, but everything still retained the casual names they had had when first occupied. So Arthur still lived in a "hut", albeit one connected to a central village hypocaust and with covered access to the stables and the forge.

Merula walked inside and sat down. Arthur poured him a cup of wine and mixed it with water. He passed it over and reached for another cup for himself, poured and sat down facing Merula.

Merula sipped and thought, leaning his head on one side in a way Arthur remembered from his youth. "Good wine, this. Where do you get it?"

Arthur laughed; of all his concerns right now, the wine supply was a long way down the list. "Ambrosius has - had - connections deep in Gaul somewhere. There's still money to be had for the finer things in life - just not the essentials."

Merula looked at him sharply. "Don't get all bitter, now, Arthur. It won't do you any good, you know. You need to keep things in perspective."

"I'm trying; I really am. But you know, I think we're losing."

Merula's eyes seemed to bore into him, seeking deep answers somewhere in the depth of his soul.

"For one so young, you seem to have become very cynical, my boy. Where did you acquire this age-weary pose? Somebody been giving you bad tutoring?"

"No, no, nothing like that. It's just very simple: numbers. We can go raid them and kill a dozen men, but then the following week another boat arrives and they have more men there than they did before. But every time we lose a man, who replaces him? They are warriors born; we prefer ... scholars."

"And what's wrong with that?"

"Nothing, nothing at all. Until you are sitting in your library with your scrolls one day, composing witty epigrams about Julius Caesar's love life when a Saxon strides in with his battle-axe and dismembers you."

"Colorfully put. Remind me not to play at epigrams with you, particularly not to those rules. But no, I was more thinking ... well, about thinking."

"Thinking?"

"Yes, have you really *thought* about the position we are in?"

"I think about almost nothing else."

"Yes, but have you really, truly *thought* about it. Like Caesar, say, rather than Pompey. Thought deeply about and around the issues and seen if you can't think of another way out."

"Such as?"

"So that would be a no, then, I presume. Too busy hacking people's heads off to spend any quality time being a general."

"I'm not the general. Ambrosius is."

"Was."

"Whatever. I'm not."

"Yet."

Arthur looked up in surprise. At 25, he was not even officially old enough to be quaestor or to be admitted to the Senate. He was way too young to officially command an army and, moreover, there were any number of men on this hill who were old enough, had the rank and the birth. Were they all going to die in a storm to make way for him?

"No," replied Merula, apparently to his thoughts alone. "They will appoint the best man for the job. Special circumstances and all that. Always a camp lawyer somewhere who can find a loophole when you need one. But no matter about that ..." He trailed off and waved his hand absently, lost in thought.

"No, what you need to concern yourself with is what you are going to do with that power. In short, how you are going to wipe all the Saxons from this land. And, if you think about it for a moment, you will realize there is only one answer."

Arthur continued to stare. If there was one answer, it was one more than he had managed to think of. What was Merula going to suggest? Wave a magic wand and send them back into the sea? Or summon up the old British and Roman gods to wreak vengeance? Arthur didn't see it working.

"You know, there are times when I think you may have been my densest pupil, Arthur. It's sitting in front of you and yet you still don't see it ... not even today of all days."

Arthur said nothing; simply sat in silence. His mind was more than blank; it had simply ceased to function. Finally he opened his mouth.

"No, go on. Tell me. Or at least give me a hint."

"All right then. In what situation *could* you destroy them?"

Arthur thought for a moment. Merula had played this logic games with him since he was a child. Usually the answer was buried somewhere in Plato, or Aristotle or one of the "greats" of philosophy. Merula could be as annoying as Socrates as well at times, thought Arthur. Now might be one of those times.

"Well, if they were foolish enough to try and climb this hill and attack us in broad daylight when we had men stationed to ambush them on their retreat ..."

"Yes?" Merula's eyebrows flickered up a little. This was an age-old clue to Arthur that he was on the right lines. Arthur briefly wondered if Socrates had done the same thing when one of his interlocutors had given the "correct" answer to one of his questions about justice, or the soul, or the meaning of life.

Yes, we could beat them - even destroy them - on an open battlefield or a battlefield of our choosing. Like Marius defeating the Germans at Aquae Sextiae, or Sulla rolling up the natives of Pontus. That would be the easy part - almost too easy given the cavalry advantage on top of everything else. But what would tempt them to do something so foolish ...

"Greed," supplied Merula, once again uncannily knowing the drift of Arthur's thoughts. "Yes, indeed, greed is a powerful motive that makes men do stupid things. Greed or lust. And a belief that you will win and the other side doesn't have a chance. And don't forget, it doesn't have to be tomorrow. Give it ten or twenty years to mature into a plan. Wear them down until they're ready to be foolish. Ready to give in to anything that might make you go away."

"Greed. Yes. And anger. I can see that. But how?"

"Details, details. The first of which is to get you elected as Imperator here. Not Emperor, no. That would never happen. Let's see ... a good title? Comes, perhaps? Dux? I've always thought Dux sounded better."

"But the Duke is bound to stay in one place and guard that territory. We are fighting a mobile war; it is the age of the Count."

"True, true. How you do test me, young Arthur. One place eh? How about 'the war'? You're not going to drift far from that, are you? And it will stop too much jealousy of your ranke and role. Yes, Dux Bellorum, I think that's the way to go."

"Dux Bellorum? I've never heard of such a thing. What does it even mean?"

"Special circumstances, my boy. Special circumstances. It means you will be in charge of this war by sundown."

Merula called the meeting to order.

The men gathered around the tribunal as the sun started to set in the west and formed into ranks, unconsciously letting their training come to the fore. On the platform stood four men, one of whom would be their leader by the evening. Officially, the decision was in the hands of the Council, but that had been so dominated, first by Vortigern and then by Ambrosius, that it would ratify anything the men here decided.

Merula would not be the leader, even though he was one of the four men on the tribunal. He was here to run proceedings and to make sure that nothing went awry. Roman discipline being what it was, trouble was unlikely, but it always helped to have a cool head on hand to make things feel more certain.

While Arthur was popular, and certainly a good leader of his unit, he was generally considered too young to make the grade, which meant that the choice was really between the other two men on the stage: Ambrosius' deputy Mardoc, or the leader of the third troop, the insufferably pompous Titus Fulvius Crispus. The smart money was on Mardoc, but there was hardly a man there that didn't think that Arthur was "the one".

"It falls to us to elect a new leader of the Roman Resistance. The tablets and buckets are prepared and you all, being citizens, know the methods of voting. Normally, we would allow a few weeks for campaigning and the proper procedure for you to get to know the candidates, but really, with the war and all ... you know, special circumstances ..." he drifted off dreamily.

"Anyway, I thought it would be good to allow each of the candidates to say something about why they thought you should choose them and, uh, well ... here we are. Mardoc? Get on with it, if you would."

Although expecting to have to say something, Mardoc was taken aback by this somewhat brief introduction. Rallying himself, he gamely began.

"Friends, Romans, Countrymen ... We have all lost today a great man, a man I am pleased to call by the name of friend.

"Just a few short years ago, this man roused us from the slumbers of the Massacre and the Raid and showed us that we could fight back against the unwelcome foreigner, against those that would take our lands, take our women and destroy our way of life. I had given up hope, I tell you, given up hope. I was considering leaving, going to Armorica with the others ...

"But Ambrosius gave me back hope. He showed me ... showed us ... that it was possible for small bands of dedicated men to take the struggle to the Saxon and, through striving, to overcome. And we will ...

"He showed us how and we will. I will carry on the struggle. Until we win."

Merula stepped forward again. "Thank you, Mardoc. Now ... uh, Titus Fulvius, if you would."

"Clearly, there is a process here and a right order for things and I can only see one proper and correct way forward which is to give the leadership to the senior man. I am that man.

"It is incumbent upon us to do the right thing and to appoint the right man. The man with the birth, the experience and the knowledge. I am that man."

Merula nodded: "Thank you, Titus Fulvius.

"It may be said that the other man here, Gaius Artorius, is officially old enough to contest this election. That may be true for different men in different situations, but we are here to elect, how shall we put it? The *Dux Bellorum Brittanicae* and as such, there is no specific requirement on the law books as to age. If Honorius could be emperor at age 10, presumably Arthur could be Dux at 25. Hmmm. Anyway. I suppose if you don't agree with that, then you should vote for one of the other eminently ... qualified ... candidates."

He paused for a moment, looked around.

"Arthur?"

Arthur stepped forward, hesitantly.

He knew that Merula had given him all the clues he needed, and now it was up to him to make that speech that would make the dream a reality. The dream that had been his since that awful night when his parents had been murdered and he swore vengeance on the Saxons by all gods, British, Roman or Christian.

He looked at the two other men on the tribunal with him. They had said what he had expected them to say: one that he was the friend of Ambrosius, a safe pair of hands; the other that he was the man with the right. What should his message be?

He looked around him, looked at the faces out there, expecting *something* of him. Did they know what? Did he? Did Merula? They were expecting him to ... that was it! They demanded hope.

"Comrades, I too mourn my dear friend Ambrosius. And I say with Mardoc that we must continue without him. But why, my friends? Why this struggle?" He looked out at the bemused faces. "No, I do not suggest lamely giving in now our leader is dead. Oh, no.

"But I do ask this: are you satisfied with raiding the Saxons, killing a few, and then being killed in turn? Are you satisfied with ceding the lands east of the Arun? Are you content that the lands of the Iceni are held by foreigners? That none can live in Linnius because it is too close to the lands of the North Folk?

"If you are, I am not the right leader. Because I am not satisfied. I want revenge for the brutal murder of my parents twenty years ago. I want the interlopers ousted. I want our lands back. I demand a return to the proper forms of government. The Council of Britain must be supreme. Until that day, I struggle for that day!"

"Well, I suppose that wraps up the speeches. If you'll kindly come and choose a tablet and put it in a bucket we can get on with the acclamation and then maybe there's some food somewhere ..."

The election officers stepped forward and handed tablets to the men as they passed. Each one marked an appropriate glyph in the soft clay for the man he wanted to be the new leader and deposited it in the appropriate bucket for his unit. Within a few minutes, the voting was over and the count began.

"The first unit votes for Arthur," declared the official when the first bucket had been counted. Not really a surprise, since it was his unit.

"The second unit votes for Arthur," declared the official, counting out the second bucket.

"And the third unit votes for ... Arthur."

It was complete ... he was now officially *Dux Bellorium Brittaniae*, whatever that meant.

And as the sun finally set, the cheering started. They may not have thought it possible, but the men were pleased with what they had done.

London

AD410

With all the changing of emperors and sacking of Rome that was going on, the details of how Britain was governed understandably mattered little to those close to the Emperor Honorius.

After the demise of Constantine had caused the deposition of the governor and prefects he had appointed and sent men scurrying to write begging and apologetic letters to Honorius, asking for forgiveness and new governors, word came of the sack of Rome. Unthinkable! Inconceivable! How could such a thing happen? Even London was more secure against barbarian attack than that.

Honorius himself, of course, was not based at Rome but at the Adriatic port city of Ravenna, in the midst of an almost impenetrable marsh. There are those who accused him of cowardice, but a good defensive position is a good defence, as they say.

Eventually, a response came from the Emperor to the effect that he would not be sending any officials and that while Britain was still nominally part of "his Empire", the lines of communication were too long for him to effectively administer it - after all, northern Italy and southern Gaul were swarming with barbarians right now - and that the cities and provinces of Britain should look to their own defence and appoint such officers and recruit such units as seemed expedient to preserve their homes.

In other words, Britain was no longer part of the empire as far as Honorius was concerned and could do what it liked.

Of course, the first thing it did was to call together the Council of Britain for a lot of talking. The promptly took all the resolutions necessary for an effective transition of power. Firstly, the renamed themselves the "British Senate"; then they ordained that there would be annual elections for two officials called Consuls; then they held the elections with all due ceremony; also elected four Praetors to run the main districts other than London (which was to be directly administered by the Consuls) - based at Linnius, Gloucester and York and the so-called "Saxon Shore", the south-east coast of the island where the Comes - previously an imperial appointment - was in charge of Britain's mobile forces, able to take them to any likely point of attack at a moment's notice.

Sadly, very little of this addressed the most pressing needs, which, as was pointed out the following spring, really were very pressing.

As had happened before, the Saxons came and attacked in numbers on the south coast, landing in a multitude of places and driving inland, burning and looting. At the same time, the Picts attacked, driving south through the border regions established by Theodosius in his time in Britain. And on the west coast, the Irish attacked Ordovica, coming through Anglesey and driving down through the mountains.

Fortunately, when making all their preparations, the Council of Britain, I mean the British Senate, had in fact done one very wise thing. They had elected Ambrosius Aurelianus (the father of the later leader of the rebellion) to be Senior Consul and given him the responsibility for the defence of the island. He had been working tirelessly - over significant opposition, it has to be said - to try and raise funds, an army and prepare the defences for such an attack. That he failed to do so says more about the difficulties of the task than it truly does about the man himself.

The Saxons needed dealing with first. They were in amongst us and had easy access down good roads to the heart of the country: the rich fields of the western lowlands. What troops Aurelianus had raised and half-trained he took with him and joined forces with the Comes Saxonae and fought a dozen engagements across the south coast. As raiders, the Saxons were everywhere prepared to retreat rather than suffer losses, and in those days retreat meant retreat to sea.

Aurelianus in those days developed the tactics that his son was to deploy so successfully: the used of mounted units to outpace and ambush the retreating Saxons. Many of the Saxon companies were defeated and utterly annihilated without being able to return to the ships. Others retreated to find that we had got in behind them and burnt their keels to the waterline. Many fierce battles were fought around those ships as their rearguards desperately tried to hold our men off.

With the Saxons defeated, Aurelianus took his units and some of the Comes' mobile cavalry and went to reinforce the Dux York in his defence against the Picts. They had come in strength, driving across the wall in the border regions to the east of the Pennines and drove down the Via Suetonia towards York. The fortifications of the city were impressive, and Aurelianus had ensured that the Dux York would hold that line until he could be reinforced and the combined forces could roll up the Picts. By forced marches he made it to York on the fifteenth day of the siege and lifted it. A bloody battle was fought and the remnants of the Picts retreated back north of the wall. Two more engagements were fought before the Picts finally fled and stayed where they belonged for two or three years.

The Irish remained the biggest menace. Unlike the Saxons, who had simply come to raid, or the Picts, who fought across a border that provided a safe haven and retreat back to the deserted highlands, the Irish came to stay and to stake out kingdoms in our land. They had established bases high in the craggy hills of the Ordovices, and it would not be a simple matter to evict them. The full might of the Roman empire could, of course, have waited them out in siege and stormed many of the fastnesses. With most of the legions having left at some point in the previous twenty years, and limited time and financial resources, the Senate found it more expedient to apply a policy of containment. Aurelianus raised local levies there, appointed towns for defence and generally tried to motivate a society used to security and being defended by professionals to take responsibility for their own defence. The problem, of course, is that it is much cheaper to pay professionals to defend you that it is to try and make every man do two jobs: farmer by day and soldier by night. But in those days, there didn't seem to be the money to pay for that "much cheaper" professional army.

There was, of course. Like a candle burning brightly as it uses up the last of its wax, the Roman civilization in Britain was in some ways at its richest. Although the markets of Europe were slowly seizing up, at this point London was still filling ships full of oysters from the Thames valley for transportation to Rome. The tin and lead being mined in the southwestern regions of Dumnonia was in demand across Europe as far as Constantinople. With the wars and disruption throughout Gaul and the Spains, there was a ready market for food - often at famine prices - wherever you could manage to ship it. For all their complaints, the magnates of Britain were sitting pretty in comparison to their continental compatriots. They were, apart from the occasional raids, secure behind their sea walls; they were rich and getting richer; their commercial activities were largely undisturbed; and their government was still largely stable and Roman.

Aurelianus' term as Consul was over, and others took their turns; as ever through the history of the Republic, and to a lesser extent the empire, some were more talented and some less. Most managed to defend the borders and repel the occasional Saxon raid. The Picts attacked from time to time and were generally repelled; and the Irish remained.

Britain carried on through the twilight years of the Roman Empire, waiting for normality to return and slowly losing the capacity to defend itself when a big shock came.

3. Celidon Wood

AD478

It felt like a distraction, but it needed dealing with.

The Saxons had originally come to Britain to help defend it against the Picts, but ever since the massacre they had been uninterested in that task and solely focused on the task of carving out kingdoms for themselves.

The regional governors that Theodosius had appointed during his administration there - and their hereditary successors - had done a good job on the whole holding back the wilder Picts by assembling confederations of their less-warlike, and more easily influenced, lowland cousins.

But now - probably because they had heard Ambrosius was dead and fancied their chances with a new, unproven leader in charge - they had attacked en masse and Gaius Quintilius Clemens - great-grandson of the original Clemens placed in charge by Theodosius - had sent emergency dispatch riders south to Arthur requesting help.

Arthur's immediate reaction had been to gather up all his forces and set off for the north, but even as he thought it, a vision of Merula's face came into his head and he knew that first and foremost he must make a calm and rational decision.

So he did what Merula would have done. He thought. Deeply.

The council meeting was not going well.

Officially, of course, all policy was decided by the Senate and the bureaucracy and whatever, but in reality, that system had faded with the ascendancy of Vortigern fifty years ago. Arthur was not "the emperor" and could not decide things by fiat. But the decisions that were made here would be respected wherever the title "Dux Bellorum" held sway. And anywhere it didn't, they would try to kill Arthur on sight.

"I cannot believe that you are seriously suggesting this, Arthur," huffed Titus Fulvis. "The men may have granted you the authority, but that does not mean that you acquired the brains or the experience with it."

Arthur breathed in, deeply but calmly, trying both to control and conceal his inner rage. How could they not understand that what he was proposing was the *only* thing that could work. A risk? Certainly. But a risk was better than certain failure.

"Let us ask ourselves, what would Caesar do?"

"Are you now comparing yourself to Caesar? Is that who you think you are? The greatest military genius ever?"

"No, no, I'm not. But we can at least agree," he paused for emphasis, "that Caesar *was* a great military genius and thus," he paused again, "worthy of emulation. Is he not?"

Fulvius said nothing, which at the moment felt like progress.

"So I am suggesting that we consider what he would do in this situation."

"The unexpected."

Almost as unexpected was this intervention by Mardoc. Arthur was both surprised and pleased at the comment, since it was exactly the point he had been trying to make.

"That's what you're trying to say, Arthur. That Caesar would do something unexpected, something that would appear rash; and yet, in hindsight appeared blindingly obvious. So obvious even the couch generals in Rome would say afterwards that they would have done the same thing."

"Yes, that's what I'm trying to say, Mardoc. Yes, the plan rests upon its being unexpected, but at the same time, there really is no choice. It will work because it's not expected; but it is the right thing to do because it *will* work."

"But this plan to strip Linnius of its garrison. That's all that's holding back the tide of Saxons from overrunning the middle of the country and cutting off our communications with York," objected Titus Fulvius. "Is that worth it to repel these barbarians?"

"Repel? Maybe not," admitted Arthur. "But that's not the plan."

"You're *not* planning to rebel the invaders," mused Mardoc. "Yes, that would be unexpected. Why not?"

"Because I am going to go north and invade their homelands and put them to the torch. And I am going to make them *want* to run home with their tails between their legs. And never come south again. But if I'm north of the wall ... who will reinforce the Dux York?"

There was a stunned silence in the council hall for a long while.

The main advantage of the good network of Roman roads around Britain was the system of post riders which enabled rapid communications. By the following morning both the Dux York and the Comes at Linnius knew what was expected of them and, although he didn't like his part in the plan - which everybody acknowledged would mean the probable loss of Linnius if not the whole of the middle of Britain - recognized that executing a disliked plan well was better than botching the job.

The plan was a complicated one and, apart from Arthur, nobody knew all the details. The first part of the plan called for the Picts to *not* know that Arthur was riding north with all speed; but required them at the right moment to find out in a way that did not obviously make it seem like a trap.

At the same time, the combined British forces had to simultaneously support the overall plan while being in ignorance of much of it. Making sure the right people were told the right stories at the right time was as much a part of the plan as planning "the battle" itself.

Much would come down to what Arthur found once north of the wall, but he had read everything that there was to read from the copies of Theodosius' dispatches and reports to an amateur Pliny's attempts at describing the geography of the north of the island - mixed in with a few amusing anecdotes about being chased through the glens by the Picts.

The key, of course, would be to deploy his forces in such a way that he could win a total victory over the enemy on his home turf - and then get away. While he wouldn't claim to be the equal of Julius Caesar, it was a plan that might well have taxed the old man had he been here.

Arthur himself took all his mounted soldiers from Badonicus and sent for reinforcements from Gloucester and made a rendezvous at Chester where he collected yet more reinforcements. He had allowed ten days for the ride to Carlisle and it was going slowly, Roman roads or no. It wasn't the same if you couldn't change horses every fifteen miles at the post stations.

A couple of days slippage and the timings would start to fall apart. Too much of that, and the whole plan could start to unravel.

Outside York, the Picts continued to encamp and threaten the city and fort. They couldn't get in, and they probably wouldn't be able to starve the citizens out. But there were always the two imponderables: luck and treachery.

Inside, the Dux knew that the next stage of Arthur's plan was about to go into effect. Arthur himself was supposed to be coming, but hadn't arrived yet. The Comes of Linnius had sent messages to say that *he* at least was coming and had sent messages to Arthur to find out where he was. The message that had come back was discouraging and indicated that Arthur was distracted fighting Saxons on the road but would be there when he could and to relieve the city as soon as possible.

Being barbarians, the Picts underrated the value of communications and "letting one or two people in or out". So the Dux and the Comes were able to keep in pretty much constant contact over those long days of preparations.

So it was that in the early morning, the 22nd of May, AD 478, the Picts were surprised, to say the least, to find the northern army issuing out of the city gates in battle array. Formed up in four squares, the overstrength legion drove into the centre of a boiling mass of barbarians: the standard infantry tactics that had won the Romans an empire for over a thousand years. An outward-facing metal box which flipped open from time to time to issue pointed swords that stabbed, wounded, killed and then pulled back to make a solid wall.

The tactics didn't always work. If they did, none of Arthur's careful planning or reinforcements would have been necessary. This legion could have gone into action any time in the past month. But on this occasion, the barbarians held enough cards that, given time, they would be able to grind down this too-small force. Even overstrength, one legion in such relatively open territory could not deal with this horde of 50,000 or more barbarians.

But what would always, always work was a sneak attack from behind. What they had failed to realize was that the Dux's army was just a lure: a feint for the cavalry charge that seemingly came from everywhere at once.

And suddenly there they were. In the midst of a boiling mass of barbarians, the Comes of Linnius and his eight regiments - twenty-four centuries - of cavalry charged from all points of the compass and drove the Picts to scattered flight.

The first phase of the plan had succeeded. The combined army now needed to herd the Picts north.

Maybe Arthur hadn't been needed after all.

The men came running out of the house screaming.

Arthur had crossed the wall at Carlisle and started heading east. Once across the border he had sent messages to <the other regional governor> to coordinate his actions and find who was friend and who was with the enemy. Wherever he had found enemy or enemy sympathizers, he had burnt farmsteads, rounded up livestock and killed indiscriminately. This was, in the words of the military tactician Agrippa, a "punishment expedition". There was no intent to calm, to control or to hold. No effort to "win hearts and minds". The sole intent of this incursion north of the border was to inflame and enrage the locals into either fighting him at a place of his choosing, or deciding right now that they would never fight him, ever again. He didn't really care which, as long as they feared him and his ability to destroy their livelihoods.

"Kill them," he shouted to his men and quickly Quintus took a squad of eight off, using their lances to skewer the three unarmed men. Their house continued to burn and Arthur and his men watched until they were content that nobody was left inside.

"Move out," he ordered and they formed up and rode off.

Not every house, barn and farm was destroyed; there simply wasn't the time. But across a five-mile front, the three columns of men burnt and destroyed everything that they came across and killed anybody they could find who didn't have the sense - or ability - to flee or find a secure hiding place. Each one killed here was one less to be killed in battle, although, if he were to be totally honest, Arthur would have had to admit that there were almost no warriors here. They had all headed south - the only thing that had made this punishment raid possible.

"Come on, come on," he called and spurred eastwards.

Arthur knew that his four regiments were not much to take on the might of the Pict nation, but he also knew that numbers were not everything. After all, he was facing a mad, enraged enemy who had recently been defeated and felt betrayed, who were returning from an expected rout to face their homes burning and who just wanted blood. Men who balked at planning even when they had all winter to do it. *Divide et Impera* as the saying went. Confidence might be a two-edged sword, but confidence in your own competence was a different matter. And he and his men *were* competent; they knew what they were doing and had a good plan.

It was a simple plan: break the enemy up into small, ineffective units round them up, encircle them and run them down. In some ways, it couldn't fail. It was just a question of killing and demoralizing enough of them that he could retreat back south of the wall without running into the same challenge they had right now: being in enemy-held territory in full retreat.

The key was finding the right ground to fight this battle. Too open and the numbers could possibly count against him; too wooded and his cavalry would be unable to deploy. The right ground would enable him enough room to deploy while keeping the battlefield broken up. A hill would be good. In a forest. With gentle slopes broken up by defiles. Where? Where?

He kept riding and kept looking.

"This one speaks British."

He referred of course to the native language of Britain. Arthur spoke it fluently, as did most of the "Romans" although they generally spoke Latin to other civilized people. Many of the British peasants only spoke the language, and while they spoke a related language, most of the Picts that they had come across were unintelligible. If he'd had the time to properly prepare this campaign, he would have tried to find someone who spoke the language as an interpreter. They had several who spoke Saxon back at Badonicus, but neither there nor either of his brief stops - in Chester and Carlisle - had he managed to track down a native Pict speaker.

Arthur rode over, eager to interrogate him.

"You know who we are?" A nod. "You know what we are doing here?" Another nod. He might speak some British but was either uncomfortable in the language or just not a great communicator. I wonder if he has any friends, Arthur thought absently.

"We are looking for a place. A clearing in the woods. We want a hill and we want it craggy. Can you tell us of a place?"

"Why? Why help I you? You kill us. You burn."

True enough, thought Arthur. But you'll help us because you won't have any choice.

"Do you want to die? Painfully? You can tell us what we want to know and live; or hold it from us and die painfully, right here, right now."

The man seemed to consider this. It really wasn't much of a choice.

"And we will probably find what we need anyway."

The man looked at Arthur, hate burning in his eyes.

"Ride north," he said. "Two miles, three, the woods end. You'll know. What you want, I don't know. But it's there. Hill in the woods. Grassy. Cait Celidon."

Arthur and Quintus exchanged glances. He might be lying. He might not. But it was enough to save his life. If he was lying and they came back this way, they would kill him.

Arthur waved the men forward, riding north.

They burst out of the treeline.

They had been riding uphill for the past hour or so. Certainly more than two or three miles and Arthur had increasingly worried that the man had lied. But the uphill had been good news: ride far enough uphill and you will get to the summit. Only then will you know if it is clear or wooded.

But as they came out into the weak afternoon sunshine, Arthur marvelled. The terrain was perfect. Ahead was the crest, a pointed crag. Between him and the summit was a natural breastwork: oh, yes, his men could spend the next two days readying for the battle improving it, but it was exactly what he needed. To the left and right, arms splayed out, making the approach look tempting - until you found yourself funnelled in with no room to move.

And then the forest, so close and ideal for deploying the rear-attack ambush.

Only one challenge remaining: get them to come here.

He signalled to the bugler who sounded "Form up, parade square" over and over. His men, spread over miles, would take an hour or more to assemble after hearing the signal to assemble on the bugler, but he wasn't going to wait. His personal command generally had the easiest of it, so he would get them to work straight away.

"Quintus - that embrasure: it will be stronger than the walls of Rome by sundown day after next. Take the first half of this regiment and get digging. I'll get you relief tomorrow, but for tonight you're it. Dig all night, we don't have time to waste. Don't forget to pile up any useful-sized rocks you hack up or move for the artillery.

"Cato - supplies. There has to be food out there. Go looking for it; split up if you can but *do not* get isolated, trapped or killed. They'll be out there somewhere and my nose says they'll be here in two or three days, so take care. When you've taken everything you can find, burn everything but *don't* kill anyone. Tell them to go south and if they come north we *will* kill them. I want them to be a signal to all the men coming north. And make sure you spread out in a funnel and get those fires to burn high and bright.

"Cornelius - take two squads and get hurrying south. Don't bother about burning anything close to here; Cato has that covered. I want to know when and where the enemy are and when they're coming. Quintus doesn't need his horses for now, so use those to set up a basic pony express between here and wherever you get to. And the same as for Cato: *don't* get cut off; *don't* get killed. We're few enough as it is; we need every man we've got when they finally come up here.

"Caecilius - we need artillery. Plenty of wood down here in the forest. Take from there and there," he said, pointing. "We'll keep those other areas dense for hiding the cavalry and we'll get the skirmishers to lead the Picts in through the central area. Clear? Four trebuchets and eight scorpions should do the trick. And lots of missiles. Also, work with Quintus to prepare trebuchet rounds. Good."

He looked around. In every direction the men were moving to their assigned tasks. No haste, no panic; just quiet efficiency. They were Romans; they knew what to do.

Three days later, the landscape was transformed. Many of the trees at the edge of the forest had been chopped down; the embrasure had been turned into a fortress with a six-foot ditch and a twenty-foot high wall. The wall reached between the two spurs of rock coming down to east and west. Two gates were placed in the wall close to either end. The eastern gate was closed and barred already, while the western gate was wide open with a "bridge" of planed pine logs laid across it. Ditches had been dug at what seemed random angles across the valley and "enhanced" with timber walls. Range markers had been placed all over the valley, their purpose obscure to anybody who had not done the requisite basic Roman army training.

Arthur sat his horse in the middle of the valley and looked around. Yes, everything was ready. The enemy was audible now, coming through the forest. Quintus' skirmishers were leading them here, apparently retreating from the enemy's superior force. Meanwhile the bugler was sounding call after call, seemingly to organize the retreat but in reality just to make sure that even the laggards in the Pict army kept coming the right way.

Cato looked at the fort. "It's impressive. We would be able to hold that for weeks with enough supplies."

"That's the way it's supposed to look," said Arthur. "I wonder whether they'll bother to dig in themselves, or just assume their numbers are enough and just settle down in the valley?"

"Against one hundred men? I would expect them just to try a frontal assault."

Arthur turned and stared at Cato. "Really?" He looked at the fortification again. "Really? Down a six foot trench, lined with obstacles and then up a thirty foot sheer cliff? Are you insane?"

"No," replied Cato, controlled and sober. "But they might be."

Arthur looked at him and nodded. He had made a fair point. Time to go. Arthur rode down and to the west; Cato rode to the east. All would probably be decided in the next few hours.

Cornelius led his men at a full gallop across the valley. If they were shocked by its transformation, they gave no hint of it. Quintus took in the range and trail markers at a glance and unerringly led his men through one of the prepared cavalry routes to the top. Once there, his men went over the lowered pine bridge through the west gate. When all his twenty-four men were across, the bridge was pulled in, the gate closed and secured.

The first Picts had come charging out into the valley, chasing the retreating men. As they burst out of the trees, they stopped, involuntarily. Surely they had just left the fortifications at York? And yet, here was a defensive position almost as strong as the one they had left behind - in the middle of their homeland. This was intolerable.

And then, almost as one, they shook off the shock and charged. Across the prepared ground.

"Wait for it, wait for it, you bloodsuckers. Wait for them to pass the red ones." Quintus had his eyes on the range markers as did all the defenders. Some were manning the walls, but they had the easy job for now, especially since the gates had been closed. The artillery was where the action was.

The Picts were lost in confusion in the battlefield. If you knew the routes, or could read the markers, there were four fairly straight routes between the forest and the fortress. But if you didn't know what you were doing, it could almost seem like you were on islands in the midst of a volcano. And the Picts had no clue.

For Quintus, the key to the defence was to allow as many Picts onto the battlefield as possible without actually allowing them the opportunity to properly deploy, dig in, organize or attack. Basically, to keep them on their toes and stop them from being able to concentrate on attacking his position, which was strong, but not invincible. A well-disciplined attack force could fill in the ditches in the valley, chop down their own wood to build a ramp or siege towers, or flank their position up either of the mountain spurs. Quintus didn't think that any of these things were in his enemies' minds, but it was better to stop anything occuring to them.

The leading men had made it through to being within range, past the red markers. There was still no clear organization out there - not that Quintus was expecting any. But they were close enough now to start charging and possibly hurling missiles. The time had come.

"Trebuchets, release." Men cut the ends of the cords and the four giant machines launched their missiles. They arced gracefully over the battlefield and crashed down amidst the horde of men on the field, just at they'd planned it. The crews immediately went to work winding them back up, reattaching the cables and loading the next projectile.

"Scorpions. As you mark." The scorpions, more direct and accurate than the trebuchets, were really like giant bows. They had ranged off in practice and knew exactly where they would fire. No point shooting if there was nobody standing right there. The eight guns fired as the opportunities presented themselves and rapidly reloaded; started a continual rain of missiles across the battlefield. I hope we made enough, thought Quintus. You really could never have too many.

The battle was starting to be joined now.

It still wasn't really a fair fight, and from Arthur's vantage point in the forest, it wasn't really clear whether it was a fight or just a lot of men milling around waiting to be killed. The leading elements were at the ditch now, caught in the classic dilemma: do I go down when I want to go up? or do I stay here, a target but almost unable to do anything about it.

This is where the intelligent man presumably thinks to himself, "I should have brought something to put in this ditch, or across it," he thought. The prepared man, of course, would in fact have brought something. For himself, Arthur wouldn't have gone anywhere near that fortification for a couple of days. But then, if they weren't barbarians, they would be part of Roman Britain and not fighting us. And then the Saxons wouldn't be here and we would all be happy.

His biggest concern was that all the men had gathered here now. No big deal if a couple of hundred stragglers were left behind; they would probably be the weakest and least brave and would run away rather than fight. But a couple of thousand men in his rear when he attacked *could* be a problem. He wanted to ask for help - he'd love to know what Quintus thought from his much better vantage point - but this was his command, his battle - his decision.

"Julius, what would you do?" he murmured, then took his life in his hands, literally.

"Charge!"

The men burst out of the forest in three lines; the formation Arthur had decided on within minutes of planning this battle and that they had practised four times a day since. No battle ever went exactly according to plan, and Arthur had no delusions that this one would be any different. But they were ready; they knew what they were doing; and the ground had been prepared. He looked to his right and saw Cato leading the charge from the forest to the east. Good man! he thought. To have used the bugle would have been to give away something happening in the rear, and that he could not afford. Cato would have known the situation just like Arthur did, but he still had to wait for Arthur to move before moving himself.

He felt the shock as his lance crashed into the back of the first man as he rode up behind him, the full weight of the horse behind the thrust. He stopped and pulled the lance back out and charged again. All around him his men were doing the same, Picts dying without knowing why or how. They were turning now, starting to ready themselves, full of blood lust but not organized. Never organized. Arthur's men knew what they were about, knew the ground, knew their tactics. Some died under lance and spear, some were pushed into the gullies and ditches, and others died under the relentless hail of missiles from the wall.

Obviously, the battle could not be won by cavalry alone.

But that had never been the plan. The plan was to use the cavalry to bring chaos to the battlefield and to *turn* the enemy around. The bravest men, the strongest, the most daring, the most talented, all moved to the front. They were the men facing Quintus; the men at the back were making up the numbers: too young, too old, too weak, too cowardly to be real soldiers. Arthur cut them down like the sheep they were and in six lines cut his way through the prepared routes. He was vulnerable to an attack from behind - if the Picts still had enough brave enough men in the woods - but he was also vulnerable to his own success: sooner or later he would cut through enough of the fodder to get to the real warriors. Time to retreat.

The bugler sounded "fall back; reform fifty yards" and the men fell back in good order. No rush, no chaos. The pressure relieved, the Picts started to re-form themselves and to form a good battle line. Given time, they would learn, Arthur knew, and resolved to not give them time. Another trebuchet strike came down in the midst of the enemy, adding to the chaos.

Now the leading men were pushing through the horde, trying to form up and get to grips with an enemy not behind twenty-foot ramparts. But their way was hampered by the men in between, the ditches and the continual artillery strikes. But they were successful in clearing away the area immediately in front of the walls.

Quintus gave the signal and the two gates were opened in unison and the bridges lowered across them. All the men not working the artillery ran down the bridges on the double and formed a shield wall across the neck of the battlefield.

And the classic Roman infantry meat-grinding machine went to work.

In the end, Arthur and Cato were forced to sound "run away" - that is, full retreat to prepared positions. The pressure from the retreating Picts had become so intense that it was about to turn to rout and that would have cost Arthur too many men. But "run away" did not mean they were giving in; rather, that they were retreating to prepared positions to the sides of the ravine. From here, they would watch any Picts who were truly running away head south; but if any tried to form up and resist, they would charge in skirmish order, stopping effective resistance and driving the men south. Not that Arthur really wanted them to go back south - the way his men would need to go themselves - but it was the only way out of this trap.

And flee the men did. As the pressure from in front was released, and the meat-grinder kept grinding from behind, men threw away swords, shields, packs, armour - anything that would slow them down as they ran away.

As the last of the Picts fled, Quintus and Arthur greeted each other on the bloody battlefield. "I would say we should clean this mess up," said Arthur. "But I feel the need to get back to Linnius before it becomes Saxon."

London

AD425

History has a habit of repeating itself.

Rome had been a Republic for centuries before Pompey and Caesar's titanic struggle turned an essentially civilian society with distributed powers into a state of personal loyalty. And when the very fabric of that society was threatened, Caesar's heir, Octavian, concentrated all the power into a single pair of hands - his own - even while keeping faith with the "forms" of the Republic.

Britain had made it about fifteen years of being an independent Republic before much the same forces led to much the same result.

There was little doubt that two men stood head and shoulders above the rest in terms of both *auctorias* - personal clout and straightforward military competence. Ambrosius Aurelianus, the first senior Consul, was one; Quintus Domitius Vitalinus was the other. Vitalinus was younger than Aurelianus, but since his election as senior praetor in 418 had taken the British world by storm. As praetor for Chester, he had led campaign after campaign against the Irish invaders in Ordovica, winning more battles than he lost. At the end of his year, he returned in triumph to London, where he was applauded and decorated. Official triumphs were not given in Britain - but then they hadn't really been given in Rome for the past four centuries either - but the "ovation" had been retained, and Vitalinus won one, as had Aurelianus eight years earlier.

Two years of vigorous campaigning in the Senate followed, leading up to the job he coveted: Consul of Britain. Once again, he chose to fight the Irish in Ordovica, this time taking a Consular army to the task. How much the British army had been reduced over the years was evidenced by the inability of even this force under a commander brimming with energy and enthusiasm to permanently dislodge the Irish from their mountain redoubts.

Retired once again to the front bench of Consulars in the Senate, he continued to fight for more action, more taxes, more recruitment, more training, more logistical support. He had one vocal supporter, Aurelianus, but many a detractor. It was too easy to paint a caricature of the glory commander, interested in nothing but winning battles and gathering power to himself. On the other hand, the majority of Lords in the Senate, coming from secure south-western holdings that hadn't seen an attack in the past four hundred years since Vespasian had brought the II legion's siege train through the district, were perfectly happy to cede an inconsequential part of a rugged terrain which nobody really wanted anyway to these foreigners. "Give them time, and they'll settle down and become good neighbors," as Titus Fulvius senior used to say. "It's not worth the time and money to evict them. Where are you going to get the troops anyway? Off our land. No. It is *not* happening. Not on my watch."

And so he floundered for many years. Yet, they were never years of real peace. Every year brought some other attack from some direction. The Irish continued to raid across the sea and bring reinforcements to their fledgling kingdom amongst the Ordovices; the Saxons raided the coast, often inflicting significant damage, killing, looting and plundering; and the Picts crossed the wall in sufficient strength to lay waste to much of the north.

For every Aurelianus or Vitalinus that obtained the consular power, there was a completely inept nobody who was awarded the same job. In 425, Lucius Fabius Maximus and Gnaeus Marcellus managed to both make it to the top at the same time. That might have ended well, except that the Picts chose that year to attack in force, and by sea, bypassing all the defensive structures that had been put in place by Theodosius almost a half-century before.

Attacking at will down the east coast, they bypassed several layers of defences and destroyed others. The signal and warning stations down the east coast were destroyed, and the Picts landed in force in the lands of the Iceni, working their way quickly to the Icknield Way; from here Verulanium was a short hop.

Fabius led the main mobile force to meet this threat, and went down badly, losing his own life - no great loss - along with five hundred others in a military reverse the country could not handle. Marcellus was sent to his aid with the backup force and what he could gather together of the remnants of Fabius' force. And went down so badly that he committed suicide on the field as his forces scattered.

In panic, the Senate met and conferred an extraordinary command on Vitalinus, making him effectively dictator. He gathered what troops he could and, in a lightning march, beat the invaders to Verulanium and whipped them soundly. They retreated, but only as far as the coast, where they started to dig in.

Vitalinus returned to London and summoned the Senate. "We have waited and waited and have not acted. You allowed incompetents like Fabius and Marcellus to lead armies and they have lost them. We no longer have the manpower in reserve to evict the Picts from their base on the coast without opening the whole of the west to the Irish. Ideas anyone?" He flung his arm out in a rhetorical gesture indicating that he imagined nobody would have any ideas at all.

It is said that the bad blood between the two great leaders - the rift that eventually sparked into open warfare - came from the moment that Aurelianus stood up. Probably, though, the causes were deeper; a more fundamental difference in their worldviews.

"We have enough men right now to hold them," argued Aurelianus quietly. "You have shown that in charge of this scratch force you can effectively defend the republic. Bottle them up on the coastline of the Iceni and they will probably soon tire of it and go home. Give them some gold and they will probably go sooner.

"At the same time, I can go down to the West Country and start a conscription of all males between 17 and 25. Within three months I could have an army ready that would be sufficient to drive the Picts into the sea if they haven't already seen the sense of leaving."

Men in the benches howled outrage. A conscription of all young men in the fields just to achieve in three months what could easily be had by waiting a year or two? And the very thought of paying them to leave - wouldn't that just make them come again and again for free money?

Vitalinus smiled at the outrage. In one way, he agreed with Aurelianus; had considered suggesting the same thing himself, but had seen the political suicide in entailed. Only a fool would align himself against the vested interests of the rich landlords.

"There is another way; a way that does not involve paying Picts to come here and loot and pillage; nor does it involve the sacrifice of this year's harvest.

"Across the sea are many sailors who would be happy to take a crack at these Picts. I'm almost surprised they haven't done it already, to be honest. To natural sailors, the Picts are sitting ducks there on the coast."

His words sank in slowly. Under the honeyed words and the seductive thought of not having to conscript workers was the sharp sword of betrayal: Vitalinus could only be talking about doing a deal with the Saxons. How could he? They were the enemy.

Moments of silence gave way to more howls of outrage. "Traitor! Betrayal! How could you?" rang out around the meeting hall. Vitalinus soaked it all up and waited for it to burn out and then strode confidently down the hall towards the imposing double doors.

"Your choice, my Lords. I say that this is the right way, the expeditious way, to proceed. Yes, we could achieve the same thing on our own, with our own resources, but at much greater expense. We already have all the tools, all the structures. We invite in 300 trained sailors, we allocate them ports on say - Thanet Island - we billet them under the normal provisioning laws for military on the move. The cost would be a fraction of what it would take to deprive our economy of a similar number of men, let alone train and equip them. And, moreover, we would be getting *expert* sailors. It is a bargain, my lords, and you are fools not to see it."

"It is a bargain, I agree," said Aurelianus, standing again as was his right as a Consular. "It is a bargain with the gods of the underworld. Once here, they will always be here; we will never dislodge them. They will come and their friends will come and they will swallow us up. What have we being doing all these years if not trying to displace the Irish from Ordovica? Trying to deny them a bridgehead on our island. And now you want to offer the Saxons - who you admit are better fighters - just that bridgehead. No, this is not a good deal. Any of the other options would be better."

Heads nodded around the chamber. The Saxons had been raiding for years and were a big threat; inviting them in was asking for trouble and to be overrun. But were the other options better? Were they even really options? The cost ...

"Well," said Vitalinus. "You instructed me to see to the defence of the state. I say that this is the only way in which I can carry out that charge. Accede to my wishes, or relieve me of my responsibility and look to your own laurels. The door is here, I can walk out if that is your wish."

Put like that, there was no choice. Even Aurelianus had said that his plan depended on the energy and genius of Vitalinus to bottle the Picts up for three months. There was little for it but to give in.

"Not that I like it," confided Fulvius to Aurelianus. "I think your plan was better, for all the cost. I fear we will come to rue this day. If nothing else, I think that man means to be king over us."

"King? What is this king? He wishes to be more than King over us, he means to be King over the Saxons as well."

"An over-king. A good name. Vortigern it is." And the nickname stuck.

Within weeks, Vortigern had done his deals and Hengest had been settled on Thanet Island with his "cousin" - a phrase that could mean anything with these Germans from brother to my wife's best friend - Horsa along with three ships full of men. Two weeks later they attacked the Picts from the sea while Vortigern led what native troops he had into battle from the landward side and utterly crushed the resistance. With nowhere to run, the Picts were annihilated or taken captive and turned into slaves to work the tin mines in Dumnonia.

"Good work, well done, Hengest. Now, as to the future ..."

Within days, more deals were struck, and over the coming months another ten crews arrived, to be stationed up and down the east coast. The "Great Raid" of 425 had demonstrated that the defences of the north simply weren't good enough to handle a determined seaborne attack. To be sure, the raid had ultimately failed, and the remnant of the raiders eliminated, but there were stil plenty of places where it was possible to come ashore.

Up and down the east coast, Vortigern built forts and ports and billeted a crew or two of his new allies along with their ships on the local residents. Uncouth and violent, they were not popular; nor was paying for them popular with locals or those further afield. But while the fear that the losses of Fabius and Marcellus had sustained was fresh in the mind, the money kept coming. The money was there, no doubt about it, but convincing the Senate year in and year out to devote it to taxes for defence was no easy matter. Even if that defence came at a discount when paying barbarians to do it rather than citizens.

And they answered to Vortigern, personally.

"You know the formula, Quintus Domitius," intoned Titus Fulvius pedantically at a meeting of the Senate held that December. "You are empowered to use all means necessary to defend the republic. We agree your success has been stunning. But it is, without question, a success. And now you must resign your extraordinary powers and hold elections for a new set of magistrates and return Britain to its proper government."

"No," replied Vortigern, without even bothering to stand.

"On what grounds? The republic has been defended. Even without an explicit term limit, your authority ends when the republic is safe. And the republic is safe. We can all see that."

"I disagree. The republic is not safe."

"How so? The Picts are annihilated or enslaved. How can they be a threat? The army is restored, if not to full strength, at least to a fighting force, and your Saxons defend our coastline."

"Until every Irishman has been evicted from our western hills, and until the threat of the Picts is finally ended, I cannot agree that we are safe. Even then, we need to build up our strength against further encroachment of barbarians from the continent."

"But *you* invited them here. You cannot call them a threat! That would be nonsense."

"Clearly our allies cannot be a threat. I speak of the others, the Angles, the Jutes, the Frisians, that we have not invited here. Still, they wish to flee the depradations of the Huns who they all fear, and presumably some day these Huns, too, will want to come here and take our green and pleasant land. Which of these threats do you not see? Are you blind?"

"Quintus Domitius," admonished Merula, leader of the house. "You will obey the forms of politeness."

Vortigern acknowledged the rebuke with a slight nod of his head, then looked back at Fulvius, expectantly.

"They may be a threat. But the Picts have been a threat for a thousand years but not even the skill of Hadrianus or Agricola could defeat them. The normal forms of government can contain these long-term threats over the long term. I demand that you resign and call elections immediately."

"Again, I say no. You may view the threat to the republic as long term, but I view it as real, existential and immanent. Depose me, and you will live to regret it."

Ultimately, Vortigern won the argument. If not by force of rhetoric, by force. When the Senate next met, two days later, it did so with Hengest and fifty of his Saxon warriors in attendance as Vortigern's personal bodyguard. When Vortigern moved for a division on the subject of the end of the state of emergency, any Senator who looked outside and considered for a moment how he would make it home alive, decided that there was, at the very least, a state of personal emergency that was very real and very immanent. And that the only thing to do was to pass to the right of the tribunal and accede to Vortigern becoming "Emperor Britannico", much as Octavian had five centuries earlier.

As Emperor, he moved quickly to do those things that he could not have done under the state of emergency: he invited two Frisians - Octha and Ebissa - and their retainers - some 500 in all - and gave them land north of Hadrian's wall, along with licence to do anything they wanted north of the border, promising them full logistical support from the bases at the wall as well as from Theodosius' buffer kingdoms. It was not a large force, but well dug in on the eastern coastline, supplied by their countrymen as well as the British, and able to raid both on land and at sea at will, it became a major thorn in the flesh of the Picts.

When buying allies for the defence of the republic, Vortigern paid with cash and land from the general fund. But for his next project, he needed Hengest's help with no long-term benefit.

"What I would like to do," he told Hengest through the interpreter Ceretic, "is to attack the Irish in Ireland. Attack is the best defence and all that. I don't imagine that it will be possible to make things so bad that our Irish will up and go home, but at least it would be good to stop any more coming over."

"You want to give bases on west coast?" asked Ceretic.

"No, no, you can work from here, or from your bases across the channel. You can settle in Ireland if you want, but I cannot support you there as I did in the North. I want you to raid Ireland, kill the Irish and make them stay home and look to their own defence. While you are doing that, I will try and evict the ones who are already here."

"What you offer me?" asked Hengest through Ceretic.

"All the plunder you can take."

Hengest laughed as Ceretic translated. "But what *you* offer me? Plunder I take, I take. What you give me more."

"I have no more," admitted Vortigern. "I can only give what I have."

"You have wife?" asked Hengest.

"No, my wife died four years ago," responded Vortigern.

"I have daughter, beautiful daughter. She now your wife. For this I do you say."

Vortigern considered, carefully keeping the disgust from his face. Marry a barbarian? Was it possible? What would the Senate say. Yet, it was a small price to pay. He could put her in one of his villas with some Saxon slaves and nobody would ever know the difference.

"Agreed," he replied. "I will marry your daughter."

4. Portchester

AD480

Nothing is ever easy.

By the time Arthur had returned to Linnius, basking in the laurels of victory, the Saxons had overrun the outer defences and the siege was in full swing. Taking advantage of the element of surprise, Arthur had swung down the river and attacked the Saxons, driving them back onto their side of the river and relieving the siege. Over the following year, some amount of normality had been restored: the units in front of Linnius were holding the line again and the legions were back in their barracks near the wall.

As autumn turned to winter in the year of our Lord 479, Arthur and his men finally returned to Mons Badonicus, tired and weary, but content with what they had achieved over the course of eighteen months.

They returned to a different environment.

Cerdic, one of Arthur's alleged allies, had decided to branch out on his own, and agree a treaty of peace with the Saxons. In a small way, it made sense: without Arthur's forces in place to go on the offensive, Cerdic had been under daily attack without the ability to effectively resist. Furthermore, four more crews had come ashore to the east, reinforcing Aelle's band considerably. Seemingly out of options, Cerdic had capitulated rather than endure until Arthur might return. Or might not.

Within days of returning, Arthur called a meeting of the council.

"There is no way we can tolerate this. It is worse than the Picts attacking. At least we know they are enemies; this is supposed to be an ally."

"What did you expect him to do?" Titus Fulvius asked. "You were off, playing the boy hero and getting all the glory, and he was having his people killed on a daily basis with no defence. What could he do?"

"He had the citizen guard. What are they for if not to defend the citizenry against attack? Why do I have to do everything?" he fumed, unreasonably. "You may view me as having wandered off seeking glory, but I tell you, we have dealt with the Picts for a generation. If we can deal with the Saxons, we could restore Roman Britain in our lifetime."

A pipe dream; they all knew it. But did Arthur know it, and cynically exploit it, or did he really think it was possible. Did he not see the country fragmenting around him? But he probably did: that was why he was so irate about what Cerdic had done. If Cerdic were to get away with it, then the habit might spread. Before you knew it, the entity that Arthur saw as "Britain" and that now was realistically two - Britain and Angle-land - could become fractured into a host of petty domains ruled by self-appointed tyrants like the ones Theodosius had installed north of the border. If Arthur really dreamed of "Britain", then he would have to act. But attack a fellow Briton? That way madness lay.

"There are no good options, Arthur. Think carefully before you act," injected Mardoc. "If you fight him, you could break up the republic sooner than by letting it splinter by itself. Remember the true enemy."

"I remember the true enemy, Mardoc. I don't need to remind you who killed my parents. But does Cerdic remember? I cannot attack the Saxons without driving through Cerdic's lands, and I cannot go through his lands without his support. And I cannot have his support while he maintains neutrality. No, Mardoc, what he has done cannot be tolerated. We must act, and we must act promptly. By spring, we must in position to attack the Saxons, and if that means we must first destroy Cerdic, so be it.

"But let us use our time wisely. I will ride west to meet with the Senate. They will pass the resolution that we need declaring Cerdic outlaw for selling parts of the republic. We will pass that far and wide as both cover for our actions and to dissuade others from considering the same. I will think and I will take counsel and in the spring we will have and plan, and then we will act. Until then, Cerdic has four months to consider his position and change his mind. Quintus!"

"Yes, sire."

"You were once comrades with Cerdic were you not? Did you not serve together years ago?"

"I did, sire. I count him still my friend and would be sorry to war against him, but if that is what you command, sire, so will I do."

"I may or I may not. But for now, Quintus, I want you to ride east. Ride east and see Cerdic. He may decide that his best policy is to realign himself with us, now that we are returned. He may see the error of his ways, or he may even wish to say that it was just a stalling manoeuvre to give us time to return from the north. Do you see what I am saying, Quintus?"

"Yes, sire."

"Well, get going. If you can convince him of the error of his ways, let me know before the Ides of January. It is then that I will convene the Senate to indict on charges of treason. Be clear to him: I mean full treason, *hostilius*; not just malefaction. He will be outcast and enemy of the state, to be hunted down *personally*. I want no doubt about this message: I will completely believe him if he says before the Ides that he was just buying us time; I will completely destroy him if he does not."

"Yes, sire."

Arthur mulled the wine Merula had given him.

While he did indeed intend to call the Senate into session, Arthur's primary motive for coming west was to seek counsel with Merula. He not only had a lifetime's experience of diplomacy and military leadership, he was well-versed in all the classics and had a thought process that Arthur preferred to think of as "deep" but could possibly be more accurately described as "twisted". Arthur had no desire to declare Cerdic *hostis*; much less to waste precious lives fighting a civil war. As Britons, they should clearly be on the same side. Why could Cerdic not see that?

Because see it he could not. A message had arrived the previous day from Quintus saying that it was not a question of form of words, or of fear, but simply he saw no reason for him to not be "governor" of his district, at peace with both Aelle to the east and Arthur to the west. And if he could manage that, then maybe it would offer hope for the rest of the country as to how to live in peace. Because peace is what serves the peasants, not the continual destruction of their crops and buildings.

An opinion about which Arthur had expressed his opinion. Vituperatively.

"You are yet young and impetuous," chided Merula. "I don't think you see the big picture."

Arthur was too angry at this point for one of Merula's philosophical discourses and told him so. He had work to do.

"Yes, but what if you do the wrong work?"

"You think Cerdic is right? We should declare peace for as long as it suits Aelle and then let him roll over us when he's stronger? Isn't that *exactly* what Vortigern did that got us into this mess in the first place? Would Caesar have done that? Octavian?"

"You could say that Octavian did do it. He allowed Antonius to hang himself, if you recall. Patience, my son, patience. Ask yourself: is Cerdic really the enemy?"

"Yes."

"Sorry, I didn't mean 'just say yes without thinking about it'; I meant, 'ask yourself' as in 'think about this deeply for a while'. You never know, you might have missed something."

Once again, Arthur was struck by how hard he found it to think rationally when his blood was boiling and his emotions were running riot. How *could* Merula sit there so calmly playing with Britain like it was of no import?

He struggled to think, but nothing would come. Obviously somebody who stood in opposition to his plans was the enemy. That was basically the definition of the word. That was why Arthur wanted him declared *hostis*: a public enemy.

"What is the real goal?" Merula prompted, gently.

"To kill Saxons and restore Britain to proper Roman rule."

"Is that one goal, or two?"

Arthur thought. Surely they were inseparable. But in one sense, they were two goals. But how could he restore Roman rule without killing the Saxons.

"Possibly two. But inextricably linked."

"And if you could have just one, which would it be?"

Instinctively Arthur knew the right answer but mulled over the wrong one for a long while. Much of his desire to kill Saxons did not arise from the desire for justice or proper government but from simple revenge: the desire to kill the men who had killed his parents. How much did that obstruct him in actually doing his duty: his first duty - to protect the innocent and ensure justice for all. Was Cerdic right about that?

"It would have to be restoring Roman rule," he finally admitted.

"In that case, can you leverage this situation to make that happen?"

Arthur blinked. The thought was immense; bigger by far than his ability to process it. Could he use this rebellion to trick Aelle in some way? If so, what? And could he do it without Cerdic's cooperation, which seemed impossible to obtain?

Arthur thought until his head hurt, but nothing he could do could shift the mental blocks.

"No, Socrates, you will have to show me."

"I am sure you can solve it by yourself, my pupil. But let me ask you a few questions."

As it had ever since Merula became his parent cum guardian cum tutor, the game of Socratic dialogue never failed to relax Arthur: the questions, cunningly worded, drove the listener down an inexorable chain of logic by their precise nature. And yet, at the end, you could never really deny that you had "thought of it yourself". You certainly hadn't been told the answer.

"So, how many men would you be able to deploy against Cerdic?"

"Well, basically the four regiments at Badonicus."

"You wouldn't recruit more from the west country?"

"No, I don't think so."

"I don't think we'd really need them. You see, Cerdic doesn't have that many troops at his disposal, just the supply unit at Clausentum."

"I see," said Merula.

"So do I," echoed Arthur, letting out a low sigh. "I hadn't thought of that."

He knew, of course, that Cerdic had few or no troops. It had been a concern all the time he had been in the north and was, to a large extent, a proximate cause of the current crisis: Cerdic would probably not have turned on him had he been able to defend himself properly without Arthur's support. It had also been a consideration when deciding to issue the writ of *hostilius*; you don't go to war with somebody who will easily beat you.

But what he hadn't considered was that, in saying *no* to Arthur's olive branch to recant his defection, Cerdic must have *known* that Arthur was serious and *would* attack; and, as Arthur had just thought, you don't go to war with somebody who will easily beat you.

So Cerdic must believe that there was a way that Arthur would *not* easily beat him. He could, of course, issue a conscription of all his young men, but if he were going to do that, he could have done it two years ago and defended himself against Aelle. So, the only remaining possibility was that Cerdic was going to ask Aelle for help in fighting Arthur. *Hostis* indeed.

But more importantly, it meant that Saxon troops would cross the Arun - in numbers - to assist their new ally. And would come and fight Arthur on ground of his choosing. Well, not exactly, but he *would* choose the ground, and they would fight, and they would die. Why? Because he was better.

A low buzz sounded across the chamber.

The Ides had come, and Arthur had summoned the Senate. They all knew what Arthur was going to demand, and fully expected to issue the *hostilius* decree.

What they hadn't expected was Arthur to make this demand for a conscription.

"We've been through this so many times. We don't want to fight civil wars at the best of times, and we certainly don't want to impoverish the entire state to do so. What Cerdic has proposed is entirely reasonable. Live and let live. If he is prepared to act as a buffer zone against the Saxons, let's take that offer."

Ready and willing for this line of argument, Arthur had no difficulty keeping calm. "If he were, there might be some merit in it. But he is not a neutral buffer zone *against* the Saxons. He has chosen to side *with* the Saxons. We cannot allow them to just keep taking land piecemeal. Sooner or later this council hall will be Saxon too. What will you do then? Retreat to Dumnonia? And when they push you into the sea?

"Or is your plan to follow your erstwhile exemplars and flee to Armorica? If so, going now while it is still not in the hands of the Goths might be a good idea.

"On the other hand, if you want your children to grow up knowing what it is like to live under Roman law, you need to act *now*. In a few years it will be too late. They will take and hold, take and hold. That is their way. The more land they have, the more places they can land reinforcements. We can't stop them coming, and if we can't get to their bases we can't stop them landing. So the only thing we can do is stop them at the borders. The Arun is the border."

"So is the Dubglas around Linnius, but you seem prepared to sacrifice that."

A point on which Arthur knew he was weak and would have to cede ground. That this situation had arisen out of his attempts to keep Linnius did not alter the fact that the situation there was still precarious and the troops he had and was trying to raise could make a big difference there.

"I cannot be everywhere at once, and we simply don't have the troop numbers to do everything."

"Once again, you come back to demanding more troops. It seems that you will not be happy until the whole country is under arms."

"I will not be happy until all the Saxons have been evicted from these shores and we are once again masters of our own destiny," he countered. "If that requires us to temporarily conscript every man in this country, I think it's a fair price."

"And who would feed this army of yours? This is not a century ago where troops raised in Gaul could be fed by corn raised in Britain! There is no other land to supply the army you wish to raise. We would starve."

"It is true that we would starve if every man in Britain was in the army for many years. But many men are engaged in other labours, that send food or metals overseas; or build houses and villas. And we would not starve if only some of the men were taken from the fields that grow food for those that live here."

"How many men then do you say you need?"

"A legion would be good, but I could make do with two cohorts."

"A thousand men? Impossible."

"How many men are gathered here? A hundred? Are you really saying that each of you is so impoverished you could not find ten men of military age to send off to fight to preserve the republic?"

The Senators looked around; at the floor; anywhere. None of them could accurately claim any such thing: the majority of them could have found that many just from the domestic staff that they knew by name.

"I thought not. Two cohorts it is. The men to arrive for training at Mons Badonicus no later than the Kalends of February. Each to bring - or separately to be provided with - sufficient rations for five months, to include training and the campaign. The men will be returned by the end of June, assuming that they are still alive and that there is still a republic of Britain at that time. Clear?"

There were murmurs of assent; they didn't like being talked to like this, but at the same time they recognized their own weakness in the face of the man who had the army. As always, the Senate had to face the facts: for as long as they allowed these military men, whether native, foreign or Saxon, to be in charge of the army, they were in charge of the country.

Merula visited Arthur again before he left.

"You have your plan worked out, I presume."

"Yes," replied Arthur. "Portchester, I think. How many men do you think Aelle will bring with him?"

"Now that he will hear you will have a thousand, you mean?"

"Plus the eight hundred already in my command."

"He would be mad to bring less than 3,000 then, wouldn't he?"

"Do you think he has that many?"

"Don't you?"

"Thirty ships' worth," mused Arthur. "They have been coming for years now. It's possible."

"How many men would he need to hold Cerdic's territory if he did take it? You have to presume he has too many men for his current holdings."

"Because he is spread very thin. Most of the work is done by British peasants."

"And I know that rankles with you, Arthur. But all they want is a quiet life. And to not die of starvation, of course. Which is a big incentive when it comes to getting up in the morning and ploughing a field."

"If we could wipe them out ..."

"But if he wiped you out ..."

"Then all would be lost. All Britain will one day become Saxony or Angle-land. It could happen anyway, whatever we do. We can only try and do our best. Try and stave off the inevitable for as long as we can manage."

"Cavalry can't win against infantry, you know."

"I do, indeed. As our illustrious ancestors discovered back in the days of the kings when they were surrounded by charioteers but could not afford to grow horses themselves. But cavalry only cannot win *unaided* against *organized* infantry."

"Surely you are not suggesting that Aelle will be as disorganized as the Picts?"

"Not when he forms his battle line, no. But when he's driven our infantry to rout, there's a good possibility that his organization might crumple a little. Especially if our camp were, say, over-stocked."

"So you do have a plan worked out."

"Oh, yes, very much so. As I say, Portchester."

The raw infantry formed a ragged front.

What Arthur had not elucidated was the ground near Portchester that he had decided was suitable for this battle. The barely-trained infantry that he had conscripted were six ranks deep and thus about two hundred across some hundred paces in front of their camp. In the camp another fifty men were "guarding" the baggage. The camp was close to the top of the hill and it sloped gently down all the way to the sea. The main road - and thus the way that Cerdic and Aelle's forces *must* come was another four hundred paces down that gentle slope.

The infantry was not quite as raw as it at first appeared. Along the front couple of lines, Arthur had added some steel drawn from his own mounted troops - who could all fight as infantry - and some other "volunteers" he had borrowed from around the country. After all, this was the big battle; this was where the action was going to be this year; and Arthur was fairly certain that Aelle would be doing the same - stripping other areas to boost his numbers here.

Moreover, the conscripts did not know they were as raw as they were. Arthur had judged them fit, and they assumed that meant "fully trained" and it wasn't in Arthur's interests to let them know any differently. His own men - with Bryn the senior officer in charge of this infantry rabble - knew the plan and would put it into effect: first holding the line steady and then causing them to flee at the right moment. Arthur just hoped they could do it with a minimum of casualties. As with any plan, there was always risk ...

Quintus had the skirmishing job, as he often did, since he relished that work. For two days he had been harrassing Aelle's route of march, but since he was coming along a solid Roman road he was always able to form up in line of battle and present a wall of shields to Quintus' men. The two sides exchanged missiles but little more, and little harm came from an exchange of missiles. But it lent credibility to the idea that Arthur was trying to resist.

The messengers that Quintus had sent first thing in the morning indicated that the Saxons had broken camp - not a proper Roman military camp like the one that topped the hill, but sufficient to stop Quintus from overrunning them at night - and would be here by noon. Bryn had marshalled the men and, with reasonable grace, managed to bring them out here in an emulation of battle-readiness. It would look the part until the line gave.

Aelle and his men appeared on the road below, and continued marching until they were opposite the men on the hill. Then they turned and took a few paces up the hill, and milled around, organizing themselves for the attack. Unlike disciplined Roman troops, Saxons seemed to always need to negotiate their formation, which could take hours. Since he'd decided he didn't want to spend hours with his troops getting ever more nervous, Arthur had instructed Bryn that this was the moment to hurry them along a little.

"Scorpions. Fire!"

There were no range markers here. They had known exactly where the Saxons would arrive and within a few paces where they would turn and form up. In fact, a discerning general would have noticed the apparent lack of any battlefield preparation - except for the camp of course.

Arthur had also chosen to deploy just four scorpions. It would be enough, he figured, for what he had in mind, and they would probably all be destroyed during the battle.

The bolts crashed down into the milling ranks of men, slicing straight through three men and wounding two others. More men went crashing down as the dead and wounded were knocked from their feet. The scorpion operators started cranking the giant crossbows again.

Shouts of invective and fury came from the Saxons.

It would be too much to hope that they would completely lose it and just charge up the hill as individuals; but the artillery fire achieved its objective and before the scorpions had reloaded the shield wall had formed and three thousand men, ten deep and three hundred across started moving up the hill.

Against a three-hundred-man front, Bryn had no choice but to change his own deployment and move his reserves out and widen his own lines, now dangerously thin: just four men deep to counter the Saxon's ten-man depth.

I hope Arthur knows what his doing, Bryn thought. But at least we have the advantage of the hill.

The Saxons came up the hill relentlessly but steadily. Twice more the scorpions fired and killed, but the lines formed up effortlessly and flowed around the casualties.

With ten paces to go, Aelle let out a guttural shout and the Saxons started running. Bryn responded with "Take the Hit!" and hoped that there were enough professional soldiers in the front rank to do just that.

The two shield walls crashed into each other with enormous force: fourteen men pushing with all their might in a giant melee, stabbing over, under or through the walls of shields pressed up against each other.

Here and there along the line, Saxons in the second and third ranks wielded giant axes, threatening death to those in the British front lines. On both sides, men with spears in the rear lines poked and prodded, aiming for eyes and other unprotected areas of the men in the front couple of ranks.

The pressure was inexorable. Even with the advatage of the slope, the British were slowly pushed back up the hill. And the line started to wobble.

"On my word, two steps back," commanded Bryn. "Now."

With remarkable consistency, the men stepped back two paces and relieved the pressure. In the moment before the Saxons followed, they straightened up and reformed the wall in a straight line.

Again the crash of shields as the Saxons charged to close the gap, and again the pressure slowly forced the British uphill.

And so it went for half an hour or more as casualties slowly bled the numbers on both sides. But they were higher on the British side - and more significant.

"On my word, two steps back," ordered Bryn again, "then disengage and reform at the camp. Go!"

This was a maneouvre they had practised many times but which, unbeknownst to these raw recruits, was not a major part of the Roman military manual. If called to account, Rutilius Rufus would probably have been able to remember that such a maneouvre did exist - for exigencies only - but would not have been able to recall when he or another commander had actually practised it during drill.

As the men took two steps back, the hardened warriors of Arthur's unit reformed a one-man-deep wall and slowly retreated one step at a time. Meanwhile, the rest of the men turned and ran for the four drawbridges - two more that was usual for a Roman camp of this type - at the front of the camp. Once the men were safely inside, Arthur's men retreated too, although being careful to do so in such a way as they protected each other. The artillery had long since been abandoned and now all the men were in the camp.

Before they could pull in the drawbridges and close the camp gates, the Saxons were inside. A running battle developed in the camp and most of the men kept running out of the back of the camp. Before long, the field belonged to the Saxons, as did the treasures of Arthur's camp, which they began to plunder.

The noise of hoofbeats coming up the hill alerted them to their danger. About five hundred of the Saxons had made it into the camp; the rest were still outside, but no longer in battle order. Arthur and his other three regiments of cavalry were descending on them from all points of the compass and there was nowhere to go.

As rapidly as they could, they started to turn and form their shield wall. But many of the men had dropped shields and spears, taken off armour and were relaxing. The men who fought in the front ranks were the ones *inside* the camp, and while they weren't trapped it would be minutes before they could cross back over the drawbridges and take their place in the army. On top of which, they were doubly distracted by having abandoned their weaponry and picked up plunder.

Arthur's men crashed into the sea of warriors, lances at the ready. It was important to keep them off-balance; stop them ever forming a shield wall, because, once formed, it was impossible for the cavalry to break it down.

The Saxons started to come back out of the camp, wielding spears and hefting shields. As they did, a new sound distracted them: the British infantry, that they assumed had run away, was now behind them, back in the camp. What was going on?

A trap, Aelle realized. It was a trap and he was caught. Fifteen hundred Saxon dead later, he acknowledged the inevitable and surrendered. Cerdic was handed over for execution as a traitor and Aelle agreed to the continuation of the border at the Arun. He and his men handed over their weapons and retreated back down the road from whence they had come. A mistake to leave their lands.

The bonfire burned merrily, but the stench was awful.

The British had spent the afternoon and evening clearing the battlefield, gathering the "valuables" - such as food, weapons, armor and other equipment - into the camp, and piling the bodies up down the hill in pyres for cremation. It was hard work and not for the faint of heart, since it was often hard to remove a helmet without removing the head at the same time.

Outside the camp, the commanders gathered and looked at the burning bonfire. As usual, they had worked harder than any of the others, setting an example and just simply being everywhere at once, making sure that the job was done. Now they basked in the glow of the bonfire whose message was that it had all been worth it: they were the victors.

"You ran away," Quintus said to Bryn. "I will never forget this."

"I did not run away," countered Bryn. "I ordered the retreat and then held the line and covered for the recruits. I was *brave*."

"Oh, you *bravely* ran away, is that what you're saying?"

"Tell him, Arthur. I did not run away."

"I wasn't there. I was too busy leading a charge. But if you were obeying orders, you should have bravely turned your tail and fled. We were counting on it."

Bryn shrugged. If they were determined to have it that way, what could he do?

Guoloppum

AD437

Needless to say, Vortigern's wedding was not popular with the other nobles.

He seemed happy enough, and did not in the end send her away to one of his villas as he had planned, but lived with her as man and wife, having three more children. To the Romans, however, it seemed strange and barbaric and whispering tales went the rounds: that she had cast a love-spell on him; or that the barbarians had strange bed-practices that made them irrestible. But in reality, it was just one more in a long list of complaints that the Senators had about their new dictator, although most of them were related to his love of the barbarians in one way or another.

One of the areas where there was relativity little enthusiasm among the Romans of Britain was for the theological disputes in the Christian church. Britain was, of course, nominally Christian and had been since Constantine had told them to be. Many of the Senators - not to message those of lesser rank - observed the necessary rites and paperwork, and then moved on with their lives. Certainly the number of craftsmen called upon for mosaics of Orpheus in the underworld or other Olympian themes had not significantly decreased over the previous century. And the theological disputes between Orthodox, Catholic, Arian and Pelagian passed them by in their entirety.

So why bring it up? Because the events of the following decard can only really be understood through the prism of Christian fundamentalism. Who can say if the actions that were taken would have been for the best anyway? But certainly what drove them was the desire for pure Christianity.

Pelagius was a heretic. There could be no doubt about this, because the Church's supreme thing with the Pope in charge had decided so. I won't bore you with the exact details of his life-extinguishing heresy, but basically he said that you have to get off your backside and go out there and do stuff if you want a good life after your dead; nothing comes from free.

Apparently, this is not the case, and the "Augustine doctrine" is that God, being all-knowing, decides what life you will lead before you are born, and then you live it, and regardless of what you do, God decides what happens to you based on who you were and whether you accepted his teaching fully enough. Or something. Does it really matter? Well, it did to the Bishop of Auxerre, who came to Britain in AD429 with approval from the collection of Bishops in Gaul - and the Pope, no less - to root out those subscribers to the heresy and put them to death.

You might well think that all the bishops and their paymasters across Italy and Gaul would have better things to do with their time and money - such as stopping the incursions of the Goths and Franks - but apparently not.

Anyway, on his arrival in Britain, he was invited to London and attended a meeting of the Senate, where he outlined his plans for the Inquisition. After a long debate, it was decided that he should proceed to the western parts of the country, where it seemed that he would find most of the men of this persuasion. He and Vortigern set off together and became close over the weeks that followed, although in reality Vortigern, who wanted to do nothing to cause further friction in a society that was already struggling with the actions he had taken, did everything in his power to frustrate Germanus' inquisitorial work.

Germanus was staying at the post station on the road near the fort of Caer Gai when the messenger came through, announcing an attack by the Irish coming down from their mountain forts in Ordovica. At the time, Vortigern had returned to London to deal with the administration, but had left Germanus his "personal" bodyguard of half a century to make sure that his orders were carried out.

Germanus quickly and efficiently determined everything the man knew. Probably 500 Irish were marauding in strength down the road, probably mainly looking for supplies and loot. Because of the issues in recent years with other battlefronts, the Irish in the rural west had been ignored, and now they were running amok.

Germanus had not always been a priest: years ago, he had been pursuing a political career, and, as did most of his contemporaries, had done military service and led armies. Twice he had commanded legions fighting against the Goths in Gaul before giving it all up to become a Bishop.

In other words, he knew what to do. He had the nucleus of a fighting force: the fifty men Vortigern had lent him. And he knew where to find others, because he had been visiting farms, villages and towns looking for heretics. And he had, right at hand, an almost ideal fortress: just on the top of the hill was the fort of Caer Gai, which, if not perfectly preserved, at least made for a defensible position.

He briefly outlined his plan to the messenger and then saw him on his way with his new force. He was riding to Chester, and would come back with as many soldiers as he could find. Two days, probably, or maybe three before they arrived.

Germanus sent riders out throughout the region, alerting farmers and townsfolk to the danger coming down from the west, and asking for all able men to bring what weapons they had and assemble at the fort, to hold the road.

Over the next day, men straggled in from across the countryside and the fort was repaired and improved. By the following morning, when the Irish came boisterously into the clearing below the hill, gleaming swords and spear points greeted them from the hillside. While attacking up the hill seemed like suicide, leaving such a fort behind them was asking to be caught in a trap on their retreat.

The potential stalemate was broken at noon when the reinforcements came up the road from Chester under the command of the *primus pilus* centurion Gaius Catellius and promptly formed up for battle. While useful, the two centuries of Roman troops that could be spared were not really sufficient for the job given the terrain. After a brief encounter, the Romans retreated uphill and were admitted to the fort under covering javelin fire from the ramparts.

Which led straight back to a stalemate. The Irish could not get in, but the Romans could not effectively deal with the superior numbers of Irish given the territory.

Neither side was well-supplied, and while the Romans were trapped *in* the castle, unable to gather more supplies without running the gauntlet of the Irish warriors outside, the Irish were likewise trapped by their inability to detach any significant numbers to go raiding without losing their numerical advantage. Some men did go off, in small groups: some came back with food, while others did not come back at all, killed by small bands of Britons who had not arrived in time to enter the fort before the siege began.

Eventually the stalemate broke after three days with the Irish retreating back up the road towards Ordovica. Germanus and the centurion from Chester had discussed their options and possible battle sites up the road, and set off about six hours after them. Marching at their full speed, they were able to go into camp that night two miles behind at a narrowing in the road, which prevented full deployments and encircling tactics. In a series of running battles over the next two weeks, Germanus won a series of decisive victories, driving the Irish back into their strongholds.

Vortigern, on his return, he was both relieved and pleased at the outcome. He had wanted to battle with the Irish for many years now and this had been a gift sent from God - and in the person of a Bishop. Recognizing the situation for what it was, Vortigern immediately appointed Catellius as regional governor and gave him the fort at Caer Gai as his permanent base. He further allowed him to keep all the troops that had been requisitioned from Chester as well as those from his bodyguard. Vortigern's plans were starting to take shape.

"It is a shame about these Irish, you know."

Vortigern more leaned to the opinion that they were a nuisance, but since the campaign against the Irish, he had come to have a deeper understanding of this man Germanus. To Vortigern, all priests seemed like leeches: sucking the money out of the economy for no benefit in security or investment. But this man was deeper - maybe they all were - and seemed to genuinely care about men's souls in this life as well as the next.

"In what way, Germanus?"

"They have never had the opportunity to see the light of God."

Again, Vortigern thought that the thing it would be more useful for them to see would be the point of his sword sticking out of their back, but he tried to see it from the bishop's perspective.

"Consider, this. Why do they come here and attack us and raid?"

"Because they want our wealth."

"And why is that?"

"Because they are poor."

"Indeed, my friend, but are not all who are without the word of God poor in Spirit? Is not this what our blessed master tells us in his beatitudes? That those poor in the Spirit will be blessed by the coming of his word into being filled with the Holy Ghost?"

Again, Vortigern felt that this somewhat missed the point. Most Irish he knew would prefer to be filled with food and wine, preferably British, and preferably without paying for it. And would then like to go and get involved in a good rousing fight.

"I'm not sure that would be wise, Eminence. I think any priest that went to Ireland without a sizable bodyguard would be running the risk of dying a gruesome death before he had the opportunity to explain about the resurrection."

"We must have faith, Vortigern. On that mountain top, I saw a vision. God came to me and said, 'These will be my people. Follow them and minister unto them.' I have been thinking about this since; while I did follow them I did not minister unto them but slaughtered them. But I think God was speaking to me in a parable."

Kill me now, thought Vortigern, who hated the way the priests turned everything inside out into tortuous explanations that made no sense to anybody. And left you wondering if their logic was logic or just a justification of an idea that had just come into their head.

"When I go back to Gaul and confer with the Council of Bishops. There may be a man who would be prepared to take on this task and go to Ireland to save their souls."

"I pray for that, Eminence," said Vortigern, hoping the sarcasm passed Germanus by.

In the years that followed, Vortigern, Hengest and Horsa stepped up their campaigns against the Irish. The Picts were licking their wounds and those Saxons that came to Britain generally ended up being recruited by Hengest, or sent to work for Octha north of the wall, rather than attacking the coastline.

This gave the British some much-needed respite and an opportunity to build their own forces for defence and even attack.

An opportunity they wasted; instead, preferring to see in the calm an example of divine favour and to complain about the amount of money Vortigern was wasting on billeting "his" Saxons off the coast of Kent and on the relatively small - and all volunteer; no conscription - force he was building at Chester and Caer Gai to final evict the Irish from Ordovica.

In 431, Palladius arrived in England and was greeted warmly as he made his way across the country. This was the man who was going to Ireland to convert the heathen to Christianity; and, more importantly, it was hoped that he would stop their incursions into the mainland.

As a man to send to convert the Irish he had some positives and some negatives. Among the positives was that he was not a man to be easily intimidated. On the other hand, almost every community he visited was more enthusiastic about his arrival than they were about the man after his departure.

In the middle of June he sailed for Ireland and began to preach. Exactly what happened to him there is not recorded, but by late autumn he had returned to Britain a broken man. The ship that brought him back reported that his preaching had not gone down well with the "heathen" Irish, and, it is to be presumed, they did not appreciate being called "heathen" or any other perjoratives.

None deterred, the following year Germanus sent another priest, Patricius, with a couple of acolytes to try again. Although the Irish king, Loegaire, is said to have been less than thrilled at the arrival of "another of these pesky priests who preach the dead-not-dead god on a tree", after a few months Patricius had started to make converts among the nobles, impressed by the tales of power and riches - not to mention life everlasting - that Patricius had held out as benefits of the new teaching.

At the same time, Hengest launched a major raid on the Irish coast and captured land on the east coast, enough to build a bridgehead. Loegaire, unaware that the Saxons had come with Vortigern's blessing, sent messengers post-haste to Vortigern to propose an alliance. Since both rulers were threatened by the spread of the barbarians, Loegaire proposed working together to oppose them. Since this ruled out the possibility of further Irish attacks on the west coast of Britain, Vortigern agreed with alacrity, and sealed the deal with an agreement that Loegaire would convert to Christianity in exchange for a suitable spiritual guide - Vortigern's daughter - as his wife.

With the possibility of reinforcements from Ireland fading, Vortigern moved to try and mop up the remaining Irish in the west. There were two areas that were of concern. On the right bank of the Severn, deep down by the Irish coast, many Irish settlers were dug in. Vortigern, considering his options, decided that repeating the "accident" that had happened with Germanus and Catellius would be the cheapest and most expedient option, went north and conferred with Cunedda, a grandson of Paternus Clemens who was settled north of Hadrian's Wall. A younger son, he had not inherited the command in the north that he felt should rightly come to him as the most talented. He had, by all accounts, been causing trouble and inciting rebellion and treason among the Picts and northern British for a number of years now, and Vortigern felt that it was time to put that talent to use.

After a couple of months of difficult negotiations - smoothed over by a relatively small amount of cash that he was able to raise without actually getting an official directive from the Senate - he managed to convince all the parties involved that Cunedda should take a thousand mixed troops (British, Picts and some hybrids) to Cetgueli in the far west, where he could make all the trouble he wanted with the local Irish settlers. In the usual fashion, he settled him down in the area with the usual "billeting" provisions that the locals had to supply him with all the necessities of life. Since the alternative was to be continually raided by the Irish, this seemed like a good deal to the British in the far west of the island, generally cut off from most Roman support.

On his way back from the north, Vortigern stopped at the fort of Wroxeter and encountered a surprisingly similar situation. Here, the Cornovii had been responsible for raising and deploying a military rapid-reaction force for many years. But it had become less reliable over the years and had seemed to spend more time ensuring that its needs were met than that Britain - in particular the west coast facing Ireland - was protected.

As Vortigern arrived at the fort, he was inundated with complaints about a string of recent incidents that had occurred with regard to the actions of Lucius Cornovius and his family. Since Vortigern happened, at that moment, to be accompanied by the thousand warriors he was relocating to Cetgueli, he was in a very good position to summon Lucius Cornovius and demand an explanation. Given the powers vested in him - as Emperor of Britain, backed by a small army - he had no problem in finding Cornovius guilty and sentencing him to banishment.

But being both cunning and aware that in these difficult times difficult men needed to be horded and used, Vortigern did not banish him from Britain altogether, but rather send him to Dumnonia with all his forces to build a state there and to dislodge the Irish who had invaded and settled in that part of the country.

In the winter of AD435, Voritgern looked around him and was relatively content with what he saw. In the north, the Picts had been pushed back and were isolated by the presence of reinforced regional governors. The Irish had been neutralized by religion and a timely marriage. In the west, the Irish were in retreat in all the places where they had started landing and making settlements. And in the east, the shore defences had been reinforced by having Saxons at key locations up and down the east coast.

What could go wrong?

"We demand that you disband them and send them home."

In London, in March 436, the Senate met for one of its obligatory meetings on the Ides. There was no set agenda; the topic was simply "the good of the Republic". Vortigern had given a swelling speech on how brilliantly his moves over the past five years had worked out, and was completely blindsided by the response.

The Senate was made up of misers. Rich misers, to be sure: misers who could, probably, each afford the entire upkeep of the handful of Saxons that he had billeted down the east coast. But now that things seemed secure, did they want to continue paying for that security? They did not.

"Do you not understand? Yes, we are paying them to protect us, but more than that, we are paying them to *not* attack us. What do you think will happen if we send them away? They will be back here next year, with their friends and allies, but not as defenders of the Republic but as our enemies. And they will win. With what could we oppose them?

"Come to that, how can we oppose them *now*? What resources, fellow senators, do you propose to deploy to evict foreign troops that are there *because you will not pay to raise our own?*

"You blame me for getting us into this mess by hiring Hengest to do our dirty work. True, I did that. But that did not get us into *this mess*. We are actually in a very good position right now. If you want the Saxons gone, you may, by all means start preparing now. A general conscription will get us into a good place to field three legions next year, which would be enough to evict the Saxons, and then we could keep dismiss half of them - assuming they all lived - and keep fifteen cohorts on the east coast. Or maybe we could do it without fighting and just pay the Saxons off to go home. But you cannot just wish them away. The world has changed, fellow senators."

"You are suggesting that we should pay for our defence not once but twice? Are you further suggesting that we should pay for both sides of a civil war? Are you insane?"

Vortigern took a deep breath, then another.

"No, I am not suggesting anything of the sort. I am pointing out your options. I respectfully *suggest* that we carry on as we are. We pay the Saxons for the defence they give us. We continue to support and provision the other appointments and dispositions that I have made. And I suggest that we try and avoid fighting amongst ourselves, against the Irish, or against the Saxons. In fact, I propose that we *only* fight against any invaders - be they Picts or barbarians from the continent."

"We refuse to pay. I will see a division. All those refusing to pay pass to the right, those who wish to continue to pay to have barbarians ruining our country pass to the left."

The Senators stood and, by a vast majority, passed to the right of the division stand. Vortigern fumed, but there was little he could do.

"I do not understand."

To be honest, Vortigern could not say he was surprised. The decision of the Senate - that they were happy for the Saxons to stay, but weren't prepared to pay them - did not really make any sense. But it was a compromise; a decision that the Senate had taken that saved them their money - their real concern - but did not want the cost and risk of actually fighting to evict them. And that was their only real choice if they wanted them to leave; even the Senators were not so stupid as to think that the Saxons would leave their homes here to go back to the much rougher life on the continent because of anything as trivial as a decree from the Senate.

"They thank you for your service, and they want you to leave, but they are too cowardly to try. They will not pay you to leave, even assuming that you would agree to leave for any sum of gold. So they simply assume that if you do not get paid, you will leave of your own account."

"The fools think that?"

"They do indeed. I have told them, I have reasoned with them, I have begged them. But they will not listen. They will not pay."

"I could make them pay. Literally. What or who stands between me and the wealth of the country?"

"Nothing, my friend. They are fools to not see it, that is all I can say."

Ambrosius was worried.

He knew that if the British Senate continued their policy of refusing to pay the Saxons, they would eventually break out and take what they needed. Vortigern had been cunning in where he had located his Saxon bases: on islands, in fens and along the coastline. All the places were chosen for their strategic significance first, of course. But after that, Vortigern had tried to isolate their ability to interact with the British as much as possible, to reduce the friction that having barbarians in their midst would undoubtedly cause.

The only option he could see was to prepare against that day. While he did not have the authority of the Senate to issue a conscription or otherwise to raise troops, he rode around his heartland in the rich west downlands near of the Severn valley and talked to local leaders and freemen. And he started to build a defence association against that day. In towns and villages and in rural communities he built up a small army of infantry.

Not all the Senators were fools; the Knights even less so. Many could see the dangers of not paying for the Saxons, but apart from anything else, none really felt that they could afford to do so "on their own" even if they could have subverted the Senatorial decree that said the Saxons were not to be paid.

In May of 437, Hengest broke out from Thanet Island. With more troops that he "officially" had, either from the continent or other stations, he crossed Kent and marched towards the west, determined to plunder the rich lands there, unaffected by previous conflict and strife and protected over the past century from Saxon, Irish and Pict raids.

Vortigern rode down from London to try and deter him and was staggered by the size of the army he had gathered: thousands if he could judge it. He hailed Hengest and tried to convince him to turn around.

"You, my friend, have always dealt fairly with me", he said through his interpreter Ceretic. "But your Senate respects not me. I have no quarrel with you, but with them. And if they wish not to pay me, I will go and take payment and teach them lesson."

"But you could expose the whole country to being overrun by other barbarians."

"What barbarians? My countrymen are with me, my cousin gives the Picts enough to do, and your Irish friends are peaceful. Where come these barbarians?"

Vortigern could not argue with this. In fact, to tell the truth, he felt that Hengest was in the right of it.

Eventually, they agreed a deal. Vortigern would ride west with Hengest and his army. And they would "negotiate in strength" with the Senators of the west. Vortigern sent riders ahead to summon the Senate to meet at Durnovaria on the Kalends of June.

When Ambrosius first heard that Hengest had left Thanet Island, he sent riders across the south west and told all his followers to get ready for battle and meet at Aquae Sulis as soon as possible. Once there, they started to move eastwards, and were already past Durnovaria when they received Vortigern's missive; Ambrosius dismissed it.

"This is an illegal invasion and the time for talking is done. We will proceed and tell them that they must turn around and go back to whence they came. Only then can we discuss the subject of payments."

The two forces met at Guoloppum. Ambrosius, like Vortigern, was staggered at the number of troops that Hengest had with him. He had not realized so many were in Britain.

The three leaders met in the middle of the field with a handful of retainers including the translator, Ceretic.

"Ambrosius, this is not Durnovaria. Nor is it yet the Kalends. But that is where you were summoned."

"Vortigern, these men have left their station without a decree from the Senate. That is an illegal act. They must turn around at go home."

"They have not been paid, Ambrosius. They understandably come to demand payment."

"They *all* needed to come? And bring some friends who are not even officially on the list?"

"They were concerned that a smaller delegation might not impress upon the Senate the urgency and the, uh, seriousness of the situation."

"The seriousness of the situation being that any Senator who *didn't* vote to pay them might find his head detached from his shoulders? Is this what you have become, Vitalinus? A bloodthirsty tyrant?"

"Me? No. I am with Hengest here because I could not - by myself - dissuade him from continuing and I thought it best to try and maintain order in this march."

"By which you mean, stop your men running amok?"

Vortigern smiled.

"Well, they may not pass."

"You would fight us?"

"I would rather not. But they may not pass. I have considered this long and hard, Vitalinus, and I cannot allow this to continue. My preference has always been for us to defend our lands ourselves. If we cannot, then I accept the need to pay these Volk to do it for us. But I cannot accept them ruling us. If the men return to their base on Thanet Island, we can summon the Senate at Rutupiae, and there we can discuss this in detail and resolve the matter to everyone's satisfaction."

Ceretic had been translating and trying to keep up, but summarizing. But Hengest had understood the import of Ambrosius' speech.

He interrupted loudly, his gutteral speech lost on the others until Ceretic clarified.

"No. No, that we will not do. You trick us, you say you pay us and then you pay us not. What can you prove? Huh? Nothing. No, we settle this here and now. You fight, or you get out of road. Understand?"

Hengest had already turned around and stomped off to rejoin his army before Ceretic had finished his translation. He scurried after his master.

Vortigern looked at Ambrosius and shrugged. "In other times, and in other ways, I would consider you brave and a friend. But here you are being foolish. Your rabble cannot win against them."

They could not win, and Ambrosius went down to defeat. But the battle was costly for the Saxons too. Although the held the field, there was no desire to carry on. Voritgern and Hengest did a new, private deal: Vortigern ceded Hengest the control of Kent. Instead of billeting the men as he had until now, he gave Hengest the powers of a regional governor as he had to his cousin north of the wall and to the governors in the far west of the country.

For a while, Hengest was satisfied and returned to Kent.

5. Linnius

AD487

Arthur was born in Linnius and always had a special affinity for the place.

His stepfather, Merula, took him away after his parents were killed and the Saxons revolted, burning and looting much of the town. There can be little doubt that the events of those days left a scar on his soul.

By AD487, Arthur had been leading the British resistance for over a decade. After the early years where he fought pitched battles in Celidon Forest and at Portchester, the war had returned to its previous status quo with raiding across the various borders.

In the south, most of the fighting was along the Arun, the border between the South Saxons and the British. London was still strongly held. North of London, the Angles held much of the territory of the Iceni, and Camoldonum had been deserted by both sides as a frontier town for many years now. North of the Angles lay Linnius, a British salient into the Saxon-held territories which, combined with the estuary of the Humber just to the north kept the Angles separated from the Jutes in the north-east of Britain. Strategically, keeping these three groups separated - and thus holding both London and Linnius - was vital to the survival of the independent Republic.

More than that, Arthur was still looking for ways to concentrate and draw out the Saxons for an open battle where he could deploy both infantry and cavalry together, rather than depending on the mobility of cavalry to take him across the border and back again.

Arthur was still chronically short of resources, however. No matter how hard he tried, the wealthy landowners of the west saw a stable situation which was both "under control" and "far away". Since the shock of the rebellion in 455 - over thirty years ago now - they had not been directly affected.

Coming up with a viable strategy under these circumstances was more than a little taxing and Arthur was showing the strain. As the months and years went by, he was becoming both more irritable and more haggard. Although he still had in his mind "the grand plan", he felt no closer to it happening than when he had first thought of it. It was all very well to know how to destroy the enemy if they were to come out and fight you, but another to figure out how to get them to do it.

The front between Linnius and the Angles - which had been stable for almost a decade - seemed to Arthur to offer the best prospects for disrupting the current stalemate.

As the spring campaigning season had approached, he had summoned various leaders and counsellors from around the country. The Comes of Linnius was there, as was the Dux from the main northern army, holding back both the Picts and contaning the northern Jutes. Merula was there, aging gracefully - how old was he now, thought Arthur - as well as loyal retainers such as Quintus.

"If we are going to beat the Saxons - truly beat them, not just contain them within the lands they already have, but drive them backwards and into or across the sea - we need to shake things up. These raids of ours barely touch them; they retaliate and we turn the border into a ten-mile wide strip of wasteland. We need to fight the Saxons, not burn out British peasants who have the misfortune to live under or near the Saxons."

"Do you have a plan?"

"No, not as such. But I feel they will only come out - and in numbers - if they feel there is something in it for them. We have to offer them a prize that would be worth taking - and thus worth taking a risk. But then we have to make sure that we do not actually lose that prize."

"Did you have something in mind?" from the Comes of Linnius.

"As it happens, I did," replied Arthur. "Although it may not be much to your liking. I propose that we put our continued holding of Linnius into play."

Aside from some audible intakes of breath, a stony silence greeted this.

"You do, understand, Arthur, that Linnius is the cornerstone of our defence. Lose that, and the country must inevitably fall."

"Yes. But unless we do something daring, something dramatic - and something soon - I think the country must inevitably fall anyway. Or be ruined. Or destroyed. I do not feel we can keep this up forever."

"What do you have in mind?"

"Removing the forces from Linnius and taking them somewhere else. Allowing Linnius to thus be exposed to attack. And then somehow rescuing it with the destruction of all the encircling Saxons. I think the key would be misdirection as to where all our forces were. Specifically, we would either need to move our forces in the north southwards to attack Linnius, or bring my forces up from Badonicus when the Saxons believed that we were still on the Arun."

"Either plan is fraught with danger. What if they were to learn where our real weakness lies?"

"Our real weakness is that they can outwait us. The more time passes, the more barbarians come to our shores and are given refuge. The more Saxons, the more warriors we face. True, they have no cavalry - yet - but sooner or later they will have force enough to come west and to take our western cities and, once encircled, we lose Linnius and all the rest. We could possibly hold the western highlands - possibly even the central highlands - but we would have lost.

"It is possible that they could outfox us with whatever plan we devise. But - if you will forgive the presumption - I honestly believe they have no leaders to compare to me. We have the knowledge and experience of a thousand years of generals passed down to us. Merula will happily discourse over dinner on the relative merits of Alexander in the East or Caesar in the West, but we know of both and can read their accounts. We read also the Peloponesian War, of Hannibal and Carthage; we have Rutilius' manual of war derived from the Great Man, Marius, himself. We all learnt to recite the summary of Sulla's campaigns. What is there to generalling that we do not know? And, on the other hand, what *do* they know? They know how to fight and how to sail. I say to you that if we stay off the water, we *will* beat them in any fair battle. It is just a question of *bringing* them to battle."

The council was quiet for a while. Then Merula spoke.

"What have we not tried?"

A silence fell again. Most of the councillors waited for him to say more, assuming the question to be rhetorical. Arthur, who knew better, knew that Merula would not supply the answer, but knew that there was only one answer - or at least, only one answer that fit the context of the question. He thought hard: what *had* they not tried?

What was there to try? A shipborne attack? They certainly hadn't tried that, but since that was tantamount to suicide, he had to assume that that was not what Merula had in mind.

An infantry assault? They hadn't tried it, although Arthur would dearly have loved to, for the simple reason that they didn't have the kind of infantry numbers that such an assault would take. Their forces were much more of a mobile strike force.

Taking one of their strongholds? Something about that resonated for Arthur. They hadn't tried it for a couple of reasons: they didn't really have the technology these days, and they didn't have the manpower to make it happen and to defend themselves while in enemy territory. And there it was: both of those were reasons not to do that *if your goal was to succeed*. But if your goal was to trick the enemy into believing that that was your goal when your actual goal was something else ... As if by magic, the plan unfurled in his mind, reaching out over the coming weeks and months until ... ah, *that* is how they would defeat the Saxons.

He nearly cried out loud for joy. In a moment, all of the years of frustration felt wiped away. In gratuitous detail, he saw what was going to come and how he would manage it all. Now it was just a question of getting everybody to play their part - including the Saxons. And that depended on him giving out the right, careful, drip-drip-drip of information over the next few years as his plan reached fruition.

And he owed it all to a simple question from Merula.

He looked around, saw the confusion on the others' faces. How *could* they be so ignorant? They had the same resources as he did, the same experiences, the same knowledge of the world situation. How was it possible for them to fail to see that which was so obvious to him?

Patiently, he approached opening up the conversation, trying to work as Merula would, asking rather than answering. But to fit the contract, he needed to first answer Merula's question, but making it sound tentative, not absolute.

"We have not tried a siege. We could invade their territory and try and take one of their forts."

"Do they have such things?" asked Quintus. "I'm familiar with the border fortifications, but actual forts? I don't think I've seen one."

"Indeed they do," replied the Comes. We have raided through to one not far from Linnius. They defend it with some strength and use it as a base for bringing in their tribute. They hold grain there against our raids."

"Which would make it particularly difficult to take by siege," mused Arthur aloud, but internally thinking, _a few miles from Linnius ... perfect_.

"I thought the siege was just meant to be a distraction," croaked Merula.

Arthur looked at him intensely. A wry smile was on Merula's lips and as their eyes met a thought appeared directly in Arthur's brain: "Well done, Arthur. I knew you could figure this out. Don't mind me; I'm just playing along with you."

Arthur glanced away and looked at Quintus.

"It would be a good location, Arthur," he began. "If we were still relatively near the border with Linnius, then we would have a good supply route from there."

"One that the Saxons would dearly like to interrupt," growled Fulvius. "They could do that by attacking Linnius."

"And they would be successful if we had removed all the defensive forces from Linnius," added the Comes.

"And they would fail if they merely *thought* that," said Arthur, "but in reality we had enough men there to act as the vice when the rest of our forces attacked as the hammer."

Yes, thought Arthur, we have a plan.

Arthur moved himself and two units of his forces to Linnius in early May and began the detailed planning for the operation. Three times they deliberately planned raids across the border that went near the fort, and the third time dropped Tiberius Gallus off in a wood about a mile from the fort. A brave and loyal member of Arthur's personal forces, he had offered to stay in the area for a few nights and do reconnaissance of who came and went; how many men were in the area, and then slip back to Linnius when the opportunity presented itself. For this purpose, he had "disguised" himself as a British peasant. He would not, obviously, be able to pretend that he lived here if anybody investigated closely - none of the locals would know him - but to any Saxons in the neighbourhood he would just be another faceless peasant in the fields.

It could not have escaped the notice of the Saxons that there was increased activity in this sector, but given that both sides were just awakening from the slumbers of a hard winter in eastern Britain, the difference from last year was probably not as significant as the fact that the raids had started up again.

Gallus returned to Linnius almost a week later, but with a story to tell. Arthur called together the inner war council and asked him for the details.

"Well, I hid out in the woods for that first day and into the night. I was trying to see if I could tell what the lie of the land was before risking myself to casual observation.

"But the following morning, I set out and before long I'd come across a group of Britons ploughing a field. I said I was a wanderer looking to make it out of Saxon territory, and gave them the impression that maybe I was an outlaw of some kind. They let me into their party and for that day I helped them with their farming and at the end of the day the head man took me back to his house and fed me.

"By that time I had - foolishly or not, I cannot tell - decided he was worthy of trust and told him a little more about what I was doing there. Not the whole plan; fear not. But I told him that I knew some people on the British side of the border and was trying to help them to more effectively raid the Saxons and liberate the British. Our raids, are, of course, not wildly popular among the men that suffer from them, but there are still some of the older men there who remember what liberty was and I was fortunate to have found such a one. He agreed to help me.

"I worked a couple more days in the fields, and then they said it was market day. They didn't have much, but they gathered together a few chickens and some eggs, and the head man and I went together to the Saxon fort. The market was held inside in the central square. You can be sure that I had a good look around while I was there.

"It looks on the inside much the way that it would seem to from the outside. The basic fortification is the ten-foot-high wall you can see from the outside, and on the inside there's the five-foot-high fighting platform that you'd expect. Around the inside, there are huts for the defenders - I'd say the fort has about forty men that live there permanently - and others for storage, hard to tell how much. And in the centre of the fort is the square where they were holding the market, but it could also be used for assembling troops, drill (if they do that) or other practice, or for getting ready to sally out of the gates.

"The gates are solid and thick and well reinforced. There's a second gate inside the fighting platform that's reinforced with metal. You would be very lucky indeed to be able to get through that. If you did want to storm it, I would suggest going over the top. It wouldn't be easy, and they've built an artificial hill so that it's about five or six feet up to the front gate. Not too hard to get to if you're on the path, but you wouldn't want to be doing it with missiles coming down on your head."

"Very good, Gallus. Questions anybody?"

"Just one," said Quintus. "When do we begin?"

To a casual observer, it might have been just another raid. But they came in strength and numbers, and with some unusual equipment. First, they took and held the ford over the Dubglas and the Saxon fortifications on the far side. This in itself was unusual, along with the cost in lives on both sides: an attacking force of over 200 had lost ten men but had taken the defensive position and killed its twelve defenders. Fifty men stayed there the rest of the day fortifying the positions on both sides of the river and connecting them with a primitive log bridge for quicker transit.

Once the ford was secure, a heavy baggage train, complete with artillery and siege engines, crossed the ford and wound through the woods on the Saxon side. None knew exactly where the alert would be raised; they had been careful to make sure none of the Saxons at the river could escape, but the noises of battle were unmistakable and travelled a long way on warm spring days; possibly even as far as the fort.

As ever, Arthur regretted his lack of manpower. He would have liked to copy Caesar's exploits in northern Gaul and hack down all the trees on a ten-man front, build a road along it and use the logs to build barriers to protect the sides from attack. Aside from the practical aspects of protection and speed of communications, such a strategy made a statement about the sheer *power* of a Roman army, even over the forces of nature. To an enemy as superstitious as these Saxons, that would seem to chip away at the very power of the gods themselves.

Between Gallus' detailed reconnaissance and his own impressions of the area from horseback, Arthur knew just where he wanted to go and how to get there. He led the column and brought it down into the valley in front of the fort. Any potential element of surprise was now gone. Ahead, he could see the defenders on the walls of the fort, with the outer door securely closed. Arthur had no doubts that everybody in the fort was on a war footing and ready to repel any assault. None of this, of course, came as any surprise. Arthur would have stormed the fort had they given him the opportunity, but he never expected it.

Instead, they settled down in encampments around the fort. Given a couple of legions, he would have circumvallated this place in a day and gone into proper camps. Of course, given two legions he would probably just have formed a *testudo* with ten cohorts, supported by artillery fire, marched up to the front gate and battered it in while the defenders did their best. With 150 men, that would be suicide.

Still, he did what he could with the available men. Each camp of fifty was responsible for building a partial wall enclosing the fort and for installing its artillery securely. *This needs to look good* Arthur thought, even if it stands no chance of success.

A general can only control part of any battle. And Arthur knew well that the Saxons had a number of different strategies they could choose to retaliate. He knew what he wanted them to do: assume that he had brought all his forces here and counter-attack behind him, using more of their own forces to try and take Linnius. But they could reinforce and attack him here, where he would be at something of a disadvantage, but was why he had made his men dig in so well. Or, they could just ignore him altogether and hope that the fort could hold out, and just simply give up on it altogether if he could outlast them. That, he reflected, would be the *right* thing to do unless they had unlimited manpower. Realistically, this location had no strategic significance whatsoever, since it was on the wrong side of the river. If they couldn't hold it from a position of strength over the summer, he wouldn't be able to hold it with almost no preparation over the winter, and surely that would be obvious to them, too.

But somehow, he knew deep inside that they didn't see that.

Kent

AD442

Vortigern's decision to cede Kent to the Saxons might have been pragmatic. It might have saved the rest of Britain from having to fight, but it was not popular. It was, understandably, not popular with the citizens of Kent, who did not want to be under the control of marauding barbarians. Neither was it popular with that faction of the Senate that had wanted the Saxons *out* of Britain: now they had control of a much larger part of it; and more than that, officially sanctioned control, whatever the Senate might say.

And the Saxon territory was uncomfortably close. The centre of British power lay in London, on the north side of the Thames River. Across that river lay the grand structure of London Bridge, with its stone arches, reaching across to the south side. From there, a few miles downstream, or a few more inland, brought you to the borders of the now-Saxon "Kingdom of Kent".

Perhaps more suprisingly, Vortigern's son, "little overlord" Vortimer, was also unhappy with his father's actions. As a child, he had believed that everything his father had done had been right and just. As a youth, he had chosen to do military service with the army in the north, and had learned just how feared - and fearsome - their Saxon allies were, both north of the border - and at home.

While he abstractly accepted his father's position that the Saxons were needed for the defence of Britain - and that, even if they were no longer needed could not be evicted at this point - he was concerned that there official "Foederati" status was now being overlooked and turning into more of a "domini" status. There was a big difference between billeting and feeding an army of Saxon allies in a few places and accepting their overlordship across much of the southeast of Britain. Where would it end?

He raised some of these points with his father, who remained unimpressed. The naivete of youth, he thought - and said. A row followed which involved many things being said that could not be unsaid and young Vortimer left home and went and found common cause with a nascent rebel army in Kent.

The battles raged across Kent for most of the next decade.

While Hengest felt that he was now the King of Kent, most of his forces were still based on the island of Thanet, off the coast. Until he could redeploy his forces, he was unable to enforce anything more than nominal authority over his nominal kingdom.

While a great warrior, and a not-indifferent leader of men, Hengest lacked the wide-area strategic awareness that came naturally to educated Romans. He largely assumed that having been granted the land by Vortigern - and having won a decisive battle at Guollopum - there would be little or no resistance to his moving troops off Thanet Island and onto the mainland.

He counted without Vortimer.

Vortimer was determined that no Saxons would take over Kent and gathered together a scratch force from across the south east of Britain. He gathered these forces and marched to oppose a small band of Hengest's men who were planning on establishing themselves at Canterbury, athwart the main road from Rutupiae to London and thus able to control access to most of the region.

The forces met at Crayford, and fought long and hard in battle lines across the river. A running battle that lasted three days, as neither side could fully cross the river to the other side and engage in full combat, it ended when the Saxons left the ford at night and, crossing the Darenth, circled behind the British. Caught between the British and the river on the final day of the battle, Vortimer's brother Categirn died leading the right wing. In the centre of the line, Horsa, the leader of the Saxon mission to Canterbury died trying to break the British line.

He died, but not in vain. A few minutes later the Saxons broke through and drove the British screaming and scrambling across the river. For the next two days, they were chased back to London where they took refuge inside the city walls.

Hengest bitterly regretted the loss of his brother and for two years failed to follow up this victory with any further action; but then once again sent men to occupy Canterbury. On this occasion they were able to enter the city unopposed and held it for the next two years.

Once again, Vortimer acted to evict them. Gathering more troops from both the south east and across the west country, he marshalled and disciplined his army almost five cohorts strong, and led it into battle in Kent. He laid siege to Canterbury and eventually made the commander there admit defeat and once again retreated to Thanet Island.

A couple more years passed and Hengest, returning to his roots, raided across Kent, all the while claiming that he was "acting legally" in collecting the taxes and tribute that was owed to him, largely avoided Vortimer's forces which were neither full-time, professional soldiers nor able to be everywhere at once.

Indecisive engagements were fought on a number of occasions and the Britons took some advantage from their superiority in cavalry; but in general the advantage went to the Saxons who, from their base of safety on Thanet Island sailed across to the mainland when they chose, landed in unexpected locations, raided inland, only to escape before the British could mobilize.

By 452, Vortimer had had enough.

He called a meeting of his advisors in the thick snows of February and met at Rochester.

"It's true that they come and go where they want, like the wind," he said. "But they have no horses, so we can go faster."

The others acknowledged the truth of this, but did not see how it benefitted them. The number of cavalry they had could not beat the quanity and quality of Saxon raiders, and they could not mobilize the infantry in that amount of time, even if they could deploy the cavalry.

"Unless we can delay them for a while," said Vortimer.

"How?"

"How do they come?" asked Vortimer, either rhetorically or redundantly.

"By ship."

"And how do they leave?"

"By ship."

Vortimer let the pause develop for a few seconds while they all shared in the same realization he had had over the winter.

"But only if their ships are still there," said Ambrosius Jr, one of Vortimer's "loyal rebels".

"Exactly. If they return to find their ships burned to the waterline, what will they do? What can they do?"

"Turn and fight like the cornered rats they are."

"And we will be there with some cavalry to harass them, and meanwhile our infantry will be mobilizing and coming across the countryside. They should be there in three or four days. With some horsemen to run messages, we should be able to bring them to battle somewhere."

They all agreed this was an excellent, workable plan.

"But how will we be able to find their ships, let alone destroy them?" Ambrosius, ever practical, asked.

"This year must be the year of total commitment," stated Vortimer. "We must all apply ourselves utterly to the task. If some crops go ungrown, so be it. If we can win this battle, we will be able to ask for help from others in the island. And if we lose, we would not have use for the food anyway.

"We must round up and dedicate all our cavalry soldiers all year. The first task is to station lookouts all along the coast. As soon as any lookout sees the Saxons coming, they must immediately ride to alert the other lookouts, gather the cavalry and mobilize the infantry. We can use the same beacons that have been used in the north. Then, when everyone is alerted, the cavalry can converge from all directions at the landing site.

"The cavalry will be responsible for destroying the fleet by any means possible, and, if necessary, holding the enemy at bay. We must then somehow shepherd the Saxons onto our infantry for the final engagement."

The Saxons managed to get three or four raids out and home again before the British were able to put their plan into full effect. But in late June, the Saxons attempted to take advantage of the long days and short nights to land on the south coast and raid deep inland. Their ships were spotted when still offshore in the early morning light, and the signal beacons were lit.

Still assuming that the purpose of these beacons was early warning and defence, and not a rallying cry for the defenders, the Saxons came ashore as they had planned and began to raid. By midday, behind the bluffs just inland from the coast, over a hundred horsemen had arrived and decided that they were sufficient for the task. The Saxons had conveniently beached their ships - all the better to offload their warriors and then load them and their plunder back again when the tide started to rise that evening - and left just forty men to guard them against any local threats.

Vortimer was not present in person for this battle; he was mustering and mobilizing units of the infantry and trying to figure out where to bring the Saxons to battle. But Ambrosius Jr had turned up just as the final decision was being made as to whether to attack now or to wait. His voice was the one that pushed the men across the line in their decision to attack.

The key, of course, was to destroy the ships; and the easiest way to do that was to burn them. But in order to do that, they would need to get to them, and that involved dealing with the men without allowing them to escape.

Ambrosius quickly formed up his forces. Ensuring there was an adequate supply of fire and timber, he deputed twenty men to be his "burners" - four for each of the five ships, four brands per man - who were responsible for setting fire to the ships and making sure they burnt.

Twenty more were designated as fighting as cavalry. From horseback, they would be responsible for trying to encircle the enemy, harass them, and deal with any that tried to escape.

The remaining sixty were to form four ranks of fifteen. It wasn't a long line, but he figured that the Saxons - with only forty men - would struggle to match it, particularly as trying to defend the ships would limit their range of maneouvre and they had to deal with their lack of cavalry.

The battle was a complete success. Within two hours, all the Saxons were dead and the ships were burnt to the waterline. Ambrosius' forces had suffered ten dead themselves, whom they mourned and cremated, but it was a price worth paying for isolating five hundred Saxons on the mainland without supplies, support or a route home.

Vortimer brought them to battle six days later, hungry, tired and ragged from constant harassment from the British cavalry.

They had, reasonably enough, tried to work their way back across Kent to where they could signal for reinforcements or rescue from Hengest on Thanet Island. But Ambrosius' cavalry had continually forced them to follow the coast road until they come close to Rutupiae.

And there Vortimer struck. Assembling all the infantry he could raise in Kent, he drove into the Saxon forces outside Rutupiae, and the cavalry crashed into the shield wall time and again, reducing the Saxons to exhausted wrecks. The fighting was close and bitter, and Vortimer was fatally wounded before, finally, as dusk was approaching, the Saxons broke and ran - and were caught between the cavalry and the sea, and were slaughtered and drowned in an outpouring of rage that had building in the British since the defeat of Ambrosius Sr at Guollopum over fifteen years before. None of the Saxons lived to tell the tale.

As he lay dying, Vortimer begged his men to bury him on that coastline, facing out to sea, as a reminder to all men of the vigilance that had created this victory and the eternal vigilance and mutual defence that would be needed to keep Britain forever free.

They sent his body back to London to his father, who cremated him with all military honours. In death, all is forgiven.

6. Linnius

AD487

The Saxons crashed out of the forest and forded the river.

They had come in strength. Messages had rapidly reached them of Arthur's siege and they had been amazed. What was the strategic significance of this site? What made it worth the effort of a long siege?

They came and looked, presuming themselves unseen from their cover. Certainly, the siegeworks were impressive, as were the number of men. Where had they come from? Linnius across the river in British territory could be the only reasonable answer. A couple of reconnaissance missions confirmed that the garrison there was undermanned. They also observed the work that had been done fortifying the ford and improving the road. While such things meant less to them than they did to Romans, they were nevertheless impressed by his industry and his preparation should he need to retreat.

Of the two options they saw, trying to lift the siege directly seemed much less likely to succeed than counter-attacking Linnius. That approach held the best chance of relieving the siege - surely news that Linnius was under attack would reach Arthur and he would lift the siege to come and counter-attack them, having to cross the river to do so. And beyond that, it held the upside potential that while Arthur was coming they could possibly manage to storm Linnius. And even if not that, they could potentially ambush Arthur as he had to retreat across the Dubglas.

That Arthur was there was certain. Although less of a legend in the town of his birth than he was in the south of Britain, his leadership, his victory over the Picts, and his year of battling here before were all well known. But his genius was widely regarded as exaggerated and the local Saxon leader was convinced that he could win this engagement.

So while Arthur spent two fruitless weeks sieging their fort, bombarding it will missiles and surrounding it with ever-more-impressive earthworks, but never actually assaulting it, they gathered over five hundred warriors from the region and gathered close to two fords upstream from the one that Arthur had secured.

And attacked.

The gates were closed.

Arthur's instructions to the men inside Linnius had been clear and explicit. They were to appear undermanned at all times and to avoid giving away their true strength even to the town residents. The gates of the city were to be kept closed at all times, except when specifically required for the movement of troops, and civilians were not to be permitted in or out of the city.

These were draconian restrictions.

To Arthur, this one battle was more important than the transient lifeblood of the region. He had calculated that it would not be for more than a month and, while his inner circle knew this, the town residents did not, and chafed under the restrictions.

But once they saw a horde of Saxons come and camp under their walls, they were grateful for the closed gates and the handful of soldiers in the city, but wished for more.

Unlike Arthur's tidy, exquisitely prepared siegeworks, complete with artillery, the Saxon camp was a mess. They had built a rough fence surrounding the camp, it was true, but there were no proper fortifications, no earthworks to control the territory, no proper facilities and no apparent plan for defence should they be attacked.

The reason was simple. The camp was just a base from which the Saxons were planning to attack an undefended city and overrun it within a day. Arriving in the evening, the camp was intended only for a single night: tomorrow night they were would be plundering and raping inside the walls of the city and ready to face Arthur's retreating forces from behind the city walls the following day.

The one recognizably defensive move they made was to detach fifty men to dig a ditch across the road at "Arthur's ford" and build a defensive work there to prevent Arthur's retreat across the bridge he had prepared. This, they reasoned, would delay Arthur's retreat even if he heard about their assault before they had taken the city.

The only siege equipment they had brought with them were scaling ladders. They assumed that it was all they would need.

The ladders crashed against the outer walls.

It was early in the morning and the sun was glaring over the tops of the trees to the east. The Saxons had deployed at four points around the walls and had started their assault.

On the walls, the fifty or so defenders had hurried to the apparent attack points and had prepared their defences. Against so many, they were an inadequate force and would probably soon be overwhelmed.

Walls naturally favoured the defenders. Both the height and the protection afforded by the walls gave the defenders a concrete advantage throughout the battle that would follow. The Romans had demonstrated, time and again, that it was possible to negate these advantages by the use of the right equipment: mantlets and siege towers, among others. Arthur had read Vespasian's description of how he had even built a mile-long ramp in front of Masada in Palestine in order to reduce that mountaintop fortress. It had taken him a couple of years, of course. But the Saxons had read none of that, and didn't care. Climb up the walls, hack down the defenders and get inside as quickly as possible. Attack from multiple angles and you'll split the defenders.

On the walls, the defenders were armed with lances and other pole arms, designed for their long reach. They were able to stab down at the attackers long before the attackers - trying to hold on to the ladder with one hand, protect themselves with a shield with the other, and at some point reach back for axe or spear with one hand or the other - could retaliate. In places, they tried to shove the ladders away from the walls, but the combined weight of the Saxons and the angle of the ladders kept them firmly in place.

At the north east corner, a couple of young lads tried hacking away at one of the ladders with axes, but the ladders were wrapped in bark and while that could be chipped away, the meat of the ladder was not affected before the Saxons were at the top.

A big, hairy Saxon came flying up a ladder, his shield held out in front of him like a battering ram. He charged off the ladder and landed like a cat on top of the narrow outer wall. From here he was even higher than the defenders on the fighting pediment and held them off with his shield as he reached back for his axe. In a few moments he was down on the fighting step, swinging his axe at retreating Britons as the others came up behind him.

Then one of the Britons stepped forward and engaged him in combat, heavy Roman shield against that scything axe, *gladius* held ready to stab when the opportunity presented itself.

Around them, more Saxons were crashing up and over the wall. Some were quickly dispatched, either in the process of jumping from the ladder to to the wall, or while they stood atop the outer wall: either thrust backwards to the outside, or helped on in, down and into the killing grounds of the courtyard below.

Soon two or three more Saxons had joined their first comrade and opened up a breach on the wall, fighting back the Britons in both directions. More Saxons were now able to breast the wall from the ladders, unopposed by British spears. The Saxons exulted, for surely now the castle was theirs. More Saxons started climbing the ladders.

Around Linnius, the British on the walls were now in full retreat and hurrying down the stairs to the city below. As they left the walls, the artillery in the town square started firing, spearing the Saxons on the walls and sending them tumbling outside the city walls.

Half the Saxons were now up on the walls, and more were coming up the ladders, unopposed. They held the top of the staircases and were coming down, protected by shields. Now they needed to deploy across the killing grounds at the base of the stairs, but they found their way blocked by a shield wall of infantry. From above, their comrades cast spears and other missiles on the heads on the infantry, but they responded by raising their shields over their heads in the classic *testudo* formation.

The first two Saxons to emerge from the northeast stair found their way blocked by a solid defense line, multiple ranks deep. Were there still this many men left alive? But they went to with gusto, laying about with their axes.

The defensive wall gave slightly, but then the shields opened and the *gladii* came stabbing out. The wall closed and pressed again as the Saxons whirled their axes. The *gladii* struck again and this time one of the Saxons died. Another took his place.

In the background, the noise of the *ballistae* continued unabated: clack, whirr, rachet. More often than not, the bolts would hit one of the men on the ever-more-crowded walls. On the ground, the need to open the gates and let in the rest of the army was ever more urgent, but it was impossible to break through the dense ranks of defending Britons.

Suddenly a major commotion eruped outside, and then on the wall. Down on the floor of the city in the heat of battle, anything could be happening elsewhere, and the objective was clear: get to the gates. The axes continued to swing, but the resistance was solid.

Outside, the remaining Saxons were under attack. Arthur himself - and his two hundred men split between the ford and the fort they were besieging - were not there, but the other units he had carefully prepared and deployed in the woodlands against this moment had attacked at the prescribed moment - once the walls had been fully taken by the Saxons and the men outside were staging to enter through the gates.

In one swift cavalry charge they were in and amongst the Saxons. Hurriedly the Saxons attempted to set up a defensive wall but they were turned about and out of formation. Without a solid initial defence, the cavalry were able to run over them and break them up into small groups and hunt them down. Within five minutes, the group still outside the walls had been killed or had managed to flee to the relative safety of the woods or river. Outside the city, the British held sway.

They followed up this initial victory by pulling down the scaling ladders, even as some of the attackers on the walls considered the relative merits of coming back down to face this new enemy. The Saxons were now trapped either inside or on the walls of the city.

On the walls, death was raining up from the continually firing *ballistae* in the centre of the town. The only real option was to fight their way down the staircases. They held the staircases themselves, but beyond that the courtyard was stoutly defended by more soldiers than had been on the walls. Without recourse, men were dying.

Some of the Saxons survived that day, and went back to tell their Lords that they had been led into a trap. They escaped across the river or through the woods. Others surrendered and became slaves, disarmed and taken far to the west where they would never meet others of their own kind who might try and rescue them.

Arthur continued his siege until late Autumn. No point in revealing that it had been a ruse. And anyway, they might still be foolish enough to try and raise the siege.

In late October, the garrison surrendered. They too, were taken captive and sent to the west of Britain. And Arthur returned to spend the winter at his own base, in Badonicus and to plan his next step in drawing out the Saxons to fight on his terms.

Linnius had been a complete success.

Verulanium

AD455

Vortigern travelled to see Hengest on Thanet Island.

In the same way that he could not control Hengest - and could not explain to the Senate why he could not - neither could he control his son - or explain by messenger to Hengest why he could not.

Hengest had been livid with Vortigern about the treachery and betrayal he felt at his hands because of what his son had been allowed to do, and that Vortigern had seen fit to give him a burial as a hero for doing it.

Messengers had passed backwards and forwards between London and Thanet throughout the winter of AD454, and by June Vortigern had recognized that the only way to resolve this argument was to go to see Hengest in person, either to apologize or to accept that he would be held hostage for, or killed in lieu of, blood price - the barbaric practice of valuing life in money.

He had travelled down through the Kent roads, and then taken the track that led to the dock where the ferry sailed across to Thanet. He had climbed on the boat with a heavy heart, knowing that this was the end of Britain as he knew it, but really not quite sure why.

By the time he arrived at Hengest's headquarters, almost a year had gone by since the great battle at Rutupiae when so many Saxons had died - and Voritgern's son. If nothing else, the two men had that loss in common.

Hengest's rage had cooled in the intervening months.

"My friend, how you?" asked Ceretic, the ever-present interpreter. "It is long time we no see."

"I am weary, my friend. These battles between you and us, they are pointless. I have lost my son. You have lost your brother. Many others have died. All so unnecessary."

Ceretic translated, and then there was a pause while Hengest thought, and then spoke. A further pause, and chatter between Ceretic and Hengest. Then Ceretic translated for Vortigern.

"Ever it seems that you are unable. You not make Senate pay us. They not support us. They not give us land. Now they kill us and you nothing do. How?"

Vortigern let out a deep breath. Yes, he thought, to them with their Lords and Kings it must seem strange, this system of ours. And truly it is strange that I cannot do as I wish.

"Because I have no real power. I cannot make anybody do anything, because I do not have an army. The Army of the North does what it's Dux in York tells it to do, and that is what the Senate tells him to do.

"I can tell the Senate what needs to happen, but if they do not listen to me, there is nothing I can do.

"I could not oppose my son, because he raised troops to fight you; I could not fight him without troops of my own, and no Britons will support me fighting for you against him. Thus you must fight him yourself.

"I buried my son with full honours because, even though I disagreed with what he did, he *was* my son, and he was brave and acted like a hero. If I had not done this, the people would have reviled me and done it anyway. Then yet more people would have risen up and joined the forces which even now oppose you."

"So what can we do?" asked Ceretic for Hengest.

"I do not know," replied Vortigern. "I cannot control my people, and I cannot get them to agree to what is needed. They say that I cannot control you - which I cannot - and that they neither want you here not are prepared to pay for you to be here to defend them against threats that have been defanged."

"But they are wrong," pointed out Ceretic.

"I encourage you to try and tell them that yourselves, for they certainly will not listen to me. I have told them, I have asked them, I have cajoled them, but they will not tolerate your presence here, let alone as masters of Kent."

"How do you suggest we 'tell' them? Have we not tried?"

"I have done your talking for you, until now. Perhaps it would be best if you sailed up to London to discuss it with them?"

"That nest of vipers? If I sail to London, I will bring fire and burn it. Burn it all. You tell them!"

"If not London, maybe elsewhere? Camolodunum? Verulanium?"

"In Kent, there many villas. How about villa in Kent?"

"I could see how that would work. Who should be at the peace conference?"

"Peace conference? What are these words you use?" This directly from Ceretic without consulting Hengest.

"Do we not need to all talk? And sort things out? And settle once and for all how we will live together? We call this peace."

"Ah, I see." Ceretic conferred with Hengest for a long while. Presumably they discussed the nature of this "peace" and what benefits it could bring.

"If we are going to discuss everything, all our brethren should be there. And thus somewhere in the middle of the island would be good. Let us say somewhere on the Icknield Way, near Verulanium. We will cross to near Camulodunum and work through to there. Osric must be there. When should we meet?"

"The Kalends of October. That should be enough time for every one to gather together. Until that time, we will not attack you and you will not attack us."

"Agreed."

And so it was that they all gathered at Vortigern's villa outside Verulanium on the Kalends of October.

Gaius Artorius Senior had left his son at home in Linnius with the family of the Princeps Senatus, Merula. Merula had said that he did not approve of this gathering, but privately he felt Merula knew more than he should. It led to an air of apprehension even before he met Ambrosius. He and his wife had travelled the hundred and fifty miles to Vortigern's villa. Although she had no legal standing at the conference, many Britons followed in the Roman tradition of deeply respecting their wives' insights - Livia being one of the most powerful individuals in early Imperial Rome, for example - and often included them in informal conferences. Many of the wives were coming and were going to have separate "back room" meetings over the next few days.

As the first day of the peace conference had progressed, the two sides had felt themselves ever farther apart, and many - Ambrosius and Artorius in particular - had felt that no resolution would be found.

They were, of course, spectacularly proved right when the treachery erupted and the villa was attacked by hidden Saxons and Osric and Hengest killed the majority of those in the villa - including the women and slaves - and took Vortigern hostage.

The Saxons had never really taken the time to understand the country in which they lived and how it operated. They had a very primitive view of wealth, that was not continually earned, year on year, by planting and harvesting crops, and by the operation of industry. When the rebellion erupted in AD455, they thought that there was simply wealth for the taking.

Within days of the massacre at Vortigern's villa, the whole of the east of the island was aflame with violence. Many towns and cities were destroyed, and others captured, ransacked and goods and captives carried off. Among other cities, Camulodunum was taken by surprise and sacked; its treasures carried off to Osric's base in Iceni.

The high water mark saw parties of Saxons raid as far west as Gloucester and Chester before retreating to their own lands. In general, the walled towns - including London - held out as the news of the rebellion outran the fact. But in the countryside, the damage to people, property and infrastructure was almost total.

There were two main long-term consequences of that night's massacre for the Saxons. In the first place, the hostage Vortigern agreed to give the Saxons yet more land beyond Kent, up to the River Arun. And in the second, with no more ability of the British to resist, Hengest invited all his countrymen - Angles, Jutes or Saxons - to come with their boats and families and occupy this island, giving him support and a power base and his people a new home.

For the British, their society crumbled and collapsed. Although London held, and the west was attacked, the fact remained that the west had always been the rich part of the country and the source of its wealth, while the areas around London were now either in enemy hands or close to enemy territory and at continual risk. Since most of the surviving Senators hailed from the west, they moved their capital there, first to Aquae Sulis and then to Glastonbury.

For some, even the west country was not far enough. For those who still viewed themselves as Roman first and British second, emigrating to Gaul seemed an attractive option. While no more secure than Britain - after all, the Goths and Franks were there - the north-west of Gaul, called Armorica, had managed to maintain its status as an independent kingdom and was looking for support from solid Romans. Many, particularly those who had lost lands in the east of Britain or had their holdings destroyed in the Great Raids, found it easier to emigrate to be with friends or relatives in Armorica than to tediously build up from scratch again.

A dark night was spreading over Britain. The break with Rome was now complete. Would it end in a new morning or in total destruction? Were these the end days predicted by the Christians?

7. Aquae Sulis

AD491

The winter had been bleak.

Since the grand battle at Linnius, Arthur had been engaged in a continual, low-key struggle for control of the east of the island. Always, his plan was to drive home to the Saxons the weakness of their strategic position, even if they held a numerical and man-for-man advantage.

But his long-term objective remained to draw the Saxons out into a large-scale, pitched battle. Without a decisive victory, they would continue to grow and establish their control over the lands that they occupied.

Meanwhile, he continued to have concerns about the welfare of the country as a whole. Ever since the province had become independent of the Roman Empire, it seemed that it had struggled to maintain the sense of decency and law and order in which Arthur - steeped in the writings of the classic philosophers such as Socrates, Plato, Cicero and Seneca - believed to be essential to civilized society. At war with barbarians in the field, Arthur felt himself at war with barbarism at home.

Surprisingly, his biggest ally in this "shadow war" against the inevitable slide into barbarism seemed to be the Christian Church. Still in its infancy, the latest trend of groups of devout monks setting up in "monasteries" and keeping alive the skills of reading and writing seemed to Arthur to offer hope against what felt like the crushing out of the light of hope to all that he held dear.

It saddened him that they seemed more interested in copying and preserving the lives of their "saints" than they did in keeping alive the veritable works of philosophy, history and ethics that he most cherished from his childhood education.

Interestingly, one of the main monasteries was growing up at Glastonbury under the watchful eye of his old tutor, Merula. Inasmuch as the Senate still met, it met there, and the monastery there benefitted from its patronage and doubtless from Merula's advice and influence.

Having been there to visit Merula, Arthur had agreed to indulge Merula's enthuasiasm for the project by visiting the monastery on the nearby hill and seeing the scribes at work.

"They tell me, you know," Merula confided with twinkling eyes to Arthur, "that when the Lord Jesus was buried and rose again, that the man who helped bury him fled to this spot. Seems strange does it not?"

"Was this spot even part of the Empire at the time?" asked Arthur, whose grip on Roman history was rock solid, but his grip on the fanciful tales of the Christians less so.

"No, that it was not. But if you were fleeing from the power of Rome, it seems an odd way to come, does it not? I can only imagine that he was fleeing by sea and was taken by a storm beyond the Pillars of Hercules and then ultimately up the Severn channel to pitch up here."

"I think the story more likely an invention. Many of these places - not just here, but I've heard in Gaul as well - seem to thrive on telling these stories of connections to famous people in their legends to draw in visitors and raise donations."

"You may be right, young Arthur. Although I feel you should leave the world-weary cynicism to me and concentrate on fighting your battles in the east."

"Will I ever be young in your eyes, Merula?"

"Well, in my eyes, yes. Since you will ever be my dear Artorius' young son. But I suppose that when I am gone, many others will judge you to be old. But remember, in days of old, at this time you would have been whitening up your toga and making a run for praetor, not lording it over half of Britain as Dux Bellorum."

"Oh, how I wish that were so. I feel us slipping inevitably into a mere mimicry of these barbarians we so dispose. Can we win the war without losing our civilization, Merula? Can we?"

"Much has already been lost. What do you think to salvage?"

Arthur thought. There really was only one answer to that. Faced with the magnitude of the task, he shrugged.

"I doubt I have time but, to be frank, all of it."

Merula smiled. "You were ever ambitious. I remember you as a lad, trying to read all those books ..." he tailed off. "You may be able to do it, but if not, know that what you do ... is enough. It may not hold the dark days at bay, but beyond the dark days ... I see brighter days ahead. And what you do now will inspire men through those days and will bring the light again. This I know."

Arthur gripped the old man's forearm in a military salute. "I take great comfort from that, Merula. If I am fortunate, I have another thirty years to do what I can to guard against the dark days."

"Fortune has nothing to do with it, young man. I swear by a strict regimen of healthy eating and regular bathing. And don't cut yourself short at thirty more years. Fifty is well within reach if you look after yourself."

Arthur had been distressed by many of the reports he had heard when he was in Glastonbury. Everywhere it seemed that the economy was collapsing and people were becoming more tribal and insular. What had started as a tactical policy under Voritgern of appointing regional prefects with wide-ranging discretionary powers was rapidly becoming a patchwork where anything went if you could enforce it. In a land where the rule of law was becoming more of a concept that an established fact, might was becoming right.

Arthur rode with his band of loyal retainers up to Aquae Sulis. He had heard that the *duumvir* here - it was a while now since city governors had been actually appointed in pairs and changed every year - had become more authoritarian in his "rule" over the town. Arthur was determined to stamp out such abuses and, if might was right, then Arthur felt he had the greatest might in the land and could hopefully enforce the rights of individuals against the abuses of overlords.

He raised his standard as he approached the city walls; let them know who was coming. Once across the river and inside the city walls, he demanded an immediate audience with the *duumvir*.

The man came in and greeted him. "Gaius Artorius. It has been a while."

"Indeed it has." This man had been his captain once, long ago, before he had taken on that role himself as a very young man. This man had gone on to greater things and now was the Lord - *de facto* even if there were no such thing *de jure* - of one of the major western towns of Britain, the spa town of Aquae Sulis on the River Afon.

"To what do I owe the pleasure?"

"I wouldn't rush to judgment, my old comrade," countered Arthur. "If I did, you would have six inches of steel sticking out of your back right now."

Arthur's tone had remained conversational, but such was the tenor of threat in the words that the man involuntarily took a step backwards and raised his hands in self-defence.

"What? What are you saying? What lies have people been telling about me?"

"Lies? Are they lies? Let us see."

"You know me, Artorius. Straight as an arrow and honest as the day is long."

"The days are very short, right now, <duumvir>, and people change. You were straight and honest, and once the law of Rome was the law here.

"Bring me Aemilia Tertia."

<Duumvir> blinked and went a shade paler. "How ..." he began, then corrected himself. "Who ... who is she?"

"Oh, come on, <duumvir>," countered Arthur. "Surely you can't pretend that you don't even know who she is. If the case is notorious enough to reach my ears, you really can't imagine that I'd believe that you *hadn't* heard about it. So that's not really a good start, is it?"

<Duumvir> gulped twice and looked around him. Then he signalled his servant and said to him, "Send for Aemilia Tertia ... and her husband."

"Oh, no need for that," said Arthur cheerfully. "I went to the effort of bringing her husband with me here. And really, you should have known that he had left your jurisdiction to take his case to the Senate in Glastonbury."

After a few minutes a short, dark-haired woman came in. She looked terrified and, when she saw Arthur and her husband with the duumvir, she burst into tears and fell to her knees, grovelling before Arthur.

"Please lord, don't hurt him. I will do whatever you say. As I promised already. You don't need to threaten me any more."

Arthur was appalled and pulled back from this wreck of a woman. Her husband had told him, but in this land it did not seem possible that a Roman citizen woman could be so treated. His face began to purple with rage.

He turned away and faced Quintus. "Arrest this man and take him for trial at Glastonbury. The man and his wife must go too as witnesses. The proper procedure must be strictly adhered to, but be in no doubt that I want the best prosecutor you can find. Let him choose his advocate, from here if he wants, but be aware that I will be carrying out a detailed investigation here and that will probably end up with many of his accomplices being arrested."

Over the following week, Arthur did what he had said and probed deeply into the administration of the area. Aquae Sulis was the principal town of most of the Afon valley, stretching north to the border with Gloucester, and south down to Glastonbury. As he dug, he found any number of injustices had been perpetrated in the name of the law and arrested over a dozen men on various charges, sending them all to stand trial in Glastonbury.

"They'll probably all avoid punishment," said Quintus, awed again by the power of the mind inside his officer's head. "Who will want to punish men like these in times like these?"

"And that is the problem," conceded Arthur. "The times are like they are, and until something changes we cannot expect things to get any better.

"What really worries me is the extent of the corruption. If it's as bad as this here, in a provincial backwater that hasn't even really come into contact with the Saxons, what is it going to be like elsewhere? In the north? In the autonomous regions? I've never really thought to look; I've been too busy trying to make sure people have been sending me the taxes we need to wonder how."

This was the aspect of his enquiry that had most worried him. The kinds of abuse of power that occurred when too much power was given over to individuals without the appropriate constraints drew notice, but were really just the pimples under the skin of a much worse disease. And that disease was that the country was basically bankrupt. The never-ending war was draining all the life from the economy and could not be supported for another dozen years.

"We need a reprieve, Quintus. In short, we need to win this war."

Quintus nodded. This was Arthur's refrain, his oft repeated homily on the state of the world and what needed to change. The only problem was, as far as Quintus knew, there was no prospect of that happening. But until it did, all Arthur's dreams were just that: dreams.

Arthur's bigger task on this occasion was to try and improve the running of the local economy. Technically, of course, it wasn't his responsibility, but then neither was arresting the people whose responsibility it was - and who were ducking that responsibility in order to enrich themselves or otherwise improve their own lives.

The problem was that the economy was going backwards. In times gone by, this town was a stage on a major trade route that led down into Dumnonia and funnelled goods across the dangerous sea crossings to Armorica, Hispania and even as far as Rome. That trade had all but ceased: a few daring merchants still came to Dumnonia for things they literally could not obtain elsewhere - tin and lead mainly - but the demand for any kind of luxury goods had disappeared along with the capital required to fund the risky adventures of sending ships all the way to Britain. With the easy routes to Gaul cut off by the Saxon occupation on this side and the Franks holding the ports on the far side, Britain was becoming ever more an island, with just a limited trade direct to Armorica, with that acting as an entrepot to the rest of the Empire, such as it still was.

Arthur heard that way out to the east, there were still riches to be had and the Emperor of the East still held sway over an indescribably large domain. But most of the west - the Gauls, Hispania and Africa - had been overrun by barbarians who at the very least had disrupted trade.

And without that trade, many of the imports upon which the economy of Britain depended also did not come. Britain had mainly been a staple producer of raw materials - corn, wool, meat, tin, lead, timber - shipped to factories in Italy or the Gauls. Inasmuch as there were local industries, they were mainly supplying arms to the Army of the Rhine - which had ceased to exist. All manner of things - from vehicles to ploughs to building materials - had been imported, and cut off from that, many of the areas of the British economy which were still functioning could not function at full capacity, forcing more men back to doing work that could otherwise have been done more efficiently.

And ever more men and resources were being pulled out to pay taxes to fund armies that went around destroying fields that could otherwise be used for growing more food. And then, to top it off, administrators like these were skimming off the top for their own personal profit and stopping the produce ending up in the right places.

"Let's go, Quintus. We've got an economy to destroy."

Mons Badonicus

AD466

The wind swept over the ancient hill fort.

For four centuries, it had been deserted. The Romans had had no use for such places: their armies defended the borders of their territories, and within them they had civilian means to preserve the peace. These forts were here to protect tribe against tribe and primitive peoples against other primitive peoples: those without the siege technology to capture these forts. Vespasian hadn't even felt the need to apply himself when he had come through here in the AD60s: he had turned to his *primus pilus* centurion of the II Legion (Augusta) and said, "Take this place. Usual methods. Nothing special. Report to me at sundown." Salutes were exchanged and the army got on with its business, while Vespasian got on with his paperwork. Within a decade he would be emperor.

The Saxons had none of the technology, organization or techniques that would enable them to take this place. At best, they could hope to starve it out. Even so, Aurelianus' first suggestion was that they improve the defences, make it a proper fortress that might even present an obstacle to a latter-day Vespasian.

"We will need to fight a largely mobile war from a long way behind our lines. We cannot at this point organize the kinds of forces that can either defend our territory or claim back that which is lost. But we can hit and run: burn and kill Saxons where we find them. Our resistance may be futile but it is all we have."

The men gathered here on this desolate hill were thrilled by his words. Almost a decade had passed since the massacre of their leaders and in that time none in Britain had known peace, but neither had any truly stood up to the invaders.

Here and there, individuals had attempted to resist: fought the invading Saxons but, without the support of a network of neighbours or a true army, they had been unable to stop the rampaging Saxons.

Strangely, to the north, north of the Humber, where the Saxons had neither gone nor been sent, the "official" Roman army kept going through its paces, but its job remained to protect the island from the Picts. Although Octha offered a buffer zone to the north, there was no question that should the army move south against the Saxons, both Picts and Saxon guardians in the north would come south and overrun their deserted positions.

And so, cut off from the main supply routes to the south, the army struggled to feed itself, became more dependent on marauding into Pictish territory, thus incurring more hostility from the Picts - although they were unable to gather their strength to retaliate.

"No," said Ambrosius Aurelianus. "If we are going to be saved, we need to do it ourselves. And we cannot do it piecemeal, for if we try, we shall surely be gobbled up piecemeal. No, we must form ourselves into a mutual assistance force, capable of defending our own lands from the enemy and attacking them in theirs."

"To do that, we need to have secure places where we can run, hide and re-equip ourselves. This is one such place. It is just what we need to corral horses, establish weapons' manufacturies and keep blacksmiths. There will be others - Cadbury for one - and we must recruit both more people and defend more locations. We must find secure locations like this in the heartland and others, less secure, near the border from where we can respond quickly - or flee if necessary.

"We must ring the Saxons with a network of forts that do not allow them to escape, or to raid. We cannot allow them a moment's peace to gather their forces and attack us again in strength, for surely then we will go down.

"Our chief weapon must be the horse. We have horses; they do not. They have ships, which we do not; and so we must avoid trying to fight them on the water. Our biggest vulnerability will be our coastline, and again, forts such as this offer us bases from where we can repel their coastal assaults. Vortimer and my father showed us that it was possible in the days of the war before the massacre. We must do it again."

The men discussed and planned on top of that hill for two days, the bleak location reminding them of the dire situation that faced them in the country.

And then they took action

The resistance spread like wildfire.

Until this point, most of the men in the country had not held back from doing something out of fear, but from lack of leadership. None had shown the way to resist, and in each man's heart was a desire to protect his own. As that had failed, this new resistance offered a hope heretofore undreamt of.

Over the summer of AD462, forts across the south and midlands of Britain sprouted new defenses: trenches, walls, palisades. They were equipped with artillery: trebuchets, *ballistae*, mortars and more. Pits were dug and stores laid in. Huts, houses, factories, stables - all were constructed and defended.

Across the countryside, recruiting and requisitioning went on. With the structures of government in a shambles, there was no central authority capable of "enforcing" the requisition orders, and many - who were least affected by the depradations of the Saxons - remained aloof. But many gave what they could - of their time, their crops or their horses - to support a mission that might mean security for all over the long haul.

After the Massacre had come the Great Raid, where Saxons had poured over the countryside. But like a high tide at the beach, the flow was followed by the ebb. With insufficient numbers to hold the whole island, they retreated to the areas where they had traditionally been quartered. Kent became Saxon, as did the lands to the west occupied by Aelle and his crews, who became known as the "South Saxons". In the east, the Angles took over the lands of the Iceni and used their fens to defend themselves and the Icknield Way to go out raiding.

Further north, the Jutes occupied the lands north of the Wash and south of the Humber, reaching as far as Linnius.

To the rest of the country, they were still raiders. Warriors born and bred it was easier to group together in a band and hike across country pillaging and stealing what the wanted: livestock, slaves and produce. The Britons had tried to resist, but it had been in vain against such overwhelming, organized force.

Aurelianus' solution was to create impregnable - at least to the Saxons - bases across the British-held territory, and to station highly mobile forces at each of them. Resurrecting the post service that had collapsed during the Great Raid, he enabled his various units around the country to communicate, and instructed villagers to be ready to signal for help using fires - something that admittedly the Saxons often did for them anyway.

When the Saxons raided, the mobile forces could issue from their bases and meet strength with strength. Over the next couple of years, the number of raids diminished, and they became less invasive. Eventually, a rudimentary border was established between "Saxon" lands and "free Britain". And then Aurelianus started to turn the tables.

Initially planned for defence against Saxon raiders, the bases were often ideally placed for incursions against the Saxons. Even those that were further west - such as Badonicus in the south and Chester in the north - were ideal for preparing for a raid, keeping units up to fighting trim and with very short supply lines, and then staging closer to the border.

Within five years, Aurelianus had completely transformed the situation in Britain. The threat of the Saxons overrunning the entire island had retreated, but the border zone was in a state of continual warfare that it seemed neither side would be able to bring to an end.

8. Glastonbury

AD495

The draughts blew throught the Senate hall.

The time had come, Arthur knew. He had been consulting with his closest aides for over a week now and they had figured out the entire plan - in detail - for the next year. Obviously, he wasn't about to share the entirety of that plan with the entire Senate, but he had to tell them enough that they would give him what he needed.

He had two things he knew he could count on. First, he knew that Merula - still Leader of the House and by some miracle, still alive - was completely in his corner, knew and understood the plan - to be honest, had largely *devised* the plan over years of scheming - and was ready to intervene in exactly the right way on his behalf. Arthur couldn't shake the feeling that the "right way" might involve him being personally humiliated, but as long as he achieved what he wanted, they could pillory him in the town square like a petty thief for all he cared.

And he knew he could count on their greed and selfishness. Given the choice between a quiet, peaceful life and going off to war, they would choose peace. Given the choice between fighting and being overrun by angry Saxons, they would choose to fight.

The preliminaries had been observed and dispensed with. In truth, there had been a buzz going around the town for a few days that Arthur had some great announcement to make and they were not going to like it. The senators were waiting with bated breath to hear what it would be and did not want to wait fussing over details of tax assessments before they heard what Arthur had to say. The normal business of this meeting was tabled for the next session.

Merula, Leader of the House, called on Arthur to speak.

"Gaius Artorius, Dux Bellorum, you are hereby called upon to report upon your brief, the military and security situation of this island. It seems," he added with a wry grin, "that much of the island is still in the hands of the Saxons. What do you plan to do about that?"

Arthur rose and walked to the middle of the mosaic in the floor of the chamber which had once been a villa before the Great Raid. Its owner had departed for Armorica, and the structure - including the roof - had been burned and partially destroyed by the Saxons. Ever practical, the British had restored it for use as their meeting hall. Ever miserly, they had done a minimal amount of restoration. There was *a* roof, but it was nothing special. There were no doors, which led to a significant swirling wind: through the doors and up through the holes in the roof. The hypocaust had not been affected, and slaves were burning trees by the forest-ful, keeping the floor and walls warm, but sucking in yet more cold air from outside, leading to stronger draughts.

Internally, Arthur smiled at the thought that it was a great metaphor for the state of the island. Externally he frowned in concentration. He knew what needed to happen; knew what he needed to say to make it happen; but needed to find the right tone to convey both the seriousness of the situation and the optimism he felt about the opportunity they had *right now*.

He thought about the exact phrasing of Merula's question and nearly laughed aloud. Without telling him in advance, Merula had devised the exact phrasing that was needed to lead Arthur through the field of caltrops. How did he do that? Arthur wondered again. Was it just a high level of education and experience? A mad genius? Or magic? Merula always denied having magical abilities, and Arthur wasn't really superstitious anyway, but sometimes ...

He turned around and focused on the task at hand.

"At this moment, there is nothing I can do about it and, indeed, it seems to me that the situation is very grave.

"It has come to my attention that the Saxons have decided on another major raid next Spring, and wish to wipe out our bases and lines of supply. They would then turn and try and mop up outstanding resistance one town at a time."

Around the hall gasps of surprise could be heard from the Senators. This was news to them. Unsurprising, since at the current moment it wasn't, in fact, true.

"How do you know?" "How many?" "When?" "Where?"

Merula rammed his staff on the floor, demanding order.

"Gaius Artorius," he declaimed formally. "Please continue with your report."

Arthur walked a few steps across the mosaic, spun and continued.

"Over the past decade, we have felt a stiffening of the resistance along the border. We hear that ever more of the Saxons and their folk, the Angles and the Jutes have come across to join those already here.

"They have the men and they are starting to lack for land. Without our forward resistance on the border, they would have spilt out over the countryside long ago.

"Everything points to them staging for a raid next year to reduce us. Logic indicates that it will come this way. Ever since the Great Raid, they have known the layout of the country and where our strengths and weaknesses lie. And they both lie here, my friends. They both lie here in the middle west of the island. You know why."

He paused for a moment, letting them reflect on the reasons. Then summarized to drive home the point.

"Our wealth is here. The engine of our economy is here. And such forces as we have are overwhelming based here and supplied from here.

"You ask where would the raid come, and I say, here.

"You ask how, and I say I would expect an attack on three fronts. I would expect the Saxons to come from Kent up the main road to the Thames valley. They would come along the Thames to <Reading> and then down through the pass at Swindon to the Afon valley and through Aquae Sulis and then down to here. I would expect them to raid, burn and loot as they went. Their first mission would be to destroy what we have left and break my supply lines. Their secondary mission would be to take and hold forts, bases and territory as they could."

Arthur walked around again and looked at individual senators: those that he knew supported him, and those that he knew opposed him.

"What will be destroyed and what will be passed by, I cannot tell you. They will come like locusts and they will go where the resistance is least and the booty is most. I would imagine that they would avoid our bases on a first raid, preferring to break up our supplies. And with the men we have, it will be hard for us to do much more than harrass an invasion in strength.

"We hold our own on the border because they have not organized and mobilized. If they were to gather together all - or even a large portion - of their forces we would be unable to oppose them."

And in a rush, he wound up to his peroration.

"In short, my friends, we must conscript. This coming year will be decisive. We cannot allow it to be decided against us."

Once more he turned, and with his long strides returned to his seat to Merula's left, second among the "consulars", not that he had ever actually held that rank, but as Dux Bellorum he was considered second in seniority among the non-officers of the Senate behind its leader.

<Somebody> stood to dispute him.

"You tell us of wars and rumors of wars, and I say if we conscript we will bring about the ruin of this country.

"We are already being bled dry to provide for the troops you already have, and now you say that you must conscript all our young men to go hold a border for goodness knows how long against superior numbers. This is madness.

"I tell you, we can't afford to keep this country on a war footing forever. It will bankrupt us."

Merula stood and looked around him. Then he focused his eyes firmly on <whoever> and said, softly:

"I quite agree."

The hall was silent for moments, that stretched into a significant pause. What did this intervention mean? Merula was known to be in the same faction as Arthur; the only question was who was in who's pocket: who was master and who follower.

In that deep silence, the whispered question sounded like a roar.

"What?"

"We cannot continue this war forever. We need more time for the study of philosophy. Children should have time to grow up being children. We need to respect the rule of law and we need to curb the abuses and indignities of these 'regional governors' who seem to think they are above the law."

He turned to Arthur.

"What are you going to do about it? It's your job, you know, this keeping us safe thing."

Arthur had thought he was ready for what Merula was going to do, but this felt like a stabbing betrayal. He jumped up and strode forward as Merula returned to his seat and gently lowered himself into it, suddenly managing to look old and frail as he did so.

Arthur spat out the words, directed at Merula but hitting everyone in that cavernous hall. "Do you think I like nearly getting killed every week? Making inconsequential raids that just spur more retaliation? No, what we need to do is to gather an army and fight one battle that will ensure peace for a generation."

He stopped, paused and turned. The white heat of rage left him and an almost battle-like stillness descended.

"No, my friends, this is not a conscription forever. This is one year and one year only. This time next year, I will return here and will resign my title as Dux Bellorum. If I am successful, I will then run for the very proper job of Consul and earn my true right to occupy my seat among the consulars.

"I am not going to use these new forces to reinforce the border and have more ineffective raids. No, my plan is very simple. I will let the Saxons gather. I will let the invade. I will let them come down the Thames, but I will only let them come the way I want them to come. They will loot and burn, but we will have cleared out everything along their route. We will harrass them from our hilltops and we will force them along the way until they are forced into a position of disadvantage.

"And then they will have to fight a battle of my choosing. If the troops are there, my friends, we will win.

"We will win, my friends. I guarantee it."

Arthur stood in the centre of the mosaic and slowly turned around. As he did so, his eyes lingered here and there, but afterwards each and every senator felt that he was looking straight at him.

Hours later, a division was held and the motion was carried unanimously: a general conscription of the British would be held, and held immediately. They would form three legions, which would be handed to Arthur for training. One would form at Gloucester, one at Badonicus and one at Isca Dumnorium.

One thought was in every senator's minds as they left that evening: the Saxons were coming and the only choice was whether they would destroy everything in their path or whether Arthur would be able to successfully resist them.

The problem for Arthur was that the Saxons had no intention of coming.

Much of what he had said had been true or grounded in truth. More and more of the Saxon "volk" had come across the Channel from Germany until their homelands in northern Europe had been deserted to the tribes behind them - the Franks, the Huns and a smattering of Gothic tribes who had become detached from the main bodies who had overrun Gaul and Hispania and were now said to be in Italy and Africa.

Arthur certainly had enough first-hand experience to know that there were swelling numbers of armed Saxons all along the border territories where he fought from Linnius in the north down to the Arun in the south. And he knew that sooner or later they would break out, either in one big raid, or just in an effort to take a small piece of land at a time.

And he knew that the only way to "contain" them would be to have the kind of general conscription and armed forces along the border that he had rejected. With three legions, it was possible he could even invade the Saxon lands; but if he were to do that, he would be handing the territorial advantage to the Saxons. It would be easier to beat them if he were to bring them to a prepared battlefield of his choosing. And it would be prepared. He had spent almost twenty years preparing both the battlefield and for the battle.

The only remaining problem was to get the Saxons to do what he wanted. He had made it sound so easy, but in reality, his plan was devilishly cunning and required everybody to play their part and stick together. Treachery at this point could be fatal.

9. Canterbury

AD496

Lucullus was regarded warily by the Saxons.

He had arrived the previous day with a handful of warriors in tow and two tame Saxons that he had brought as interpreters. Their loyalty was questionable on both sides, but they had been held prisoner by the British for long enough to speak the local Gallic-derived language. They did not speak any Latin.

Norvel looked at them intently, trying to see if he could tell divine their intentions. Since Hengest's death, he had been the leader of the Kentish Saxons and was styling himself "King of Kent". With Aelle's forces protecting much of his border to the west, and with ever more reinforcements arriving from the continent, he felt strong and powerful, ready to flex his muscles and see where the chips fell.

That this man should come at this time was strange, very strange. What he claimed to offer was stranger still. The British feared the Saxons, but they also looked down on them. Why was this man willing to sell out their cause? Cerdic had agreed to peace with them and been destroyed for it. Did this man think he would be treated differently?

Lucullus stood erect and poised under their stares. He knew his reputation - the haughty one - but it didn't bother him. And in this situation it was probably more of an asset than a hindrance. These Saxons expected a particular demeanour from Romans, and Lucullus was just the man to give it to them. That he might die for his misplaced arrogance here was a possibility he accepted with equilibrium. He might also come out of it well. There was land to be had, good land, if the Saxons were to prevail and see him as their friend.

"You would betray your master in this?" Norvel asked and one of Lucullus' tame Saxons translated. "Does not that make you lower than the scum of the earth?" His tone, even before translation, conveyed the contempt that the Saxons had for weak men that betrayed the trust of their Lords.

Lucullus saw the emotion for what it was and batted it to one side as he would a flea. *No man*, let alone a barbarian, had contempt for a Licinius Lucullus. Who were these people?

"Arthur betrays his country and the good of his people. Is he my master then? I say not. I say that I represent the true will of the British people and that is to live in peace."

"And yet you encourage me to make war on your people."

"I say that the only way in which we can have long-term peace between Briton and Saxon is to destroy those forces that would perpetuate the war. One battle now, before Arthur has mobilized his new forces, and we can have peace in our lifetime. If you wait another half-year, you will invite Arthur to bring all his forces east - infantry, not mere cavalry - and allow them to grind you down. You will not be able to resist and you will be driven out of this land and back into the sea."

"So you say. Where is the proof?"

The word of a Licinius Lucullus was *not* to be doubted. The impudence of this man knew no bounds. He raised himself even straighter, even taller; his face took on a haughtier mien.

"Arthur has conscripted three legions. They are training even as we speak at bases in the west of England where you cannot reach them but I say that they are there. In six months they can be here. _Three legions_. You know what that means? Fifteen thousand men. Maybe not the equal of your men, but fifteen thousand men campaigning through Kent - with Roman tactics and supporting cavalry. Could you oppose that?

"You ask for proof that I am telling you the truth. Ask yourself this: can you risk the possibility that I am telling you the truth, and yet you do not act on it?"

Norvel remained quiet even after the translation had finished. He walked around the party, gauging them. It seemed this man was telling the truth, but ... something was off; wrong. What was it?

"I say you lie. Maybe there are three legions; maybe there are not. But you coming here ... you do not tell me the truth. You tell me something else; something is rotten in your speech.

"You will tell me the whole truth or you will die."

Lucullus looked blankly at Norvel. In fact, what he had told him was the truth: he had heard it from Arthur himself. Arthur had claimed that he wanted Norvel to come out and attack him, but Lucullus had not been able to credit that, and believed that Arthur had just told him that so that Norvel would stay put when he heard rumours of these new forces.

That he risked death in coming here was not news. But given that he felt that he *had* told him the truth, this seemed a difficult threat. He evaluated what else he could say.

"Arthur claims that he would benefit if you were to attack him. He thinks to harry you along your march with cavalry and then draw you to battle somewhere in the west."

Norvel listened to the translation with interest. Why had Lucullus not said this earlier? Presumably because it was implausible and Lucullus did not want Norvel to doubt his earnestness. For implausible it certainly was: if Norvel were to attack in strength, he would rapidly overrun and destroy whichever part of Britain he were to invade. Arthur could try and harry him, to be sure, but cavalry against a dozen men was one thing; against five or ten thousand was a different matter altogether. Behind a solid wall of shields he would be protected from a few pesky cavalry. They had demonstrated it many times.

"Is that really what he thinks? Or are you just sent here to make me think he thinks that, and then to stay here skulking while he collects his forces?"

Lucullus held on to his temper with great difficulty. This was like dealing with a child; worse, like dealing with an idiot child. How did he hope to beat Arthur? Had Lucullus picked the wrong side.

"I said he claims that. As I say, I believe that is a feint *precisely* to make you stay here, each guarding your territory individually and thus allowing him to conquer each of you separately - divided as you are from each other by London and Linnius. Note how assiduously he has worked and fought to keep those thorns in your flesh. Together you are too strong for him, and he knows it. His only hope is to keep you from combining."

Norvel nodded, accepting that the wisdom of this, and also that it was consistent with everything else Lucullus had said up until now.

"But one other thing worries me," he said, walking forward and tapping Lucullus on the chest. "You. Why you? Why now? What is in it for you?"

Lucullus felt threatened by the approach and the gesture and found it hard to concentrate on the translation, bizarrely coming from behind him. He felt himself start to slip away, become distant from reality.

Why me? He asked himself. Because I know that Arthur will lose. Because I know that I am the better man. Because I know that Arthur would not have sent me as a mere messenger. He knows that ultimately it must be him against me and that I will win. And that to do that and to preserve some British influence in the final settlement of this island I must come here and lead the Saxons so I can be the overlord of the island when they have defeated Arthur and his legions of amateurs. But how can I say that? How can I tell him that without insulting him and having him hack my head off here and now before he sees the wisdom of it?

"Arthur fears you," he ventured. "He has lost the support of the Senate and this is his one last desperate ploy to try and win back support in the council. I cannot continue to support a man who has lost, who knows he will lose and is prepared to destroy everything for the benefit of his own ego.

"If you fight Arthur, many of the British will support him just because they see it as Briton against Saxon and they are Britons. If I fight with you, many will see it as Briton against Briton and they will say that this dispute between leaders is not for them. They will sit out on the sidelines and wait for the battle to be over and get on with their lives. And when they do, they will be Britons living in a Saxon land."

"And what is it that you want out of all this?" Norvel demanded, finally starting to see what was happening inside Lucullus' head.

"I would expect to be Lord of the Western Saxons and their subjects," he replied as if he had stated this a dozen times already - or as if were obvious.

And as his man translated it, Norvel saw through the whole plan, and realized that it really *should* have been obvious.

He threw back his head and laughed.

From Canterbury messengers went out across Kent; they went to the South Saxons; they took ship and went across to Anglia, where the Iceni had been; and they went further north also, and visited with their brethren north of Linnius.

Everywhere the message was the same: Arthur, King of the Britons, was preparing a major force readying for a major expedition. He would attempt to attack all three nations separately, and reduce each of them in turn. Norvel requested that all the leaders gather at a suitable meeting point - he suggested Thanet Island, with its central location, secure boundaries, and easy access by boat - in order to discuss how they could work together to oppose this threat.

Lucullus and his translators came to the meeting. Unlike a Roman meeting, speedily and efficiently arranged, and organized with the precision of centuries of practice, the Saxon gathering was chaotic and inefficient.

No specific date was set for the meeting. Norvel had set off two days after sending out his messengers. Lucullus couldn't be sure, but he imagined that he and Norvel had arrived on Thanet before some of the leaders had even received their invitations. The other leaders would come when they were ready.

There was no agenda or meeting protocol. As leaders arrived, they conferred - and drank - until all the news had been exchanged. If a plan was developing, Lucullus - who was present, although hampered in his understanding by the difficulties the translators faced in keeping up with the disorganized, riotous conversation where often three people were talking (well, shouting) at the same time - could not discern it. Used as he was to the organized, Roman way of doing things, he could not even understand the relative ranks of these individuals. The subtleties - in particular, the contests of both drinking prowess and physical ability - passed him by; to him they just seemed to be indications of barbarism and an inability to stick to the task at hand.

About a month passed - January was slipping away by the Roman reckoning - by the time all the leaders had arrived on Thanet Island. By then, unrecognized by Lucullus, a rough organization had formed between the leaders and a plan was starting to develop, in part because - as Arthur had recognized the previous year - only one plan really could develop.

Ormod of Anglia emerged from the following week as the undisputed leader of the combined Anglo-Saxon forces. The son of Osric, who had been commander at Venta Icenorum at the time of the massacre, Ormod had bested the other leaders in drinking, stave fighting and describing the best plan to defeat the British. Another week passed in fleshing out the details of their plans, and agreeing the point at which they would gather their forces (Silchester). Each of the tribes was responsible for individually breaking out of their territory, and marching up or down the nearest convenient Roman road, and converging on Silchester by the second full moon from now. They would then blaze a trail to the west, largely following the Roman road to Aquae Sulis, killing, burning, looting, raping. If Arthur's forces were prepared to meet them in battle, they would do battle, but if not, they were a force of nature let loose behind the enemy's lines. It was a complete plan to the Saxons.

To Lucullus, used to more detailed planning for a single Roman raid into enemy territory, it was a joke.

But numbers told. And between them, the Anglo-Saxons had committed twenty thousand vicious warriors to the task. Arthur could not even match the numbers; he certainly could not match the ferocity. And his troops would be green, even if they had been trained by the time the battles took place.

And whatever Arthur said, he couldn't really want to be fighting on the defensive against these kinds of numbers, able to divide his forces and destroy each of them individually.

10. Mons Badonicus

AD496

The rider was spotted coming up the hill.

Arthur had set up his temporary base at South Cadbury Hill. While he knew that Lucullus would betray what plans he knew, he also knew that Lucullus didn't know everything. And what he didn't know, he couldn't betray.

For example, Lucullus did not know that Arthur was going to station himself here. He had believed - reasonably enough - that Arthur would stay at his usual base at Badonicus until the legion that was in training there was ready to march and fight in whatever campaign occurred.

And although it must have been obvious to him, he also did not know the depth of planning Arthur had done, and the additional post riders - and post stations - he had set up.

One of the troubles with allowing the enemy to take and destroy your territory is that key infrastructure will be taken and destroyed - and that includes your messenger post. Arthur's solution to this was to build an entire backup system "off the main roads" - literally. He had had a team of dedicated riders spend months working up a network of hidden stations and hidden routes that would be largely ignored by the invading army and, as much as possible, off their main routes.

The messenger arrived at the top of the hill, slid off his horse and saluted Arthur.

"Greetings. All the reports are now in. All three columns have broken out from behind their borders and are converging on the Thames, burning everything as they go. We expect them to form up on the south side of the river at Reading three days from now."

For a professional, mobile force like Arthur's, three days was enough time to cross the country and start back. But for a force entirely composed of - disorganized - infantry, burning and looting as it went, three more days was not unreasonable.

The forces coming down from the north had already been in train over a week, and the plan would have been clear even if it had not already been in Arthur's mind. From Reading, they would probably strike west towards Aquae Sulis - another three days if they stuck to it. But Arthur's plan remained to drag them further south, to Badonicus, the battlefield he had prepared.

Already he had units in the field contesting the Saxons' right of passage through the countryside. There was a limit to what he could do, since he had to seem to oppose them in all directions, but his commanders all knew the same plan: as long as they keep coming south and west, let them come. Any bands foolish enough to become significantly separated from the main body of marchers were quickly encircled and killed. Every unit taken out now was one left to be faced at *the* battle.

All around him was the din of ongoing legionary training. The basic three months' training was over, but the II Legion (Artoria), which he had moved from Isca Dumnorium to Cadbury, was continuing its daily drill practices. There was being trained, and then there was being ready. Arthur wanted his legions more than ready when the day came. In his mind, he had already planned the battle and every day he ensured that his men knew how they would be expected to fight it. For that day was less than a week away now.

"Charge!"

The trumpets sounded and the horsemen rode in three columns to where the wall of shields was rapidly forming. Over the past two days, the cavalry had managed to drive the Saxons further south than they had wanted to go, off the good Roman road and into the countryside. They hadn't done it all with cavalry of course - they had fortified two of the river crossings and forced them south of the hill line.

They were now not far from Venta Belgarum, and from there the road ran straight west across the downlands to Badonicus. With intent, that road had not been blocked east of Badonicus and the cavalry would be able to draw back and harry those who left the road.

But for now, there was still the hard work of sheep-driving to be done. The wall had fully formed and they knew what that meant. The horses would happily charge through any gaps that might be left in the wall, but faced with a solid wall of steel they would shy away at the last minute.

Quintus knew that and didn't try to make his horse go straight. As he neared the wall, he pulled to the left and thrust his lance down over the wall. As he did so, a Saxon batted at it with his axe and knocked it away. Quintus kept turning and kept hold of his lance. Then he was streaking away from the wall as the next man rode in.

Quintus knew that Arthur was right: these cavalry against infantry skirmishes were indecisive. One or two men on either side might end up dead or injured, but the vast body of men would just roll on. Only a major infantry action would see an end to this vast army.

Quintus signalled for his men to regroup at the top of the rise. They allowed the horses to catch their breath and watched as the Saxons slowly moved away. They allowed them some time - after all, it was this slow south-westwards drift they were trying to encourage.

As the Saxon army started to climb the far side of the undulating valley and pick its way over some rocky ground, Quintus signalled his men again and they started to trot down the hill. Again, the Saxons formed up and presented a solid wall of shields. Again the charge and the ineffective use of lances and discharging of spears. Then the retreat and once more quiet.

"Last one for today, lads," said Quintus as he watched the Saxons move on. "Then we'll let them make a big of progress."

And they charged down the hill again and up the other side.

The Saxons were very sloppy about the marching camps they built.

Since time immemorial, the Romans had had a clear policy on building marching camps and it was so engrained in the troops by the end of basic training that once they arrived at the site and the surveyors had marked out the corners, each man could carry out all his assigned tasks without even having to ask for orders or directions. Within an hour, a solid, fortified camp was built that would resist even direct assault.

The Saxons seemed to just decide where to put their camps based on where they were when they became bored with marching for the day. They had no surveyors to point out the key features, such as where water would be raised and latrines sunk. And the outer fortification was little more than a token ditch with the baggage stacked up against it as an obstacle.

Fighting at night was tricky: it was very hard to see what you were doing, to begin with. Telling who was friend and who foe was even more tricky.

But the sloppiness of the Saxon preparations gave the Britons an advantage. Entirely mounted, their need for organization was less than the defenders, and the sloppiness of the camp meant that the defenders could not really count on it to assist in the defence.

It was deep into the night when Quintus attacked, coming out of the dark like demons on horseback. Men threw torches into the camp, trying to light tents and other flammable items. They crashed into the camp with lances and spears out, and tangled with the carts that formed the outer wall.

Saxons sprang to the defence, but it was spotty and disorganized. They were unable to form a strong shield wall, because of the darkness, the obstacles underfoot and the presence of enemy horsemen.

Quintus charged into the camp and thrust his lance into the face of a defender, dimly lit by the burning of torches around him. He pulled back and thrust into another man's face. Then he retreated as the enemy organized and swung axes at his horse's legs.

Like a wave washing against the shore, Quintus and his men charged and retreated for two hours before dawn broke, finally showing the damaged camp and injured men. Then Quintus retreated to safety, back to the north-east, blocking the obvious line of retreat.

Not that Norvel had any intention of retreating.

Norvel was angry with Lucullus.

"You did not tell me that we would be harried in this way. You said nothing of attacking at dark and burning my camps," he complained.

Lucullus stared at him, outwardly haughty, but internally in shock that Norvel could have been so ignorant and now, having been beaten in this way, that he should be so uncouth as to take it out on him. Good commanders took setbacks in their stride and learnt from them. Great commanders anticipated the enemy's moves before they happened.

"We should build proper, defensive camps every night," observed Lucullus. "I did try to tell you that."

"But we have a great superiority in numbers," countered Norvel. "How *dare* they attack?"

"Because they have superiority in mobility, and in tactics," replied Lucullus. "But that is a minor annoyance; a fly in the ointment. They are doing this just to slow us down and deter us from continuing. We must be resolute."

"If they want to deter us from continuing, why do they keep moving behind us, rather than blocking the road in front of us?"

Lucullus thought about that. It had not occurred to him up until this point, but for the past couple of days, the enemy had indeed seemed to take up positions behind the Saxon army.

"They are probably scared of being in front. They know they cannot stand in your way; you will just run over them. But at the same time, if they follow you and dog your footsteps, you will be slowed down and will not be able to move as quickly west as you would like. And eventually you will be ground down and run out of supplies and have to retreat."

Supplies were another issue. Norvel had assumed that they would just take want they wanted from the peasants, who would be unable to oppose them. But foraging had been hard because of the continual presence of Arthur's cavalry - it had not been possible to continually detach small units to forage from each farm along the front, and the whole army was too large to be able to survive on the small rations that could be had from the farms that were in their direct line of march.

Once again, Lucullus tried to suggest dividing the army into columns; each column could then protect itself against the cavalry, but divided they would be able to cover much more territory and forage from more farms.

"No, I tell you, no," said Norvel, intuitively distrusting the advice. Apart from anything else, once separated, his units would be prey for Arthur's forces which, he sensed, were out there somewhere waiting for him. Moreover, once separated, he would find it very difficult to keep the columns together and they would end up all over the place. And finally, he just didn't trust Lucullus - and thus his suggestions.

They crept on slowly, meandering through the countryside, being shepherded on towards the prepared battlefield.

Another argument broke out when they came upon the road.

"It will be blocked like the other," insisted Norvel.

"True, that may be true. But until it is, we can take it," argued Lucullus.

Ormod stalked over to enter the discussion.

"It may be that the road is blocked, but I said it then and I say it again. We should roll over any blockage in the road. We can take them."

"But they fortify so well. It would cost lives."

"We have the lives to give. What we do not have is time or food. We need to capture towns, take food and kill Britons. Only then will we be able to drive these peasants into the sea and make Arthur grovel at our boots."

The argument continued for half an hour before finally the obvious prevailed and they took the road.

Mons Badonicus rose to the south of the road like a shining beacon.

Lucullus already knew where it was and knew what was there: the I Legion (Artoria), along with two divisions of cavalry. All well dug in. A trap waiting and baited for the Saxons with enough food to feed this army for a year.

"You can't starve them out," pointed out Lucullus. "If the whole point is to get their food because they have more than us, then the arithmetic simply doesn't work."

"They are too well entrenched to hope to assault them," contributed Ormod. "We would have to attack uphill with trenches and stakes and cavalry to deal with. I don't think it's possible."

"What choice do we have?" asked Norvel, aware of the difficulties but unable to think of any other way of proceeding.

He suddenly turned to face Lucullus. "Do they have water up there?"

"Yes," he replied, but then doubted himself. Did they truly have wells, or were they reliant on rain water to fill cisterns? "But I think they depend on it to rain."

Norvel thought about this for a while. Here was one downside to adding five thousand men to an encampment designed for four hundred. A man could go without food for days - or even weeks - at a time if need be. But water was a daily essential. Take a man's water away for two or three days and he was a dead man. How long, he wondered, how long?

"Call the shaman," he ordered. The magic man came forward and was consulted. Would it rain in the next week? He did his dance and spilt fluids on the floor. No, it would not. For the next week, there would be no rain.

Norvel made his decision. They would dig in around the base of this hill, weaken them with thirst, and then storm the camp on the seventh day.

As plans went, it wasn't a bad one.

They fortified the base of the hill, surrounding it with two ditches and two palisades: one facing inwards, one facing outwards. They sank wells - a gratifyingly long way down, even here at the base of the hill - and ensured their own water supply. They sent out scouts in parties of a thousand to reconnoitre what was going on and to try and forage for whatever food remained in the neighbourhood.

All their actions were watched both from the top of the hill and from neighbouring hills. Every day, several times a day, messengers rode off to the north and others came back. Try as they might they could not catch any of the horsemen.

Three days passed, then four, and the siege continued. Then from the top of the hill a small delegation came down to meet with the Saxon leaders.

"We are dying of thirst," they complained. "What terms will you give us for surrender?"

11. Mons Badonicus

AD496

Arthur was no longer at Cadbury.

The forty miles he had to cover from Cadbury to Badonicus was almost nothing for a horseman; still less for the post riders who covered the distance in both directions each day. But for his two legions of infantry - III Legion (Artoria) from Gloucester had now joined them as well - marching across countryside rather than down the main road, it was a two-day slog. That he managed to get near the top of the rise just to the north of Badonicus was due to the tireless efforts of his harrying cavalry preventing the Saxon infantry from coming too far north without combat. While the combat was often ineffective and more tiring and time-consuming than deadly, it served its purpose when all Arthur really needed was to keep the Saxons away from the forest where he was staging.

All was now in readiness. He just needed to make sure that everything went according to plan and that he could deploy all three legions, and force the Saxons to commit.

He wandered up to the top of the rise and looked out through the trees. In the distance he could see Mons Badonicus rising up, but he could not see what was going on up there.

Quintus came and stood beside him. "Do you want to go and have a closer look?"

Arthur considered. "I'd like to, but I don't think it's worth the risk. We've come this far, we don't really want to give it away."

"The delegation has come down the side of the hill and they're treating right now. Only time will tell what deal is struck."

"It doesn't matter. We aren't going to be bound by whatever they agree to, no matter what. I just want them looking in, not out, and the key moment."

One of Quintus' men came riding up.

"Sire, the delegation have started to retreat up the hill. The formation they are in says that they have reached an agreement to leave. They will start leaving the settlement soon. Presumably they have agreed to give up their armour and weapons."

He rode off.

Shortly, another man rode up.

"The first men have started to form up at the edges of the encampment and are coming out. They appear to be disarmed, Sire. I think it is time."

"That's my decision, of course," corrected Arthur. "But I agree with you: it is time."

He moved back into the woods, not really needing to hurry. Everything had been prepared for this moment.

"I don't like this. There's something wrong."

Norvel turned to face Lucullus as the translator completed the thought.

"What do you mean?"

"They shouldn't give up this easily. I would expect them to hold on to this position; buy Arthur some time to try and mobilize his other units."

The leaders had promised that all the men would surrender and come out without armour or weapons. The cavalry would leave their horses as well, and all the food would be left undisturbed. The Saxons would have possession of the camp by nightfall.

In exchange, the Saxons had agreed to let the Britons leave alive.

"But you tell me they are peasants who do not want or know how to fight. Why should they sacrifice their lives for a lost cause?"

Lucullus heard the words but could not shake the feeling that Norvel was missing something. Something big. He wanted to shout that it was all a trap - but how could it be? Just something about his instincts about Arthur told him that something here was not as it should be.

Something about the way the men were moving. They were coming through the barricades, moving slowly down the hillside. They were unarmoured, it was true, but ...

"Do they look half-dead to you?"

Norvel asked the translator for clarification, but none was immediately forthcoming. Then Lucullus elaborated.

"These men claim to have given up due to lack of water. I would expect them to be stumbling, falling down, looking weak and pathetic. But these men ... are in formation! It's a trick!"

Norvel immediately saw what Lucullus was saying. But he did not know what to do about it. What threat could unarmed men be, even in formation? Ormod provided the answer.

"Look! Behind them! The fourth rank!"

Norvel stared. And there, sure enough, darting behind the first three ranks were glints of metal. Metal shields, metal spears. The first three ranks were a decoy and behind them were coming the soldiers, fully armed.

"Prepare to repel the assault! Man the barricade!"

Agrippa had never expected to get all the way to the wall without the deception being uncovered. Truth be told, he had never believed they would go for it in the first place. But, as one of Arthur's few confidantes in this plan from the very beginning, he knew that the deception was just one twist within another.

Once the first spears were launched from the Saxon lines, he called the order and the first three ranks of unarmed men turned and fled through the formation. The rest of the men then formed up as the others ran back to the camp for their equipment. The legion formed up tightly and moved at parade-ground speed across the uneven hill. On his command, Agrippa's men cast their javelins in four volleys and then charged on to the barricades.

The defences gave the Saxons an edge, no doubt about it. So did their numbers. Time would tell how organization and preparation would play out.

Across the valley, less than a mile away, the other two legions were coming at the double. Even so, the II Legion would have to hold for over a quarter of an hour before relief arrived.

Arthur ached to commit his cavalry - they could have bounded up and attacked in much less time - but although he had doubts about his ability to launch a surprise attack from the rear, to have used his cavalry at this point would have alerted them to that very real danger.

The two legions were formed up in four divisions of five cohorts each. His plan was to attack from the north and try and suck in as many of the Saxons as he could along a roughly half-mile front. His cavalry would be deployed to protect his wings and stop the Saxons using their still-superior numbers to roll him up.

But first he had to make it to the battlefield.

On the hill, the walls of shields were kept apart by the rough palisade of the Saxon defensive line. As the first rank fought and stabbed, others from behind tried to dismantle, remove, disrupt that palisade. In cramped and tight conditions, it was almost impossible to move, let alone remove the tighly bedded stakes.

Over two yards apart, both sides were resorting to siege spears; the Saxons more effective because their defensive wall more than made up for being further down the hill. On Agrippa's signal, the Britons retreated five steps and took a breath.

Agrippa hoped - rather than believed - that the Saxons might be foolish enough to abandon their defences and follow their retreat. But it didn't happen. Before they could have the opportunity to look around and consider what else might be going on, Agrippa ordered his men back to the attack.

Suddenly, just to his left, a number of stakes came flying loose and they were quickly tumbled into the ditch. Men charged into the breach, forming a mini-wall inside the palisade and facing the Saxons. The breach was there for a moment, and then Saxons came flying into breach, literally pushing the Britons off the wall over the ditch by sheer force of numbers behind their shields. Stabbing down with their siege spears, one of the Britons' was stabbed through the eye and fell to the ground, dying.

Suddenly a commotion from behind the Saxon lines and a giant roar went up. Agrippa knew what that meant! From behind the Saxons came the belling sound of shields crashing into each other and the sharp cacophony of swords rattling into spears. From the corner of his eye, Agrippa saw a flight of javelins crash into the backs of the Saxons opposite him.

Now more logs were coming out of the rough palisade and the trench was filling with logs, bodies and discarded equipment. Agrippa grabbed a siege spear and leapt up to the Saxon side of the ditch, thrusting it before him. He impaled a Saxon and thrust his shield into his face to force him out of the way. At his back he felt others climb up beside him and more press up to hold the breach.

As the weight of the attack grew from outside, the Saxons simply did not have the numbers to resist every thrust from the inside wall, and here and there up and down the line, Britons established breaches in the Saxon defences and drove on through to do battle on equal terms.

The battle had descended into chaos.

In the centre, the British forces attacking both inwards and outwards had met and split the Saxon forces in two. But the confined space between the palisades had allowed the Saxons to form a new defensive wall and their numbers were superior there.

Further away, the Saxons had voluntarily spilled through their own defences, moving around and trying to encircle the British forces coming down the hillside. They were slowly succeeding and the British were inexorably being killed.

But the long front on which Arthur had chosen to attack from outside had paid dividends: he had managed to break through at multiple points and sucked in considerable numbers of the enemy on disadvantageous terms. And now he was through the palisades, the time-tested Roman tactics of advance-open-thrust-close were reaping their heaps of dead. And as the battlefield started to open up, the cavalry came into their own, charging down and mopping up loose units who had become separated from the main body of the Saxon army.

The battle still rested on a knife-edge, but Arthur felt it was swinging his way.

The bugler signalled "retreat and reform".

Arthur's troops pulled back from the defensive works, taking yet more of it with them. As they did so, the Saxons followed. And when they did, they lost the battle.

Out on the plain, with two legions in front of them and another behind, and surrounded by cavalry, the Saxons went down to a mighty slaughter.

As the sun set, two thousand Saxons asked for quarter and surrendered.

12. Glastonbury

AD496

Arthur entered the Senate chamber to rapturous applause.

He had achieved the impossible: he had drawn the Saxons into open battle, and, once there, managed to roundly defeat them. There were still Saxons in the east, of course, but any lingering threat that they might come west and again ravage the heart of the country had gone. Arthur had saved Briton for the British. And here he was!

In the aftermath of the battle, word had flown that Arthur was victorious and the Saxons defeated; indeed, destroyed, wiped out. The Senate had gathered and, in Arthur's absence, issued a series of decrees awarding him the highest honors. The very men who had opposed all his actions now gloried in the results of those actions - safety and security at last!

And Arthur had kept his promise to bring the Saxons to battle within a year; the army could now be decommissioned and the conscripts returned to their farms.

Arthur acknowledged the applause, moved to his customary place and sat down.

The consul began the proceedings and then asked Arthur to speak "on the state of the Republic and the Saxon threat."

Arthur rose and moved to the centre of the mosaic, poised, yet thoughtful. "I think," he began, "that it would be happier to take those in the reverse order."

He paused and looked around the chamber.

"As you already know, the Saxon army is no longer a threat to us in the West. Over twenty thousand Saxons were killed at the siege of Badonicus and another two thousand who survived were disarmed, swore perpertual allegiance to the Senate of Britain and were sent home.

"The number of useful Saxon fighters can now be measured in the few thousands. They could possibly outnumber our full-time professionals, but they, too, have none of those. They would need to strip their lands in order to put together an army that could again threaten our borders.

"But by the same token, we can still not evict them from this island. It may be - in fact, I would expect - that many of the families who have lost fathers and eldest sons will consider returning to the continent where they may feel they have better opportunities than they do here, but we cannot make them move, nor can we dislodge them from their current strongholds."

There was a noticeable intake of breath as he said this. For most here, the "Saxon threat" and "the Saxons being here" were interchangeable sentences. Not so for Arthur, who distinguished very clearly between their presence, and indeed, their military strength, about which he was neutral, and their risk to the independence, prosperity and values of Britain.

"I say that, at this point, we are at a crossroads. We have guaranteed ourselves peace for a generation - we have destroyed a generation of Saxon warriors, and they will need to wait for their forces to replenish and their young men to grow up. In twenty years, they will once again be able to pose a threat to us, should they wish.

"So, will they pose a threat?" He asked with the appropriate rhetorical flourish. Among the audience, there were those - like Merula - who still appreciated the technique of Greek and Roman oratory and rhetoric and they sat back and relaxed to enjoy what was, they knew, going to be a fantastic speech. The scribes, responsible for copying down the notes of the meeting, sensed the same thing and increased their intensity to catch as much of what was said as verbatim as possible. This was a speech that would need to be recorded for the archives - up there with Cato's famous filibusters.

"That is, curiously enough, for us to decide today. You see, people create a threat when they feel threatened. Let us review our interactions with the Saxons.

"For fifty years, we felt threatened by them and their raiding ships. Then Vortigern did a deal with them and the raids ended - in exchange for allowing them to settle here and paying them to defend us against the Picts and Irish. And for twenty years - as partners - neither felt threatened and there was peace.

"Then what happened, my colleagues? You should know, because even if you were not members at the time, you are now members of this body and should know what decisions it has made over the years.

"We refused to cooperate and engage with them. We rejected the alliances we had signed and reneged on the pledges we had made. We refused to pay the Saxons, and we refused to cooperate them. Yet we did nothing to clean up the situation and allowed them to hold territory against our sovereign will.

"With what results, O Senators? What happened? Well, the Saxons rebelled and took what we would not give them. As we all - or at least those of us that were here - must have known they would. And for twenty years they ran riot is this land of ours until - slowly but surely - they were tamed by the efforts of the great Ambrosius Aurelianus. Tamed, but at a cost.

"You applaud me today, Britons, for adding the next chapter in this story. But it is not the final chapter. There never is a *final* chapter, but this story is very much incomplete. This island holds Britons, and it holds Saxons. It is big enough for all the people but it is not big enough for two ways of life. Either ours must prevail - or theirs will."

Again the dramatic pause, the rhetorical flourish. The questioning pose, as if a thought had hit him like one of Jupiter's lightning bolts from heaven.

"But, my friends, what is our way of life? What makes it ours and not theirs? And have we given it up in order to achieve this victory for which you applaud me?

"I stand here, holder of a title I still consider unconstitutional - I hold it because it is what is needed in order to get the job done, not because I approve of it. And today, as I said I would, I wish to lay it down and announce my desire to stand for election to that very constitutional post of Consul.

"But before I do, let me reiterate that I hold the *unconsitutional* title of *Dux Bellorum* right now for very sound reasons. Simply put, because there was no *constitutional* route which would have preserved this republic.

"Think about that for a moment. There was no constitutional way of preserving the constitution. This tells you something - or at least it should.

"What makes us different from the Saxons is that we are not families, bands and tribes; we are a constitutionally mandated society under a set of laws. *All of us!* Each and every one of us is under the laws that we as a body choose to pass, and all of those are *supposed* to be in line with our constitution, which says what kind of people we are."

He paused again for a while to let that sink in. Looked at individual faces to see how they were taking his lecture in basic Roman governance. Knowing all this, but as background knowledge, not something they used to inform their daily decisions; thinking that there was always someone else who would do the dirty work for them.

"We are not a warlike people. We have been at war for so long that it often seems like war is a key part of who we are, but just a century or so ago, our grandparents knew a period of peace. A period of peace unprecedented in history. Neither Greeks nor Egyptians not Babylonians nor Republican Romans had known a period of peace as long as the two hundred years of security ushered in by Hadrianus."

His voice swelled, reached to the rooftops.

"A golden age, my friends. A golden age of the world. And yet, it slipped through our fingertips. *Rome* was destroyed. Not in my lifetime; not in the lifetimes of most of us, although one or two might remember it," this last with a glance and a smile and Merula, who claimed to remember where he was - and what he was reading - when the news came that Rome had been sacked. His claim that he was reading about the fall of Troy in *The Iliad* made the claim somewhat dubious, but Arthur was not one to doubt the word of Merula.

"We have the opportunity here and now to try and re-build that golden age. Not across the whole of Europe, but we can do it here, in this Albion of ours. We can stand out as a beacon of hope to the rest of Europe in this night of domination of Barbarians. We can remain an island of civilization in the midst of a sea of Chaos.

"Or we can choose to give up our values and what we believe in. We can descend into the pit of barbarism ourselves and, regardless of what happens to our bodies, sacrifice our souls to the barbaric values and methods of the Saxon invader.

"It is our choice and today is the day we choose."

And he walked back to his seat and sat down. For a few moments all was silent in the chamber as the majority of those there were temporarily transported by his oratory from their daily concerns to a broader view, a wider view of what it meant to be *Roman*; not just the lifestyle; not just the privileges; but the responsibilities and *duties* that went with it. A duty to truth; and virtue; and to be the light of civilization for all mankind.

Then the applause broke out. For today at least, the hero could do no wrong.

But would that last? When the applause died down, Merula called the assembly to order and dismissed them. And then invited Arthur and a few others to dine at his house. They accepted. But then, who could refuse?

The dinner was pleasant, with like-minded individuals sharing an intimate conversation.

Many of those present had been with Arthur at the battle of Mons Badonicus, and the first two courses passed with a discussion of the battle and their roles in it. Those who were not there were impressed with the courage and skill of those who were, but to Arthur's mind this was all the more symptomatic of the problems facing Britain. Without the stirring oratory of the Senate meeting, he raised the same issues he had brought up then.

"We cannot afford to continue viewing the Saxons as the enemy; they simply are not. They came here willingly, under contract to defend us. They are warlike and have a simple worldview that goes with that: kill or be killed. If we work with them, we can all benefit, but if we insist on fighting them, we will all lose. And, eithout the kind of all-out commitment that we have just made every generation, it will ultimately be us that lose."

"Why?" asked <somebody>.

"Because, you simpleton," interjected Merula, "while Arthur has just won a great victory, he has just killed the fathers of some sixty thousand little Saxon brats who will learn at their mother's knee who killed their darling father and swear revenge. And in twenty years' time when they have grown up they will carry out that threat.

"And Arthur may or may not be alive; they may or may not kill him. But they will do great destruction across this land. And if we beat them, then what? They will again have children who will swear vengeance on the heads of those who killed their fathers.

"And we will lose *not* because they are better than us, or more warlike than us, or more prepared than us, but for *the very simple reason that they have less to lose than us*.

"Think about what Arthur did: he tricked them into coming here with the promise of wealth and the opportunity to destroy us by taking out a couple of our key cities. And now the tables are turned, Arthur says we cannot destroy them. How is this possible? Because they do not have *key cities*; they do not have large forts that are critical to their defence; they do not have infrastructure that can be degraded. They are not a civilized people; if civilization falls apart, what do they care? They can have their little lords of nowhere-in-particular and whereever-I-am-right-now and maybe they meet once a year in some *moot* or whatever and thrash out problems, or possibly the *King* of Thanet Island goes to war with the *King* of Rutupiae and sort it out on the battlefield. As long as they have enough food to eat and enough steel to make swords, they are happy.

"Books? Who needs them? Cities? What benefits do they really bring? Baths? What for? Law courts? Easier to use a sword. You get the picture?"

Arthur laughed. "Merula, you do take this so very personally. Not to be rude, but I think I have guaranteed civilization for your lifetime, at least."

Merula smiled at Arthur, but the bitter edge remained. "You may be right, young man, but it is cold comfort to know that for all that I have had in my life, all those I leave behind - my children, grandchildren, friends, comrades, good men and women all - will be left in the night of barbarism. I have fought against it my whole life and it pains me to see it slip from the grasp of those left behind."

"Then let us choose otherwise," replied Arthur. "I mentioned a choice today, and while the idea that we have to choose today is maybe a rhetorical flourish, the choice is real but is a choice for all of us to make together.

"If civilization is to survive, then we have to not beat the Saxons as men, but as *an idea*. Their idea, as Merula says, is 'each man for himself'. Each man wants to become a Lord, and each Lord wants power over his rivals.

"That is not our way. We have rivals, but we are all rivals in the glory of Rome. My greatness is not based on whether you fear me, or whether I can destroy you, but whether or not you believe that I can contribute to the greatness of what Rome stands for.

"How does that win against the Saxon? It cannot win by force of arms; that is their way and regardless of the military results, they will ultimately win. We have to overwhelm them with our culture. We need to win over the hearts and souls with what Rome stands for and has to offer.

"To paraphrase Merula: we have to get them to want books, cities, baths and lawyers. Only then will we win."

The others looked at him and at Merula, once again struck by the notion that in a land of midgets, these two men were intellectual giants. Where many fumbled to even know right from wrong, and they themselves struggled to know how to achieve their aims, these two had it all figured out two hundred years into the future. It was almost as if *they had been to the future* and were now just coming back to tell them what was inevitably going to happen. Almost like fortune tellers with their crystal spheres.

But over and over again, they both mentioned a choice. While making it clear that only one selection would be considered valid by their offspring.

"What does that look like?" asked <somebody> again, speaking for all the others in the dining room.

"We must engage with the Saxons. Not take our army east, but our culture," stated Merula authoritatively.

"But it is already there. The majority of people living east of the Arun are already British."

"The people are," replied Arthur. "That is true. But the culture is not. They are ruled by Saxons and the Saxons do not share our culture and where it is not supported it cannot thrive. London is a beacon of civilization - because we still hold it. Linnius is civilized - because we still hold it.

"But Camulodunum is a ruin. Claudius' fair city is back to what it was after Boudicca burned it to the ground: a mess. Canterbury is still a town with some buildings but they are cattle sheds, not law courts. We need to change that."

"And," added Merula, "there is also the *difficult* part, which Arthur is keeping back from you. We need to convince the Saxons that they *want* it to change.

"Oh, and we have twenty years."

"Is that even possible?" asked <somebody>, breathlessly. "I wouldn't even know where to begin."

"Oh, that's easy," said Merula. "Vote for one Gaius Artorius who I hear will be running for Consul next month. And then support every aspect of his legislative programme energetically and enthusiastically; argue for it and campaign for it. Oh, and convince everyone you can that the money they spend over the next twenty years is worth every penny if they want to see anything they own passed on to their grandchildren. In another century Britain will be Saxon if we fail."

The next month went by in a whirlwind.

Arthur had been used to ruling by dictat and working with like-minded individuals who were sufficiently familiar with him to know that, even if he ordered something that seemed unexpected to them, he was going to be right and that they should "just get on with it."

Not so the privileged nobles and electors of Western Britain.

They were grateful to him for saving them, and pleased that the expensive conscript army could be disbanded. But now he wanted to start spending more money on an expensive and ridiculous project to "civilize" the Saxons. As if that made any sense: they were barbarians.

Patiently, over and over again, he covered the same ground. Winning a battle was one thing; winning a war was more complicated; but winning the peace required a different skillset. And Arthur was starting to wonder if it was one that he had.

His surrogates, Merula chief among them, also campaigned energetically among the electors. There was little doubt that Arthur would be elected - his reputation after Badonicus was just too stellar - but the question now became one of whether he could manage to get his aggressive programme of legislation through the Senate.

He could, of course, have resorted to the old trick of hiding his agenda until after the election and then trying to force it through a reticent Senate; but he reasoned - with the essential concurrence of Merula - that to do so would generate enormous resistance from a Senate that thought the difficult months and years were behind them. Much better to admit up front that this was a crisis election where a choice needed to be made - the tone Arthur had taken from his first speech - and then argue in every subsequent debate that he had received a mandate from the electors for his entire agenda. Those that truly supported him would back this message, and those that merely supported the victor of Badonicus would go along with it. And hopefully that would cobble together a majority most of the time.

Finally election day came.

Arthur was returned as senior consul - no surprise. But, to his dismay but also no real surprise, Titus Fulvius was appointed as his colleague. A brake and an obstacle on any radical plans he might try and force through the senate. On the upside, the senior praetor - the one, who, officially, should be the commander-in-chief of the various armed forces - was his preferred co-consul, Dyfnwal.

For the past twenty years of course, Arthur had been unconstitutionally filling this role; and he had taken over from Ambrosius who had merely filled it *de facto* by dint of getting on and doing it without any legal appointment whatsoever. And before that, there had been the ten-year hiatus of government ... but in theory, this was an appointment that was made on an annual basis.

Arthur's main campaign theme had been a return to "normality" and "constitutional government", so one of his first measures was to announce that Dyfnwal would, in fact, fulfill this role and would be responsible for trying to reign in and harmonize the action of the different armed forces around the country.

Over the past thirty years - in reality, ever since the government in Rome officially abandoned them in AD410 - Britain had been in "survival" mode, doing whatever it took to keep the Saxons (and others) at bay regardless of the long-term consequences. It was these that Arthur now sought to rein in.

The problem in Britain remained intractable: in order to have peace and stability, there needed to be a strong central government that was able to pass - and enforce - laws on all the citizens of the republic. But in a fragmented republic where there were small, independent, bands of horse soldiers ready to go to war at any time and who were - following the example of Ambrosius and Arthur - entrenched in easily-defensible hillforts, enforcing the law became a battle of wills - or worse.

What differentiated Arthur from most of the warlords was his genuine desire for a return to constitutional government, rather than attempting to use his position for personal gain.

Of course, there were those that would argue having been Dux Bellorum for all those years and now, having leapt from that unconstitutional role into the highest constitutional one, it was easy for him to lecture others on the virtue of being "under the law".

Arthur took all those attacks in his stride, and tried to work as openly as possible, consulting with others and working hard to make sure that all his actions were constitutional, fair and open. But at every turn, he faced obstructionism. The vested interests in Britain were just too strong for the interests *of* Britain to overcome them.

On the Ides of January, Arthur called the Senate into session for the third time since becoming consul to promulgate a series of measures that he hoped would crystallize his approach to unifying the country once again. His agenda for one year as consul, but a blueprint he hoped would be followed for the next generation; one that offered a slim hope of peace, law and security on this island.

Once the meeting was called to order, Arthur arose from the consul's chair and addressed the gathered senators.

"It is pleasant indeed to address you in a time of peace as a man of peace," he opened. "I hope that this is something that my children may have the opportunity to do, and their children.

"And it for their sakes - my children, your children, their grandchildren - that I have called you here today. I have said it ever since we returned victorious from the battle of Mons Badonicus: we stand at a crossroads.

"To the one hand, lies utter destruction. We can relax our vigilance and allow our enemies - traditional, recent or as yet unknown - destroy us by allowing our defences to slip and taking this current peace for granted.

"On the other hand lies fragmentation and decay. We can choose as our defenders wolves; we can feed them and encourage them; and then one day, as did the Saxons, they will reveal their true colours and devour us. We have already done this once by appointing Saxons as our guardians; we must not make that mistake again.

"But in between these paths lies the one straight way. It is, in the words of the Hebrew Jesus, as quoted in the Christian texts, a narrow way, which avoids the destruction to every hand.

"I can point this way. Indeed, today, I *will* point this way and I will point it clearly and forcefully. And over the course of this year, I will try and place your feet upon that way. But then at the end of this year I will move from this chair to one amongst the consulars - constitutionally, for a change. And then it will be up to whomever you choose to elect as the magistrates for next year - and the year after - and the year after that - whether we stay on that straight and narrow way, or if we fall off that path to the one hand or the other into the jaws of one or another dragon.

"Because listen, and listen well. With the vast range of threats that surround us, there can be *no* question that success is a very narrow window. It will take the same level of effort - although of a different nature - as we expended last year to defeat the Saxons. And it will take it year after year.

"I know that this is not what you want to hear. You want to hear that everything has been resolved and that I have guaranteed us peace and we can all rest on our laurels and enjoy the fruits of our labours.

"But that is not the case."

Arthur paused and watched for their reaction. Nobody likes to be told that their dreams of peace and security are just that: dreams. And much as all these men loved their children - and in some cases grandchildren - it was hard to understand that *sacrifice now* was the only way to guarantee their continued existence, let alone a fair and just world for them to live in.

"So let me start by outlining the threats as I see them. There are four.

"Firstly, there are the foreigners. The original threat is still there, if different. The Picts, like the Saxons, have been defeated for this generation but are threatening to rise again. With swift action, we can capitalize on that victory to establish a new order in which we can defuse that threat for all time. I will return to this later in my programme of action.

"The Irish have been defanged by the work of Vortigern, Germanus and the monk Patricius. They are now - nominally at least - part of the family of Christian countries in Europe and slowly becoming civilized. If we treat fairly with them, they will be our allies for centuries to come.

"However, to our west, across the Sefern river, many of the old Irish have colonized parts of our lands. We must evict them by one means or another. Sadly, I think the only means that will work - since they would no longer be welcome back in their former lands in Ireland - is to evict them or destroy them by force.

"Across the sea to Europe are nothing but barbarians. Against them we must continue to defend our eastern coastline. At the moment, we either need to depend on the Saxons to do that work for us, or we must admit that we cannot do it, because we have no navy and no ports - and we hold none of the eastern coastline.

"Across the sea to the south are the lands of Armorica - or Britannilla - where many of our former people live, holding the Frankish barbarians at bay. They are our natural allies, and we should try and work together to hold the barbarians back. This may or may not be possible. Here in Britain we have the advantage of the sea to hold the barbarians at bay - they must be able to land and stage in large numbers in order to threaten us; whereas in Armorica they can stage all along a border many miles long.

"Secondly, there are the Saxons. Like the Picts and Irish, they present no current and immediate threat due to the victory at Badonicus. But long-term they present much more of a threat than all the foreigners put together. Why? Because they are here, in our land, have a long border with us, are very warlike and are a major force in this island. Without immediate and positive action, they *will* eventually overrun us. Be in no doubt about this: they are not going anywhere, and if we do not civilize them, they *will* overrun us.

"Much of my programme will deal with this truly existential threat; I hope that I will convince you that this programme *must* be fully funded and carried through with application and dedication.

"Thirdly, and more insidiously, there are our own rogue governors. Like the Saxons, they pose a long-term existential threat, in that they are here among us, have borders with us, cannot be easily controlled because they *are* a force in the land.

"These men see themselves as above the law. And I say that *no man in Britain is above the law*! The law must apply to all men. Above all else, we must ensure that, in future, the government of this island is a government for all men, according to their station, which is honest, equal, blind and enforced.

"I have plans to deal with them. Of all the parts of my programme, this is the area where I am least happy and would most welcome better solutions, but I - and others - have looked hard at this problem and can see no better way of proceeding.

"Finally, I come to the most insidious threat of all. The threat inside of us: all of us. The external threats can be met and mastered; or countered and neutralized. But the threats inside of us can only be dealt with by a change of heart and a change of spirit.

"For change is needed, my fellow senators! A change as radical as the difference between barbarism and civilization itself. For many years, we have faced threat after threat to our continued existence - and done nothing.

"Oh, we have fought. I, specifically, have fought. I look around this chamber and I see others who have fought. But for what, I ask you, have we fought?"

The question was asked rhetorically; Arthur did not expect or want any answers to be called out. But he did want each and every man there to take the time to think about the answer he would give if questioned. To think about whether he had fought, whether he had sacrificed, whether he cared about his country most - or his personal wealth and standing.

"I say that we have fought to preserve what is ours! Not to preserve the Roman civilization in the West! Not to preserve a way of life that has lasted over a thousand years! Not to preserve the great works of learning and scholarship that have been written and curated. Not even for the lives of other men, less fortunate than ourselves.

"No, we have fought by and large in order to preserve our wealth and our position and our right to rule. Look at when we have fought and when we have not fought. We have fought when our wealth is threatened. We have abstained from fighting when our wealth is secure. But our values? They have been under constant threat for over a century. And in that time we have actively undermined them whenever it was more profitable to go the other way.

"And I say the time to stop that is now. Today is the day we start to put values ahead of profit."

Arthur paused again. He looked around and saw some resistance, some intolerance, but mainly he saw faces that were looking back at him with expectation: they saw him as a man who had been through so much, survived it and now had lessons to teach rather than learn.

Now he had to launch into his agenda. If it were just a programme of legislation, or if he reasonably thought he could carry it through in "his year", he would have been filled with confidence about getting it done.

But this was a multi-year project. He wasn't even sure that it would have fully taken root inside the next generation: and that was the timescale he knew, knew deep in his bones, was the one he was working towards.

"So today, my fellow Senators, I have a programme to propose. It is a long-term programme that may or may not be complete in my lifetime or the lifetime of many of those present today. But it is, at heart, a simple programme which addresses all of these concerns in one simple trick.

"The trick is this: we establish our principles - the principles of good Roman governance - and we gather together all those who support and will fight for those principles. Regardless of who they are - or from whatsoever nation they hail - if they swear to uphold the constitution of the Republic, we will call them 'Romans' and 'Britons' and consider them brothers.

"All others we call enemy. Again, regardless of birth or nation."

He paused once more. He had promised a programme and in large part this didn't sound like one. Indeed, he had not propounded the details. But all the details were implied for those who cared to pay attention. But as he looked around he saw the penny had not yet dropped for most of those present.

"So, to get to specifics. Against my better instincts, I first propose we offer a complete amnesty to all those governors holding troops, camps, hills or land 'in their own right' who will surrender those places and those forces to the proper government of the republic - to wit, this body. I will be clear with you all: without the vast majority of these men coming over to our side, and straight away - within weeks - there is no prospect of any of this agenda working and there is no prospect of our long-term survival. They can and will eat us alive before we even have to face the existential threats.

"I would dearly like to see them punished for their crimes, and for any that will not give themselves up, I wish this body today to pass the sentence of crucifixion on them and all their retainers *for the crime of resisting*. I want to be clear about this, my friends: there is a huge carrot and a huge stick here. To those who will resign their strength, accede to our authority and agree to follow the law *in the future*, we will frankly forgive them all their crimes - which are many.

"To those who are foolish enough to refuse, I will take all the might of my army and utterly, utterly destroy them. Just for refusing. There will be no subsequent trial and conviction. A special treason court, constituted here, will pass the sentence, it will be taken to the location where they are resisting and carried out forthwith; with the one exception of any individuals inside that camp which aid the forces of the republic in getting inside will be spared.

"This is my first proposal, and word of this should be carried to all those 'petty generals' by the end of this week. They then have one month - until the Ides of February - to obey this body. The treason court, if needed, will be invested the following day and will pass sentences that day."

He looked around. The majority of faces were reflecting the awe of the impressive sweep and thought that had gone into this proposal: it was a brilliant divide-and-conquer strategem on two separate levels. First, he planned to use the generals who *did* give in against the ones who didn't; and second, by threatening crucifixion for *every man, woman and child* who could be considered a collaborator with those resisting, he created a positive army of potential traitors in any camps that *did* decide to hold out.

But here and there among the senators was a tinge of one fear or another: some had relatives that were the 'petty generals' being targeted; some could think through the consequences of this kind of legislation and see how it could be turned to a more ruthless usage by a suitably unscrupulous individual.

Arthur cleared his throat; moved slightly. Time for a change of tone.

"Then we will have unity among the armed Britons in this island. For too long our forces have had their strength dissipated by fighting each other, or their force has been wasted oppressing the common people of this island. By bringing these men down from their hills and into the main body of the army, we will gain strength *and* gain wealth.

"But we will still have to pay these men. I know that this will not be popular, but we need to levy the appropriate taxes to pay for this army. On the upside, my friends, we do not need to conscript an army - they will all be volunteers! But we *must* pay for this army, and we must pay on time and in full.

"Why? Because it is the right thing to do. Oh, and many in this army have a tradition of taking what they want from the nearest peasants who can't resist them. Speaking for myself, I simply don't want to encourage that, but as I look around, I see men who, if the army were to be located near their estates would be highly distressed to find it just 'taking' what it needs.

"And I plan to move this army around. This is not the old army of the North, stuck out of the way; or the Saxon army of the East, only affecting people 'over that way'. This army is going to be running backwards and forwards between Dumnonia, Demetia and up north to fight the Picts.

"In short, my friends, this is an army that is going to go past your estates, your villas, your friends at least once every year. And if you vote to not pay for it, I'm sure that somebody here will let them know why they aren't being paid. If you take my meaning."

Most of them did; the nasty smile that Arthur left on his face as he finished talking didn't leave much room for doubt. He had read that Sulla had been a master of the forceful facial expression, and that many senators in the late Republic had been left quaking in their boots by nothing more than a look and a reprimand from the original Caesar.

"So what is this army going to do apart from run around the country intimidating honest taxpayers? Well, reducing our enemies of course.

"The details are boring and otiose to relate in detail. But by the time this decade ends, all of the Western highlands will be ours, and all of the North up to the Antonine wall will be a secure dwelling place. All these lands will report to this Senate and accept its authority. If you want the details, come to the military planning meetings that will be taking place over the next month.

"Finally, I turn east, and consider the Saxons.

"This is more tricky. We have beaten them in battle, but cannot evict them. So we must integrate them and civilize them. Within twenty years, they *must* be Roman. Otherwise they will continue to present the biggest threat we face.

"I have a simple solution, but it will not be easy or cheap. It consists of three parts.

"Firstly, we must show them that we are not afraid of them. I propose that from next year, we move the government back to London, where it rightly belongs. This location is more convenient for many of us, it is true, but the real reason we are here is for fear of the Saxons. By returning to London, we may inconvenience ourselves, but we demonstrate that we are the government of the whole island.

"Secondly, we must take civilization to them. Camulodunum was destroyed in the rebellion and has never been rebuilt. Canterbury has become their *de facto* capital, but it is a barbaric place. We must show them how Romans function: law courts, businesses, forums. We must show them how we live: baths, theatres, sports.

"And finally, we must educate their children. It will be the children who hate us, for killing their fathers. It will be the children who destroy us - because they will grow up hating us.

"We must stop them hating us. And the only way to do that is to show them - every single day - that we destroyed their fathers for a reason. And that reason is civilization."

He sat down and waited for the reaction. Merula applauded, then others. As the grandeur of the vision dawned on them, all of them joined in and cheered him to the rooftops.

13. Camolodunum

AD497

Looking back, it was his high point as Consul, just fifteen days in.

The Senate opposed just about everything he tried to do; for the very simple reason that just about everything he wanted to do had short-term costs and benefits only in the long - or very long - term. All of his plans were going to cost a great deal of money, and in the short term at least, there was basically none to be had.

The economy was collapsing. Although none of them really understood what was happening, they were aware of the consequences. From the time of the massacre, the great rebellion and the great flight of citizens and lords to Armorica, the sophisticated infrastructure of British and European life had collapsed. For the previous centuries, life in Britain had been ordered and organized, with a division of labour that would not be seen again until the industrial revolution once again ushered in an organized society. Many men had worked in the fields, it was true. This was a basic staple of life throughout the millenia. But these men had worked for pay, and had produced goods from the land that were sold and distributed across the island and often sent to Europe in exchange for other goods.

Each man worked within the fabric of a society in which other men bought and sold their goods and services. And the scale of Roman society - and even British society if the whole island hung together - was enough to allow specialists to grow up in towns such as Gloucester, Wroxeter and London. Specialists in metalworking, publishing, arms manufacture - or even such simple necessities as making ploughs and harnesses.

For the past fifty years of the troubles, that had broken down. Now, most men simply farmed whatever land was sufficient to feed their families and maybe their neighbours. Some trades and professions had dwindled or even died out due to lack of demand. Across the south coast, the oyster beds that had been farmed for export to Rome - and other rich patrons across the western empire - had been abandoned in favour of the more immediately marketable, and edible, craft of near-shore fishing. Deep-sea fishing - like ocean trade - had almost vanished because it was just too dangerous in waters infested with pirates, raiders and generic "enemies".

Arthur sought to turn back the clock on all of these trends, but he was continually swimming upstream. In order to achieve any of his goals, he needed to achieve one of the others first. This vicious circle - again unseen by his contemporaries - just generated resistance from some quarter to whatever he tried to do on any given day.

In order to boost the economy, Arthur had to try and re-integrate society. In order to do that, he needed to offer people security and enforce a structure on society that had been absent for fifty years - beyond the memory of most of those alive today, who resented his interference in the only life they had ever known.

In order to offer security or enforce the laws, he needed the force to oppose generals and others who set themselves up as "kings" or local, independent governors. That meant he needed to muster, arm, equip and provide for a force big and powerful enough to overawe any of the lesser generals in the land.

In order to overawe other generals - not go to war with each one individually - he needed an army so large as to intimidate them into not even fighting him. One that was loyal to the state, not to the individual generals, since that would lead back to the same problem he was trying to avoid. And the only way to make sure that the army was truly loyal to the state was to make sure the state paid it - and that they would stop paying it the moment it did the wrong thing.

In order to pay this army, he needed funds of some description. Money had largely broken down as a form of exchange in the past few years - the trust in it had gone along with the markets where it could be freely spent, and you can't eat precious metals - but funds in the form of food and equipment would have been sufficient if he could manage to create a surplus and use that to feed and equip his (necessarily large) army.

In order to obtain those goods, he needed two separate and contrary things: he first needed an efficient method of controlling that - involving yet more useless, non-food-producing mouths to organize, collate and control a commissary and taxation system; and he needed to boost the economy to greater production. If money were still effective, it would be possible to "prime the pump" by borrowing money, offering it in the markets for whatever goods were available, and then hope that production would gradually increase as more and more lords and men realized the profits that could be made by growing crops to sell to the state.

In order to make a real success of it, Arthur really needed a century or more of peace and stability in which to make his investments and see the results grow. But obviously he was never going to have anything like that, and he just needed to act quickly and hope for the best. He knew everything that needed to be done; it was just a question of taking a stab at whatever parts of it he could find to do.

While he left Dyfnwal and Quintus in charge of trying to round up, subdue and organize all the rebel British military forces into a single army, he took a party of senators together with a century of administrators and rode east. He had arranged to meet with the Saxon leaders at the beginning of February at Camoludunum, and while he was not wildly optimistic about the short-term benefits he could achieve, settling peace terms with the Saxons was at least a policy agenda item that didn't involve any fighting in the short term.

Much of Camolodunum was still standing; it had been sacked by the Saxons at the time of the Great Rebellion, and parts of it - including the walls - had been burnt. For Arthur's present purposes, the wall was not important, since the only people he felt the need to defend against were the very people he was inviting inside. As with many towns and cities of the later Roman Empire, defence was not the issue - commerce and law were.

The two parties met in the central forum. Here the Stoa of Claudius still stood, somewhat damaged and, in the odd way that often seemed to affect buildings, with much of its roof missing. Fortunately, the day was clear and bright; a blessing in early February. The Saxon party consisted of twenty leaders, all from the area they now called *Anglia*.

One of the problems that Arthur felt urgently needed addressing faced him immediately: the Britons spoke and wrote Latin; they also spoke the traditional Celtic language of the islands. The foreigners spoke their dialects of German and almost wrote not at all. Since his youth, Arthur himself had learnt to speak the Saxon dialect, and planned to converse directly with the Saxons in that language, his interpreter translating for his own side, most of whom had not the opportunity - or taken the time - to learn the barbarian tongue. But in the long run, peace and stability would only be possible with a common language supporting a common culture - Latin being the basis of a Roman system of laws.

"I greet you in the name of the Roman Republic of Britain, for while I am Artorius, and you know me as a warlord, since in our lands we do not have warlords, I am not, in fact, such.

"I am merely one servant of many in service of that which we know as Rome. Sadly, Rome is no more and has been sacked and destroyed by those of your brethren who chose a path of destruction. It is clear, however, that even if Rome is not always stronger than barbarism, it is better.

"You are here because you are strong. In the innocence of youth and unfettered by civilization, your ancestors were the perfect tool to fight our enemies and protect our culture and civilization. But two mistakes were made; mistakes that, even now, sixty or more years after the event, I would put right and try to salvage what I can of our common bond of living in these islands.

"The first mistake - and most obvious - was to take your service for granted and treat you as interlopers rather than allies. To accept your protection, but not to be prepared to meet the cost. Today, I promise that this will not happen again. I say that we are stronger together than we are apart, and that divisions between us serve neither of our parties.

"Just a few months ago, I was in western Britain - maybe some of you were too. Thousands of men died; some British, many more Saxon, or Angle, or Jute. We could continue this vicious cycle of killing, of destruction and violence, or we could try living alongside each other.

"The second mistake - and in my opinion, more serious - was to invite you here, and to accept you alongside us, but to keep you at arm's length. To tell you that you were welcome to settle here, but not to incorporate you into our society, with all the rights and privileges that come from being *Roman*.

"There were many - indeed, there still are some - who refuse to accept that *mere Saxons* could be worthy of admission to the councils of the *good* and the *great*. They look to their own privileges and perquisites and care nothing about others. These men I represent in name - since they are Romans - but not in spirit, for theirs is a mean spirit and I have a great heart.

"I have fought you almost my entire life. For many years, I hated you. After all, through what my people view as treachery, you killed my parents. But as I grew older, I saw that what I did myself caused pain: to Britons, to Saxons, to Angles. And I saw that you responded in kind, causing yet more pain and suffering to those I was sworn to protect.

"In other words, eventually, I realized that my hate was killing my own people."

Arthur paused and reflected, then continued.

"I come here today not as the victorious conqueror of Badonicus - although that I am - but as a friend and a representative of the legal government of all of Britain, to invite you to participate in that government.

"Ours is a government of laws, and a government of representatives. We do not respect force, or arms, or violence, even though those may sometimes be necessary, but we believe in important men, men of standing, with property, meeting and discussing the common weal of the republic and acting in accordance with its prosperity.

"This is what I propose. We are here met in the traditional seat of government here north of London. I propose to reinstate this as the government of this area, and to have you appoint a committee of one hundred leading local men to meet here and decide what happens in all of this area. If you accept, we can decide the exact territory and that territory will be Saxon. But not Saxon in a barbaric sense; Saxon under Roman law, and Roman discipline.

"This council will choose ten men - the ten men it finds to be most outstanding, and preferably all able to speak Latin or British - and I will invest them as Senators. As you may have heard, our Senate will be returning to meet in London, and I welcome them to join us there.

"We will provide all the assistance you need - lawyers, men versed with procedure, administrators, census-takers and the rest. Over time, you will train and appoint other men. More of your men will learn Latin, and you will become Romans, as we British are Romans: obeying the laws of Rome and living in the Roman way."

Arthur paused again to gauge their reaction and saw what he had expected, rather than what he had hoped for. These men knew that after their defeat the previous year they could not realistically expect to resist him, or anything he asked them to do. They would do what he asked but, initially at least, it would be due to the lack of ability to resist; not from any true enthusiasm.

"As long as we live like this, discussing our differences and resolving our disputes in the proper fashion, I undertake neither to do battle with you nor to cease from paying you. We will ensure that a certain portion of all the goods of the country come to you and that your forces are equipped to defend your coastline against any enemies - from the east or from the north.

"There are those who see what I am doing as 'arming the enemy'. If we all act in good faith, that need not be the case. We have no need to be at odds. Your gain is our gain - we all wish to live together, in one accord, in one island. I give you my word that I will work for this."

The Saxon leaders conferred, discussed and let out a great shout. Then the leader of their delegation came to Arthur, grabbed him by the arm and them in a giant bear hug.

"You are indeed a man among men, Arthur. I have fought you many a time, and been beaten by you many a time. If we fight again, I mean to beat you, but I would rather fight as your friend and drink beer in your tents.

"As long as you live, and as long as you deal honestly with us, we will deal honestly with you."

14. Pictland

AD498

Arthur now had his "invincible" army.

Nobody, of course, was ever invincible, but he had patched together all the cavalry resistance units, a number of Saxon units from the various Saxon lands that he was trying to integrate into proper Roman formations, a number of men from the conscription of two years' before who preferred life under arms to returning to the subsistence existence of peasants and a handful of garrison troops who were, for the time being at least, surplus to the requirements of the more peaceful times.

He had also incorporated the remnants of the "Great Army of the North" under its Dux in York. What had amounted to four front-line regions a little over a century ago was now more accurately described as ten under-strength cohorts. Still, it was as big as the rest of his forces put together. For many years, they had remained static on the northern frontier; unable to evict the Saxons but - with the single exception of the Pict invasion of AD478 - easily able to defend their territory north of the Humber from Saxon and Pict alike.

Arthur had appointed Dyfnwal commander of this motley army and sent him - together with his mobile forces - north to drill with the experienced and largely hereditary centurions of the Dux's forces. By the end of his year as consul, this had become a single fighting force and the strongest - although not the largest - army to be seen in Britain since Maximillian had led three of the legions astray in his march to become emperor of Rome.

What this army had that all the others had not was an integration of forces and a true, disciplined, professional nature. Every man is this army wanted to be there, wanted to fight, and was ready to be disciplined and *train*. The army had experienced legionaries from York, mobile cavalry forces from the south, and shock troops and a navy provided by the Saxons.

And it had a leader - Dyfnwal.

Dyfnwal had served many years with Arthur and had come to understand his multifaceted tactical approach. While he would be the first to admit that he did not have the tactical genius of the master, he had the same intellectual approach to understanding the fighting of wars. His first task was to secure his supplies and supply lines, and to ensure that his troops were able to eat and be ready for battle. His second was to make sure that every man was thoroughly drilled and disciplined, and knew his role. Only then did he start to think about the campaigns and the battles.

And for this campaign, he had Arthur to do all that for him.

"Right, men," said Arthur to the officers and centurions when they gathered in late March before the campaigning season. "I want there to be absolutely no doubt about this. Dyfnwal is in charge and will remain in charge - unless he's killed or incapacitated. My reputation proceeds me - especially since many of you have served alongside me in one capacity or another over the past twenty years. I may be the second coming of Julius Caesar - although I doubt it myself - but you take your orders for Dyfnwal and nobody else. On the other hand, since I'm here, it makes sense for me to offer my advice and perspective on the situation."

The officers laughed. In other words, constitutionally, Arthur would observe the forms; and in the field he would let Dyfnwal give the orders, but the campaign strategy was coming from just one man.

"You know the situation. Everything's a mess. We have peace in the south and east because both Britons and Saxons have decided to work together. Up here, we have issues with both the Picts and the governors that were appointed to deal with them. And all over the west we have old-fashioned Irish invaders. So.

"We need to move quickly and sweep them all away. My old comrade Fergus - yes, the Irish Fergus - has been having some issues with his neighbours over the sea, and I've promised him land between the walls of Hadrian and Antonine if he wants to - uh - come and claim it. He has agreed, and will be sailing up the Clyde. I have sent messengers to our friends there, and they will let him pass as long as we vouch for his good behaviour, which I've done.

"We meanwhile, are going to push up the east coast and take the old fort at Dunedin from the Votadini. We will bring them to pitched battle and crush them, and then we will displace them. Dyfnwal will remain there as the new governor and take responsibility for properly organizing the territory, carrying out a census and deciding on taxation, and I will be looking for about a thousand volunteers who want to stay with him and be the regular standing army and police force up there. Fergus will push up from the west and do the same thing on that side, displacing all the petty governors who think themselves above the law. Fergus will then be Dyfnwal's deputy, each given a ten-year pro-consular imperium.

"Any questions? Good."

And he walked out. The grand strategy was in place; Dyfnwal and his officers could work through the details. Arthur would have little to do until the time came to bring the Votadini to battle.

The Votadini had been sent to the border by Vortigern in an attempt to shore it up. Supplied from the south through the supply chains based at York, the arrangement had worked well until the Great Rebellion had caused the central government to collapse and the funnelling of supplies could no longer be arranged.

The Votadini had then followed the example of the Saxons and "gone native" - looking after themselves rather than after the common weal of Britain. Arthur had not fought them when he had previously come north, because at the time their interests were aligned - the Votadini had been roundly beaten by the Picts as they broke through their territory on their way south to ravage York.

Arthur had been tempted to try and do a deal with the Votadini as he had with the Saxons - to forgive and forget. But he felt he had already forgiven too many people too many times since becoming Consul and sooner or later he needed to make an example of someone. He had to fight them first; and make them concede. Then maybe it would be possible to do a deal with a weakened enemy.

But that deal did not include letting them keep their power here. Arthur knew who he wanted in charge of this critical area, and that was Dyfnwal and Fergus. When he left, they were the men he would leave behind.

The army rode north in true Roman style. They did not need to build marching camps south of Hadrian's wall, for everywhere they went had been Roman - nominally at least - for centuries and proper forts were available all along the Great North Road.

In these days, of course, the forts were not used to accomodating an army of this size. But that didn't mean they weren't still capable of it - and in general they found themselves in camps that were designed for even bigger armies. And, more often than not, they found themselves re-fortifying the camp before settling in for the night. But on the whole, it was easier than marching into the unknown.

Which they did after crossing Hadrian's wall.

The traditional frontier of Britain to the north, it had been originally envisaged by Hadrianus as a temporary frontier to hold back the Picts until they "realized" the benefits of civilization. A couple of times the British and Romans had pushed up passed this line - and Antoninus had even built a more advanced fortification, the Antonine wall - but each time they had been pushed back here. The distances to the north were simply too vast.

Vortigern - among others - had attempted to defuse the problem by introducing a buffer zone occupied by "friendly" barbarians, given the right of self-government and general independence north of the wall, in exchange for being in a state of constant war with the barbarians to the north.

The most recent of these were the Votadini, who had established themselves at a place colloquially known as "The Rock" - often written as Dunedin. A natural fortress, it was generally considered impossible to capture, but Arthur knew better.

It was a perfect defensive position against barbarians, and, with the appropriate care and attention it was possible to defend an area of many hundreds of square miles from the fortification. And the Votadini - with just the one exception - had managed to hold it for all that time.

Now Arthur purposed to take it from them and install Dyfnwal instead.

They dug in two miles to the south of the fort. They built a full size, properly Roman winter fort: not just a marching camp or a battle camp. To any who knew the signs, this meant they planned to stay as long as it took. Arthur hoped that someone on The Rock knew the signs.

"That's one big hill," remarked Dyfnwal as he, Arthur and the majority of the command staff rode out to look at it. "I wouldn't like to have to storm that."

"It must be over a hundred feet up to the top," agreed Arthur cheerfully. "Even our catapults are going to have a problem getting missiles up there with any force."

"So we're stuck with a siege, hence the big camp," said Dyfnwal.

"Well, I wouldn't like to rule it out," conceded Arthur. "But where there's a will, there's a way. And I have the will to take this place."

"Treachery?" asked Quintus.

"I certainly wouldn't turn anyone down who came to me with the right offer," agreed Arthur. "If you have any contacts inside the fort, let them know I would be prepared to consider a deal. But there are definitely limits: the Votadini are not going to be in charge here by this time next year; and that's not open to negotiation."

"Stealth?" suggested Dyfnwal. "It seems as if the hill slopes off more gently to the east and there are other lesser hills there we could use to stage a small party."

"It's possible," admitted Arthur warily. "But I assume that they have fortified that hill too, against that possibility. You'd probably just lose all the men you sent - and admit you didn't know how to take the place."

"So what is your plan?" asked Quintus, once again in his life irritated by Arthur's apparent nonchalance in the face of the seemingly impossible.

"My usual one," he replied with a smirk. "I intend to fight them down here in the plain on my own terms and defeat them."

"How?" the others asked, almost in unison.

"Make it seem like their best option."

The digging began in earnest the next day.

"It's only four miles," said Arthur. "And there's plenty of timber. A circumvallation like this would take a real army just four days. Caesar claims he managed to get this kind of job done overnight, but even though he had more men, I still don't see how he managed it.

"You understand the plan? The key is to allow the line to bulge here. This is the logical place for them to come down and attack us, and it needs to look good. But this bulge will drive them apart and give us the line to attack."

"But why will they come down?" asked Quintus.

"Fear," replied Arthur. "They have planned and prepared for an attack by barbarians and haven't laid in the kinds of resources that they need to deal with us. And we outnumber them. Meanwhile, we have declared that we are here to stay and they will see their only option to come down and fight their way out *before* we complete the circumvallation.

"Which is why this part - where we want them to attack - must still be incomplete when they come down."

At dawn, two days later, the Votadini struck.

In theory, they were a Roman-trained force. In practice, they were a violent rabble who understood the benefits of organization but not the benefits of daily, dull drill.

They came down the hill in good order. Arthur's bugler immediately sounded the call to drop tools and arm. Within minutes, Arthur's units had formed up in the two remaining gaps in the southern arm of the wall - gaps that were exactly the size of the hundred-man front Arthur wanted to deploy. In front of them, many of the trenches and hurdles had already been dug into no-man's land. Arthur's forces had not had time to "rehearse" this battle, as they so often had in the past, but they knew what they were doing and had practised the appropriate manoeuvres a thousand times over the past year.

Dyfnwal was commanding the forces to the left; Quintus to the right. Arthur held the cavalry and the reserves behind the main lines but in front of the fort in the centre of the field.

The Votadini worked their way around most of the obstacles and came on at a rush. Dyfnwal's men met the rush and their line wobbled but held. The Roman killing machine went to work: open-stab-close-shove, open-stab-close-shove.

On the right, Quintus' line gave way from the moment the contact was made. The first wobble became a wave and almost allowed some of the descending attackers to break through. But Quintus called for order and retreat and the line moved back a few paces. Then a few more.

Quintus called out the commands and tried to steady the line but nothing he tried worked. Slowly but surely, they were being pushed back down the hill and losing the battle.

Arthur saw what was happening but did not immediately react. The Votadini were still pushing through the gap in the defences and they were still covering their flanks. But he watched carefully for the right moment.

Dyfnwal's line was holding and there was noise and clamour all along the front. The Votadini shield wall was up against the Britons' and the two lines were shoving against each other and stabbing when they could. But battles between Roman-trained armies invariably came down to a wrestling match: the defence of the wall of shields was more than a match for the thrusting of swords or the occasional stabbing thrust of a spear coming down from above. From time to time a strike would go home and sometimes a man would be forced to retreat.

Quintus' line continued to retreat as Arthur watched. The attackers had pushed through the gap in the encircling wall now, and had continued in formation, leaving their flank unprotected. As they pushed on, a steady gap opened up behind them ... two paces, three, now four. Arthur watched carefully, then, deciding the moment had come, set his horse off on a trot and signalled his personal cavalry to follow him. The others should know what to do when the time came.

Arthur rode straight for the gap in the wall. That was the key to this whole battle. From there, he could encircle both groups of enemy soldiers and, once there, nothing they could do would dislodge him.

As they reached the distance of fifty paces from the flank of the ongoing battle, Arthur signalled the charge and spurred his horse into a gallop. The noise of the pounding hooves transmitted itself through the floor to the soldiers, but there was no time to react. The troops on the outer flanks turned, and tried to lock shields, but they were not Arthur's target: he rode around behind them and attacked the Votadini in the rear. Here too, the defenders tried to turn and lock shields, but they were too slow; the move too unexpected.

All Arthur's reinforcement companies came up as fast as they could. Within minutes, the battle on the right was over as the Votadini lines crumpled under attack from all sides. More, as reinforcements arrived, Arthur was able to lead his original storm company to attack the units pressuring Dyfnwal. While he was unable to repeat the element of surprise, the early offer of quarter - as opposed to the alternative, almost certain death - brought the battle to a quick close. Once more, Arthur was victor on the field. The rest of this campaign would be mopping up. Arthur was happy to delegate that to Dyfnwal and Fergus.

Cunedda came to the tribunal somewhat apprehensive.

He had been the leader of the forces facing Quintus, and had to face the double ignominy of having *nearly* beaten one of Arthur's generals, while at the same time recognizing that Arthur's plan had always been to allow him to advance precisely so that he could encircle him.

Arthur was seated there, in all the dignity of an emperor, although he had not claimed the formal title. He recognized that more than once, in the ancient Roman Republican tradition he had been hailed as "Imperator" - victor without peer - on the battlefield, but had never accepted the true validity of the role of Emperor, let alone "Emperor of Britain".

But as he stood before him at the tribunal, Cunedda felt the awe and the majesty that required words like "Emperor" and "King" to describe the people that radiated them in this way.

"Cunedda," began Arthur. "You fought valiantly yesterday, and could possibly have won had your troops been alert and disciplined. That they were not might be held at your account, or it might be held at that of your senior officer. Either way, I expect that you will learn from this salutary experience."

Arthur looked at him intently.

"By now, I'm sure that you have heard of my plans and dispositions for the north. Dyfnwal will be in overall control, and Fergus the Scot from Ireland has come to take the battle further north and make continual war against the Picts. I am sure that in due course the Scots will push the Picts out: they are just too vicious not to.

"You, I hear, are a good man, and many of your forces are good men, too. But they are no longer welcome in the north. But I ask whether you would accept the promotion to Dux and take on the task of defending the central western highlands?

"I would have you take with you such men as can be trusted and are still young and fit. Those that you do not trust - or are not suited to the discipline of military life can remain here and I will discharge them from the army and they can become civilians again under the rule of Dyfnwal.

"What do you say?"

Cunedda looked at him, new hope being born in his eyes. "I would like that very much. Will there be war?"

"I hope not," replied Arthur. "At least, not for you. I am hiring you as an administrator and a protector; not as a general. Where you are going there are no enemies at the moment, although some may come your way as we evict them from further south, in Demetia. I would have you always ready to defend your territory against any that would cause harm to the people there."

"I accept," said Cunedda, and became Dux on the field of battle outside Dunedin.

15. London

AD500

A lot of the work of the next decade was for administrators.

Arthur - well, Britain really, but Arthur was the guiding force in the Senate in those days - needed to get the economy back on its feet and get tax revenue flowing. It was all very well crushing rebellious forces in the south west, midlands and the north, but when it came down to it, what the country really needed was to get back to work.

After returning from the north, Arthur had convened the Senate and asked them to consider two interconnected motions. The first was to order a large-scale census of the island: who lived where, what equipment there was, and what land was lying fallow. The other was to authorize him to redistribute people and things around the country to maximize their utility and to begin a programme of improvements to the country's infrastructure. The roads and bridges had not been propertly maintained in almost a century, and the work that had been done from time to time had been done sloppily and in a hurry, generally by soldiers who wanted to *use* the road.

The Senate passed the motion for the census relatively easily. They recognized that without a fair and complete census, it was going to be impossible to figure out the correct taxes for the country and for as long as they could not tax effectively, the whole of the costs of government were going to be a burden on those rich enough to be known to be able to contribute - to wit, the members of the Senate. Of course, they didn't like the costs that Arthur's motion carried with it - the number of inspectors, the overlapping areas to ensure everything was covered and the men could not be bribed, the thoroughness of the investigations and the random inspections to make sure that none of the inspectors were enriching themselves. "Quis custodiet ipsos custodes?", as Arthur said, costs money.

Nothing and nobody could move the Senate to pass the second motion. Now that the Senate met in London, Merula - who didn't want to leave his estates near Glastonbury - no longer attended, and without his sage advice, Arthur felt frustrated and impotent.

He railed and raged, argued with individual senators and canvassed more generally for support. But the root of the problem was trust and personal interest. The powers Arthur was asking for - no matter how much he protested he would use them for the good of the people at large - were dictatorial in nature and could stand the current order on its head. Moreover, since he could arbitrarily move people or equipment from one place to another, he could easily impoverish his enemies to the benefit of his friends. By the end of the three weeks of debate, Arthur had to admit he felt sorely tempted. And felt he knew who his enemies were: basically the whole Senate.

Slowly the census moved ahead and the numbers came in. As Arthur had expected, Dyfnwal did a superlative job in the north - an area that hadn't been properly covered by a census *ever*, as far as Arthur could tell. The man was a born administrator and was well able to delegate the job of fighting to Fergus - a born warrior.

Again and again Arthur used the excellent job that Dyfnwal had done as a model for the rest of the country, and more than once sent to him to ask him to loan him some of the census-takers to distribute to other parts of the country. Cunedda did well in the central western highlands as well; another area where it was traditionally difficult to do a census. He made himself - and Arthur - more than a few enemies among those who wanted to conceal their wealth from the "thieves" in London, but his census was complete within the year.

Among land actually held by the British, the south-west gave the greatest difficulties. There, the vested interests opposed the actions of the census-takers over and over again, and more than once Arthur had to send detachments from his army to assist them in collecting the relevant information.

Surprisingly, the Saxons were very willing to collaborate on the census, and were curious about the whole process. They worked rapidly to obtain all the relevant information and assisted the inspectors in every way possible.

In the far west, where the Irish still held territory against the will of Arthur and the British Senate, there was no census. Soon, they would have to be dealt with, but first, Britain needed a breather from war to rebuild.

After two years, with all the information in, Arthur went back to the Senate to obtain approval for his long and complicated plan of "redistribution" that would get the economy back on its feet and make the most of their land, people and materials. If he had been authorized in the first place, this could have been happening as the census was ongoing and the benefits might be starting to be felt soon.

Arthur delegated to Agricola, one of the census chief inspectors - styled "Tribune".

"They are fed up with me," explained Arthur. "They assume that because I am victorious in battle, I must want to overpower them at policy and in wealth too. Nothing could be further from the truth. I would love for them to take the responsibility for making this country great again. But they just wish to carp, criticize and oppose what needs to be done. I hope that with you, they will listen and consider the merits of the facts that we have gathered; and, once they have listened, that they will then be prepared to act - or authorize you to act.

"I will be there, of course, but I intend to say nothing. I apologize if you end up feeling you have been fed to the sharks, but I truly believe this is the best way of making what we know to be necessary to happen."

Agricola smiled at him and simply replied, "All I ask is that when this is over you let me take out my rage and frustration on someone who deserves it."

"How about the Irish in Demetia? We still need to deal with them if we are to reunite this island under its proper government."

Agricola smiled. There was a campaign to sink your teeth into!

It did not go well.

"What do you mean you want to transplant my peasants and their ploughs to Saxon-held lands? That's madness. First you forgive the enemy, then you arm the enemy and now you want to reward the enemy."

"I would remind you," said <somebody>, acting Leader of the House in Merula's absence, "that while they *were* our enemy, before that, they were our allies, and now they are our fellow citizens. Some of their representatives are here in this hall."

"Just waiting for the opportunity to rise up and kill us all again, no doubt! Well, I refuse. My people are needed to grow my crops, and I will not part with them."

"That is not the case," countered Agricola, outwardly calm but inwardly seething. He understood know what Arthur was talking about but had no idea of how the old man had put up with it for so many years. He was a man of action, and to be stymied by idiots like these ... it was demeaning.

"The census clearly shows that much of the western lands are overpopulated; many fled there at various stages during the troubles and there is simply not the land there to support them being productive. So we have too many people working land at subsistence levels. Meanwhile, we have land in the east - some owned by lords of Saxon descent, it is true - which has remained fallow for many years due to the depravations of the wars. It makes sense to move the people to where the land is, for we surely cannot do the reverse."

In the end, Arthur managed to achieve about a tenth of the improvements he was hoping for. It would not be enough, he knew it.

16. Demetia

AD503

The army had settled into a tight unit.

It had drilled consistently for over five years now, and the officers had bedded in and weeded out the troublemakers.

At length, Arthur had persuaded the Senate to authorize this mission and given authority to Agricola to lead it as "General". Arthur, of course, was along as an advisor and general expert on everything war-related; the resident genius if you will.

The first battle had been fought at Carleon, where once the IX Legion had been based. It was an obvious base for the army to start from, but it had been held by the Irish for over fifty years.

When they had arrived, Arthur had had no bright suggestions for evicting the Irish through trickery or deceit.

"We have the men and the machines," he said and Agricola ordered a frontal assault.

It wasn't pretty, and it wasn't quick, but within six months the fort was theirs - just in time to winter in.

The rest of the winter was spent in re-fortifying the fort, repairing the damage they had done themselves in storming it, and in ensuring their supply lines all the way back to the territory they held solidly on the far side of the Severn.

"This was never going to be a quick campaign," Arthur said to Agricola as the rode out one day to observe the next fort up the valley. On top of a high hill, it looked almost impossible to reach it, let alone to march an army up there to take it.

"Which is to our advantage," countered Arthur when Agricola raised these objections. "How do they manage to supply it? There can only be two or three routes up there."

"Circumvallate? That hill? You'd have to go two hundred miles around," Agricola gasped in awe at the prospect of such a task.

"Not so," said Arthur. "As I said, there can only be a few routes up or down. Seal each of them off at the base with a fort and a wall. Connect any together where it makes sense and then just wait them out. We may starve them out or they may prefer to come down and do battle. We win either way."

"But it will take ages," complained Agricola.

"I never said it was going to be a quick campaign," repeated Arthur with a grin.

Two months later, when Arthur had gone back to London to continue his "duties" - mainly trying to bash heads together to pass his agenda and get the economy back on its feet - the Irish came down from their hill and attacked in the night.

Agricola's forces were taken by surprise, but nevertheless they managed to rally and fight a defensive action by torchlight. The Irish had chosen to attack under cover of darkness in the hope that in the confusion some of them at least might escape. Probably some did, but as the battle raged many were killed and many more finally surrended. In the morning, the sun rose on a field of dead and wounded.

Agricola marched up the hill, demolished the fort and moved on through Demetia.

Arthur rode over the hill with a Gaul in tow.

Agricola was notified by one of his staff and rode out to meet him. The two saluted and Agricola eyed up the Gaul.

"Are you going to introduce us?" asked Agricola.

"This is Theodoric, lately from Armorica. He has come across the sea due to the sad loss of his home port there has come north, along with all his vessels. He arrived down in Cornwall, and offered his services in exchange for being granted land and safe harbour. Since this is where the action is right now, I thought it might be good for him to come and help you - a fleet would probably come in handy along these coasts - and then the pair of you could probably make him Dux of Cornwall."

"By evicting the current rulers, you mean."

"That's exactly what I mean. You can be in charge on this side of the estuary, and he can rule the other side. Between you, I expect you to keep the estuary safe from any marauders - Saxon, Irish, Frank or any others brave enough to chart these waters.

"He brings ships, you know."

"Those could be useful. We haven't had to fight many naval engagements, but supplies along the coast can be hard here. Supply by ship might be the most practical choice."

Over the next three years, Agricola, Theoderic and Marcellus worked together to evict the Irish from all of Demetia and to build strong garrison forts and monasteries along the coast road. By 508, a network of forts, monasteries and roads had made the territory a secure part of the British Republic.

True to his word, Agricola took the majority of the army south and together Agricola and Theoderic established firm grip over the whole of Cornwall. In a series of lightning campaigns, they took the hill forts using siege techniques honed in Demetia. By 512, Agricola was back in Demetia with a small force based at Carleon; Theoderic operated a naval base at Falmouth - an ideal base for his naval forces to protect the British coastline; and Marcellus had taken charge of central Cornwall with another small part of the armed forces.

That left Arthur with the majority of the army to discharge.

Foolishly, he had assumed that discharging the army would be popular.

Technically, it wasn't particularly his responsibility; but because he had been largely responsible for keeping the army running - making sure it was supplied, recruiting new troops, discharging those who were too old - somehow the overall responsibility had devolved onto him.

And now there were six thousand or so men to discharge all at once, with little memory of anything than being under the colours.

"We cannot just send them to be subsistence peasants," exclaimed Arthur, aghast at the Senate's reaction. "These were men of property who have fought in our armies for years, if not decades. They have kept us safe from the Saxons when they were our enemies; they have reunited this island; they have fought up inhospitable mountains in the west. We owe them land and property."

"We simply cannot afford to keep giving away the republic," countered <some senator>. "Again and again you come here, demanding that we give away this or that part of the country to this or that group with special needs and impoverishing us over and over. You cannot continue to do this."

"And I will not continue to do this. This is the last thing. I have settled Britain now. It would be better if you were to do more to help make the farms productive and to create incentives for people to start new businesses and operations in the towns - the towns are dying! But there is no more that I will ask after this. After this, I will retire."

"But you ask so much ..."

"Is it really so much? That each of these men who has given so much should be given either enough land to farm to produce for himself, his family and to sell to others; or else to be given the capital to start a business in a town? These are things that *need doing*; these are people that *need something to do*. These are two problems that cancel each other out."

"But where does the land come from? Where does the money come from? How do you propose to pay for this?"

"There is still plenty of land lying fallow all around the country. We know where it is, because we have the census from a decade ago. You've done so little to bring that land back into cultivation that I don't imagine there is any shortage of it. If we went through the census today, I have no doubt that we could find three thousand suitable farms for the men who would choose this path."

"And for the men who choose to start businesses?"

"We would need to provide money from taxation."

"But we are already broke."

"We are broke because there is not enough activity in the economy. We are slowly starting to recover from a half century of fear, uncertainty and destruction. We need to act to solve that; the best way of doing that is to invest in activities that have been allowed to degrade over the past half century or more. Invest. Not throw away."

"But you would take our money and give it to others. We have no money to give."

"Of course you do; you have been paying for the army for all these years, and now that expense will be going away. In five years, all the money that I'm asking for now will have been recouped in lower taxes because the army has been discharged."

"Until there's another war!"

"But where? We have settled all the borders. We are at peace with the Saxons to the one hand and the Irish to the other. Anyone else would have to come over the sea, and the Saxons defend our eastern and southern shores, while Theoderic does the same to the south and west. In the north, the Picts may be fighting with the Scots, but it is very unlikely that either of them will trouble Dyfnwal, let alone come through to the midlands. As long as you are sensible and govern well, there need be no more wars in this island."

Yet they remained unconvinced. For day after day, and week after week, the Senate met and argued about what could and could not be afforded. Ultimately, they made it the responsibility of the individual section commanders to find somewhere for their troops to go; something for them to do.

A worse solution Arthur could not think of. They would go nowhere in particular and they would prey on their fellow citizens. At times, he couldn't help feeling that they were just determined to undo all of his hard work.

17. Camolodunum

AD516

Medrault was a fool.

Arthur cursed his name over and over as he rode at the head of his force of cavalry enforcers up the Icknield Way as fast as he could.

Arthur, of course, had opposed the appointment of Medrault as Governor of Camolodunum from the start, but once again had been voted down. The only difference was that this time it could be serious.

Camolodunum was in "Saxon" territory, and while over the past twenty years, that had come to mean less than it had before, the Saxons still viewed their heritage with pride and did not want to be talked down to by a stuffy Roman.

But the Senate had wanted a very Roman Roman in charge; one who would look down on his inferiors - and hold them in their place. Fools, the lot of them, cursed Arthur again. And now, once again, I have to clean up their messes.

Because of course, the inevitable had happened. The Saxons had taken umbrage at their treatment by Medrault, and he had been forced to flee the capital at Camolodunum and retreat to London. Arthur had been called out of his genial retirement and was now coming from the west, where he had been wintering with Merula on his estates near Glastonbury. Hopefully Medrault would be waiting for him at Verulanium and then they would proceed - with a suitable armed force which Arthur hoped and prayed would *not* be needed - to a meeting with the Saxon leaders. Hopefully, everything could be sorted out.

"What were you thinking?" Arthur demanded.

"They were insisting on having their disgusting Modraniht festival in the civic hall. Well, I just couldn't allow that. We are a Christian Republic."

"They have a different religion to us, Medrault. Don't you know that? Romans were pagans once; not even so very long ago. What harm would come from them celebrating their rites?"

"You have been very clear that they need to integrate. There are perfectly acceptable Christian celebrations at that time of year: the birth of Christ, and the feast of St. Stephen."

"And over time, I'm sure our very eminent bishops will make the point to them that their Mothers' Night celebration is really just another way of looking at the stoning and martyrdom of St. Stephen. But until they do manage that miracle, it seems that allowing the Saxons to celebrate in their traditional way would be the most likely way to bring peace and harmony; don't you agree?"

It was clear that Medrault did not agree. Even though his chosen approach - to refuse to let the Saxon leaders into the civic hall, and finally barring all the entrances until they broke them down and stormed the hall, chasing Medrault and his followers out into blind retreat - had clearly *not* led to peace or harmony.

"So what do we do now?" Medrault asked pathetically; almost whining, thought Arthur.

"What choices do we have?" retorted Arthur. "We have to ride back to Camolodunum and see what we can salvage from the situation. Hopefully, they held their festival, feel that they got the better of you and I can just send you to the Senate for trial and execution and the whole thing will just blow over."

"Hopefully? Execution?" squealed Medrault.

Arthur looked at him in blank confusion. And then it dawned on him that Medrault *still* did not realize that *he* was in the wrong. That obviously he had broken the law and would need to be tried, and, when the situation was so sensitive, justice would not only need to be done, but would need to be *seen* to be done.

In that context, executing the ringleader was the very least that could be expected to happen. Arthur's fear - that the whole of the east coast might erupt and Camolodunum might have been burnt down by the time he arrived - seemed a lot worse. The execution of a petty, self-absorbed bigot like Medrault seemed a small price to pay for peace in this island.

Camolodunum was still standing when they arrived.

While this fact in itself was pleasing to Arthur, the fact that the road to it was blockaded by a Saxon force, well dug-in in almost Roman style, sent the clear message that they expected trouble. Arthur considered the various options at his disposal and sent his troops away. He would have risked fighting marauding Saxons; he would have ridden up with his small force as an insurance policy if everything had *seemed* calm; but in this context, he wanted to lower tensions and take the heat out of the situation.

He sent Medrault away with the troops; seeing him might be the trigger that set the Saxons off. And rode on alone.

He was greeted by <somebody else we should have met before> and they exchanged greetings. Arthur dismounted and <the saxon> walked out from behind his defensive wall. Arthur hobbled his horse to a nearby fencepost and walked up to <saxon>.

As always, Arthur spoke in the Saxon language.

"Well met, my friend. How can I apologize for the boorishness of Medrault?"

"You could hand him over to me and let my men pull him limb from limb," replied <saxon>.

"Yes, I suppose that would be a possibility. But that's not really how we do things here, as we've discussed."

"It is when you want it to be and it isn't when you don't want it to be," countered <saxon>. "You let this creep barricade the hall against me."

"And he was wrong to do so. I have told him so. I am going to send him to London and the full Senate will try him for treason. He will then be executed - *legally*."

"So you say. But I know your Senate. They are his friends and they still think of us as enemies. If you want us to be your enemies, so be it. We will fight you again, and who do you think will win this time?"

"If we fight, none of us will win, my friend. You know that. Chaos and darkness will descend as they did before we agreed the truce after Badonicus."

"Ah yes, your great victory, O Arthur. The one for which you will always be remembered. The one you can never cease to rub into the wounds of us Saxons. But I say to you, Arthur, that we have grown strong and you have grown weak. You have looked away from us and fought the others: the Picts, the Irish, your rebels. And you have done so at great cost to yourselves and then you broke up your army, leaving parts of it in the hands of fools like Medrault. I say that we are stronger than you."

"And I say that we are stronger together, <saxon>. Consider this: we are together on this island, free of all others. United as one people, we can live in peace, without war, and with all our children growing up together. I want that for my children. Don't you want that for yours?"

"Can we live in peace, Arthur? Can we live in peace with cretins like Medrault allowed to be governors? Why is an Angle not good enough to be appointed governor of Camolodunum? Or a Saxon? Why must it be a toffee-nosed Roman? Because we are not good enough.

"We may not be *good* enough for you, Arthur. But we are *strong* enough. Don't pretend you didn't come with an army today just because you sent them away when you came to parley. We saw it. Your men and your horses. But we are ready for you today, Arthur. We have learnt from our previous mistakes and we know what it takes to beat your horses.

"Enough of this talk. Let us decide on the battlefield who will be Governor of Camolodunum."

"No, my friend. Friends do not fight. Allies do not fight. Fighting is for enemies and I am not - and do not want to be - your enemy."

"But Medrault is my enemy and him I will fight. Are you a coward? Will you not fight me?"

"I will fight you if you give me no other choice. But I would rather be friends."

"Then I give you no choice, Arthur." And, so saying, he lifted his ram's horn to his lips and blew a mighty, ringing tone that sounded around the valley, echoing back from the far hills.

But, as Arthur listened, he realized it was not an echo but the sound of other horns answering. He - separated from his little force - was surrounded by Saxons.

As <saxon> laughed, Arthur ran to his horse, jumped on it and rode back to his small cavalry unit. By the time he arrived, they were already engaged fighting a force of three thousand Saxons, surrounding the two hundred light cavalry troopers. They had the advantage of mobility, but the Saxons had the advantage of the prepared terrain, the numbers, and the organization.

Arthur had ridden into a trap.

It was the only battle he lost. After Medrault died, and Arthur was pulled from his horse and killed, the rest of the men surrendered. But no mercy was shown them.

The Saxons were barbarians on the rampage once again.

Epilogue

Arthur was dead.

And so, the world Arthur had created, and in large part held together through the force of his own personal will, started to fall apart.

The immediate causes picked up directly from the death of Arthur: the Saxons no longer trusted the Romans to be honest partners, but saw them as desirous of being their overlords once again. They might still be barbarians, but they had their pride, and that was more important to them than the common good of the "people of Britain".

The Romano-British might have been able to resist the Saxons - as Ambrosius and Arthur had done - if that had been their united goal. But the stresses already implied in the fall of Arthur - the competition between the rich and mighty, and their own self-interest - fractured completely with Arthur's death and the rebellion of the Saxons.

Some of Arthur's generals did well for themselves and held on to their territory - Dyfnwal and his descendants held the border against all comers - English and highland Scots - for another 500 years. Cunedda held central Wales down to the time of Edward I. And Theoderic and his descendants successfully held off the advance of the English at the border of Cornwall.

But across the rest of the island, the Saxons, Angles and Jutes - combined as the English - managed to push back the boundaries of the British kings and picked them off one by one, until they had control of the entire island - just in time to be attacked by the next influx of seaborne raiders, the Vikings.

But that would be another story.

Author's Note

I was first inspired to write about Arthur when I read the notes to Robert Graves' "Count Belisarius". He makes the point that our relative confusion about the events of Arthur's time come down to a lack of good source material, especially compared to that of the time of Justinian and Belisarius.

It's hard to know if this is because nobody wrote that history, or if it simply did not survive the sacking of Britain in the sixth century. Obviously, at this point it is not possible to recover the original, true story of Arthur. However, by working only from the earliest sources (before Geoffrey of Monmouth) and by constructing a story in parallel with that of Belisarius and what we know the Romans were capable of, I have attempted to reconstruct something that could have happened, unlike the traditional tales which cast Arthur very much as a mediaeval knight descended from the Anglo-Saxon tradition.

Which obviously he was not: there can be very little doubt that Arthur was a Roman. If he existed at all, and fought for the Britons against the Saxons, then he was a fifth-century Briton and that century started with Britain still a part of the "whole" Roman Empire, a status it lost when the Emperor Honorius washed his hands of defending it around 410. If we assume that Arthur was born sometime in the middle of the century – I have assumed 452 – then his parents could easily (per Gildas' description of Ambrosius' family) have been "wearers of the purple" who died battling the Saxons. The only plausible interpretation of "wearers of the purple" would be at least the rank of Roman Knights, which would have plausibly carried with it the command of auxiliary regiments of infantry or cavalry. While these would probably have disbanded over the course of time, it is not implausible that between this history, Arthur's upbringing, and his possible access to Roman Literature (I have him at least having access to all the works extant today, but probably many others, especially those known to have existed in antiquity but lost today), Arthur could have been "the second coming of Caesar to Britain", one of the rare men who combined an instinctive understanding of war with the arts of democracy and a longing for peace.

In so doing he could have moved from a small-scale operator as a warlord (initially commanding 50-100 like-minded warriors) to a full-scale army general, leading the British forces at the battle of Mons Badonicus.

There is no need or reason to assume that he took at any time the title of "King" or "Emperor". It is reasonable to assume that there was a strong central government, and there may have been an emperor, and it may even have been Arthur - but I have chosen to assume a more Republican form of government, which feels closer to the context described in the sources before the rise of Vortigern.

In the peace that followed the battle at Badonicus, both the need for an army and the prohibitive cost of keeping one no doubt would have contributed to its demise. In this time, Arthur would doubtless have stepped back from public life. The fact that he died at the battle of Camlann suggests that he was still involved in some role.

While trying to remain as faithful to the "true" story as possible, I have tried to acknowledge the other traditions and point at incidents that, had they happened and been remembered, could have been later misunderstood in such a way as to give rise to the tradition. On the other hand, I think it is much more likely that later authors added to the tale exactly what they wanted to add to the tale without any thoughts for its accuracy. These traditions include, of course, the historically inaccurate "Monty Python and the Holy Grail" whose "Brave Sir Robin" inspired the Bryn story in Chapter 8.